
MERCY OF LIGHT

*The Life of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ Woven with the Quran and the Sound
Hadith*

An Integrated Sira in Nine Books

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A Humble Servant · Fellow Witness

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AUTHOR'S PROLOGUE

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim. Alhamdulillah.

I must first say what this book is, how it was made, and the discipline that holds it together.

This is a life of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in nine books. It sets out to occupy ground that most such lives leave empty. The literature has long divided into two estranged camps. On one side stands the devotional Sira. It narrates with love, yet it often leaves its sources unweighed. It also seals the Arabian story off from the world that story actually inhabited. On the other side stand the academic and the polemical. They place the sources within history, but they handle them with suspicion, and at times with hostility. This work keeps the reverence of the first camp and the apparatus of the second. It surrenders neither. It is the book of a believer who is also a historian and an archaeologist. It situates the Prophet ﷺ within late antiquity. There stood the two empires, bled white by three centuries of war. There was the Plague of Justinian, and the year the sun dimmed within living memory. There were the southern kingdoms of Himyar and Aksum, and the massacre at Najran. There were the client courts of Ghassan and Hira, the Syriac Christian milieu, and the formulas cut into stone. Here the providential reading and the material record are not rivals. The geopolitics is the stage on which the divine plan worked. It is not a substitute for that plan.

This book did not begin on a blank page. Beneath the narrative lies a long labor of reconstruction. It is a data-anchored registry of the witnessed Sira, built across more than twenty volumes. It runs along a chronological spine of thirty-one episodes, with twenty-five deep dossiers lettered A through Y. This is not a compilation of theology. It is a compilation of direct transcripts, of what the Companions saw and heard and reported at particular moments. Behind it stood a search space of more than sixty-seven thousand narrations. These were drawn from the nine canonical collections, from Bukhārī and Muslim through the Musnad of Aḥmad, together with the early Sira and Maghāzī of Ibn Ishāq, al-Ṭabarī, and Ibn Sa'd. Once repetition is set aside, some fifteen thousand of them are distinct. From these, a few hundred verified reports were distilled as load-bearing testimony. Only about a hundred surface by name in the pages that follow. They are paraphrased rather than quoted, and cited by collection rather than by number. The two Ṣaḥīḥ books carry the weight. On the Qur'anic side, the whole recited Book stood open. It holds six thousand two hundred and thirty-six verses. Roughly fourteen hundred of them bear on the history. From these the narrative draws on five hundred and eighty-two distinct verses, spread across eighty-nine of the hundred and fourteen suras. Some four hundred and seventy of them are rendered directly into my own words. Each was prepared from the Arabic, and none was lifted from a published translation. The foundation is an ocean. The citation is a cupped handful. Both are deliberate.

The great biographies of the tradition run to many volumes, to ten thousand pages and more. They are treasuries. Yet they are built for the specialist. They ask of the reader something near a lifetime, to study their detail and to hold their intricacy. This book attempts a harder and humbler thing. It tries to keep the substance of those vast works, their evidence, their care, their fidelity. It tries to crystallize that substance into a single volume a sincere reader can finish, grounded at every step in the Qur'an and the sound hadith. The scholar should find nothing falsified in it. The ordinary reader should not be shut out, the reader who simply wishes to know the Prophet ﷺ as truly and as fully as a short book can allow. To be at once as accurate as possible, as comprehensive as possible, and as brief as possible is a difficult aim. It may even be an impossible

one. It is nonetheless the aim the author set himself and labored to deliver. Whether he has succeeded is not for him to declare. That judgment belongs to Allah ﷻ, and after Him to the readers who come.

The work stands on two anchors. It admits no third as load-bearing. The first is the Qur'an. It is the one source that does not err, and the measure against which every other is weighed. The second is the sound hadith, the mass-transmitted and the rigorously authenticated, drawn chiefly from the two Ṣaḥīḥ collections. Beneath these stand the biographical reports. They are taken seriously as narrative, but they are weighed by their chains rather than swallowed whole. Where a report is uncertain, it is named as such. Where a chain is weak, it is not leaned upon. Nothing has been invented. No narration has been manufactured. No chain has been forged to close a gap. The voice is reverent and the eye is neutral. Where the tradition is contested, the contest is named rather than smoothed away.

One book keeps a stricter rule than the rest. It is the heart from which the whole volume takes its measure. The ninth book is the study of the prophetic portrait and the Seal. It takes its evidence from the Qur'an alone and sets the transmitted reports aside. The reason lies in its question. It asks how the recited Word itself names and addresses the Prophet ﷺ. That question can be answered from the Word and from nothing else. It is read by the Word's own usage and excavated at the level of its own roots. The Qur'an speaks of him in two registers at once. It raises him to the limit of created honor. In the same breath it binds him as a mortal who will die, who holds no key to the unseen, who is reproved within his own household, and who is commanded to seek forgiveness. The devotional treatment tends to harmonize the humbling verses away. The polemical treatment seizes those same verses as a weapon. This book does neither. It holds both registers together and softens neither. It reads the accountability not as a weight against the dignity, but as the very mechanism of it. The model is the Qur'an's own account of Adam. There the honor is granted not for an impeccability the angels already hold, but for the capacity to err, to recognize the error, and to turn back. So the command to seek forgiveness arrives not in defeat, but at the summit of victory. The contested episodes are set in their place. They are named where tradition assigns them, without being claimed as event. The Seal itself is read at its root, as the signet that certifies and completes. It closes the office of revelation while it leaves open the road of the servant. The portrait is not a smaller Prophet. It is a nearer one.

What follows is offered as a faithful and careful telling. It is anchored in the Word and the sound report. It is watchful of the world, reverent without flattery, and honest without irreverence. Its errors are mine alone. Its truth is borrowed. And the road it traces was never closed.

A Humble Servant · Fellow Witness

I • THE CRUCIBLE

The world into which he was born was not at peace, and it was not waiting. Two empires had spent three centuries learning how to bleed each other. A plague had thinned the cities. The sun itself had failed for a season within living memory. In the south a monotheist kingdom had risen and burned its dissenters in a pit. In the deserts between the giants, a tribe of traders kept an ancient House and fed it three hundred and sixty idols. Yet the recitation that was coming would speak of all of it. It would name the Romans and their defeat, the burners and their fire, the elephant and the House, the buried daughters and the broken sanctuary, as though it had been watching the whole time. This is the ground. Before the dawn there was the long night, and a Book that already knew the night by name.

The Two Exhausted Giants

For as long as anyone alive in the sixth century could remember, the inhabited earth that mattered to them had two masters. To the west and north stood the Eastern Roman Empire. It was Greek in speech and Christian in creed, and it ruled from Constantinople over Anatolia, the Levant, Egypt, and the rim of the Mediterranean. To the east stood the Sasanian Empire of Persia. It was Zoroastrian in its state cult, and it ruled from Ctesiphon on the Tigris over Mesopotamia, the Iranian plateau, and the approaches to India. Between them ran a frontier soaked in repetition. Edessa, Nisibis, Dara, Amida. The same fortress towns changed hands, were besieged, ransomed, and lost again, across generation after generation. Each empire called itself the center of the world. Each treated the other as the only rival worth the name. Neither imagined that the decisive blow would come from the gap between them, from the one peninsula neither had bothered to swallow.

The duel reached its furnace in the early seventh century. In the year 602 the Roman emperor Maurice was overthrown and killed, with his sons, by a usurper named Phocas. Khosrow the Second was the Persian king of kings, and Maurice had once helped restore him to his own throne. He now seized the murder as both grievance and opportunity. What followed was not another border raid. It was the deepest Persian penetration of Roman territory in the history of the two states. Persian armies took Antioch, the great city of Syria. They took Damascus. In 614 they took Jerusalem, sacked it, killed many, and carried the relic of the True Cross back to Ctesiphon as a trophy. For Christendom this was a wound to the spirit as much as to the body. The holiest city in Roman hands had fallen to fire-worshippers, and the Cross itself was in captivity. By 619 the Persians held Egypt, the granary on which Constantinople fed. Their cavalry reached the Bosphorus and looked across the water at the Roman capital. In 626 a combined host laid siege to Constantinople itself, the Persians on the Asian shore and the Avars with their Slavic levies assaulting the land walls. The city held. Its defenders credited the Mother of God. Its survival was the hinge.

The Roman recovery, when it came, was the work of one stubborn man. Heraclius had taken the throne from Phocas in 610. At one low point he had even considered abandoning the capital and ruling from Carthage in the African west. Instead, from 622, he did the thing no one expected. He left the defensive crouch and campaigned offensively into the Persian heartland. He wintered in hostile country, drew on the treasure of the Church, and made alliance with the Western Turks of the steppe against the shared enemy. In 627 he met the main Persian field army near the ruins of Nineveh and broke it. Within months Khosrow was deposed and killed by his own son. The exhausted Persians sued for terms. The Cross was carried back to Jerusalem in 630, and Heraclius walked it through the gate. The Romans had won. They had won the way a

man wins a knife fight in which both parties are stabbed many times. The treasuries of both empires were empty. The frontier provinces were depopulated and embittered. The armies were spent. The administrative machinery of Syria, Mesopotamia, and Egypt had been wrenched back and forth between two tax regimes, until the populations were exhausted of loyalty to either.

Into the middle of this came a passage of revelation that the believers of Mecca would carry as a sign. The Persians were still ascendant and the Romans still reeling. The opening verses of the chapter named for the Romans declare a defeat, and then, against the visible run of events, they promise its reversal. *Alif Lām Mīm. The Romans have been defeated, in the nearest land, and they, after their defeat, will be victorious, within a few years. To God belongs the command, before and after. And on that day the believers will rejoice, in the help of God. He helps whom He wills, and He is the Mighty, the Merciful. The promise of God. God does not break His promise, but most people do not know* (al-Rūm 30:1-6). The prophecy was made when Persia looked invincible and Rome looked finished. The reversal at Nineveh fulfilled it within the span the words allowed, for the term rendered "a few years" is in the Arabic a number between three and nine. Two details in the wording reward attention. They sit at the level of the text rather than of any later commentary. The phrase "the nearest land" can carry in the Arabic a second sense, "the lowest land." The theatre of the early Roman defeats was the rift of the Jordan and the basin of the Dead Sea, which is in literal fact the lowest exposed land on the surface of the earth. The second detail is that the rejoicing of the believers is tied to the same day as the Roman victory, two distant reversals bound into a single appointed moment.

The believers of Mecca treated the prophecy as exactly what it was, a public claim that could be proved false. The traditionists transmit a report carried by al-Tirmidhī and others and judged sound by a number of them. In it, Abū Bakr, the closest of the Prophet's companions, took the verse at its word. He wagered against the Meccan idolater Ubayy ibn Khalaf that Rome would defeat Persia within the term. When the news of the Roman victory came, the wager was won, and the Muslims rejoiced, as the verse had said they would, on the day of the help of God. A scripture had named an outcome before the world delivered it. A man had staked property on the naming. The world had paid out. For the believer this is the point. For the historian it is a datum to be typed honestly. The chapter was recited in Mecca before the outcome was known. The outcome matched. What a reader does with that depends on the register in which the reader is standing.

Plague, Cold, and the Thinning of the World

The empires did not exhaust only themselves. For a century before Heraclius they had been worked on by forces no king commanded. In the year 541 a pestilence erupted at Pelusium on the Egyptian coast and spread along the sea lanes with terrible speed. By 542 it had reached Constantinople, where the historian Procopius watched it kill, by his account, in numbers the city could not bury. This was the first of the great bubonic pandemics. It was later called the Justinianic Plague, after the emperor on whose watch it struck. Recent recovery of ancient genetic material has confirmed the pathogen beyond dispute. It was *Yersinia pestis*, the same organism that would return as the medieval Black Death. What remains genuinely contested is the scale, and it should be stated as contested rather than asserted. The older histories spoke of twenty-five to fifty million dead, and of a demographic catastrophe that gutted the late Roman world. A more recent and skeptical line of scholarship has pressed hard on the thinness of the evidence for mortality on that maximal scale. It argues that the textual reports are concentrated, rhetorical, and hard to convert into population figures, and that the archaeological and documentary traces of total collapse are weaker than the dramatic narratives imply. The confirmed fact is the disease. The magnitude is an open question. A reader who wants

the truth here should hold the pathogen as established and the body count as estimated. He should distrust any source, ancient or modern, that converts a chronicler's horror into a precise percentage of the dead.

The man who was coming would, in time, give his people a teaching about exactly this kind of killing. It is worth setting that teaching here, beside the pestilence that prepared his world, for it shows the distance between the order he would bring and the order he found. The sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim preserve his instruction on the plague in words of startling practical clarity. When you hear that it has fallen upon a land, he taught, do not go into it. And if it falls upon a land where you already are, do not flee from it. The principle of containment is to hold the sick and the well apart by refusing both entry and flight. It is stated plainly more than a thousand years before the germ was named. He taught further, in Bukhārī, that the plague was a punishment sent upon those before them, and a mercy for the believer. So no one remains patient in a plague-stricken land, expecting reward and knowing that nothing will strike him but what God has decreed, except that he has the reward of a martyr. The world of 541 met the plague with terror and flight and the emptying of cities. The teaching that was on its way met it with quarantine and patience and the reckoning of the soul. The contrast is the measure of the dawn against the dark.

What the plague began, the sky continued. In the year 536 something dimmed the sun. Across the Mediterranean and beyond, witnesses recorded a veil over the light that lasted the better part of a year and more. Procopius wrote that the sun gave its light without brightness, like the moon, through that whole year. A Roman official in Italy described a summer without heat, crops that would not ripen, and a blue sun. In far Mesopotamia and in China the same strange dimming was noticed. The cause was recovered only in our own time, from the cores of polar ice and the rings of ancient trees, and it was volcanic. One or more colossal eruptions, an Icelandic event around 536 and a second great eruption around 540, loaded the high atmosphere with sulfate and ash and shut down a portion of the sun's warmth for years. Tree rings show some of the coldest summers of the last two thousand years clustered in exactly this window. Scholars now speak of a Late Antique Little Ice Age, running from roughly 536 into the middle of the seventh century. It was a sustained downturn in temperature, laid across the same decades as the plague and the wars. One historian called 536 the worst year in which to be alive. The chain is not hard to read. Cold shortens harvests. Hunger weakens bodies. Weakened bodies feed pestilence. Pestilence empties the tax rolls and the army musters. Empty musters lose wars. The material world had been preparing the ground for a century. It dimmed the light, thinned the people, and hollowed the two great powers from beneath, while their kings imagined the only danger was each other.

The Fire in the South

The peninsula was not all desert and idol. Its southern corner is the well-watered highlands and wadis of what is now Yemen, and it had carried high civilization for more than a thousand years before the sixth century. The old kingdoms of Saba, of Qataban, of Hadramawt, and of Ma'in had grown rich on the incense trade and on a system of dams and channels that turned monsoon runoff into terraced agriculture. The Quran itself remembers Saba and its gardens. It remembers their ruin when they turned away, the bursting of the dam and the gardens of sweet fruit changed into bitter scrub. *There was for Saba, in their dwelling place, a sign, two gardens, on the right and on the left. Eat from the provision of your Lord and be thankful to Him, a good land and a forgiving Lord. But they turned away, so We sent upon them the flood of the dam, and We exchanged their two gardens for two gardens producing bitter fruit and tamarisk and a little of the lote tree* (Saba' 34:15-16). The greatest of these waterworks was the dam at Marib, among the engineering marvels of the

ancient world. Its breaking entered the scripture as a parable of ingratitude before it entered the history books as a fact of hydrology. By the sixth century these older states had been gathered under the kingdom of Ḥimyar. And Ḥimyar, in the centuries before Islam, did something that should arrest any reader who thinks monotheism arrived in Arabia only with the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. It abandoned its old pantheon and turned to the One God.

The evidence is not later legend. It is carved in stone, in the inscriptions the Ḥimyarite kings and nobles left in their own Sabaic script. From the late fourth century the dedications stop naming the old astral deities. They begin to invoke, instead, "Raḥmānān," the Merciful, and the "Lord of the Heavens," and the "Lord of the heaven and the earth." The name halts the breath of anyone who knows the Quran. Raḥmānān is al-Raḥmān, the Merciful, the name with which nearly every chapter of the recitation opens, in the formula *in the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate*. It is also the name to which a whole chapter is dedicated, the chapter of the Merciful that begins *the Merciful taught the Quran, created man, taught him eloquence* (al-Raḥmān 55:1-4). Scholars debate the precise color of this Ḥimyarite monotheism. They ask whether it is best called Jewish, or a Judaizing royal cult, or a deliberately ecumenical monotheism designed to stand above the quarrels of Jews and Christians. The royal inscriptions lean strongly toward a Jewish-influenced worship of a single transcendent God. What is not in doubt is the bare fact. Two centuries before the Hijra, the kings of South Arabia were addressing the Merciful as the Lord of heaven and earth, in writing, on the walls of their tombs and temples. The monotheist hunger that the Quran would later name as the buried religion of Abraham (AS) was not a foreign import into the peninsula. In the south it had already taken a throne.

It also drew blood. In the early sixth century a Ḥimyarite king of the Jewish faith moved against the Christians within and at the borders of his realm. He is known in the Arabic sources as Dhū Nuwās and in his own inscriptions by the throne name Yūsuf. The geopolitics behind this were real. Across the narrow sea lay the Christian kingdom of Aksum in Ethiopia, allied to Christian Rome and pressing into Arabian affairs. For a Ḥimyarite king, to resist Aksumite and Roman encroachment was to resist their co-religionists at home. Around the year 523 his campaign reached the oasis city of Najrān in the north of Yemen, a flourishing Christian community. The city was taken. Those who would not renounce their faith were killed, many by fire, in numbers the sources count in the thousands. Their leader, remembered as al-Ḥārith in Arabic and Arethas in Greek, was martyred with them. This atrocity is among the best-attested events of pre-Islamic Arabia. It is recorded in a Syriac letter by a contemporary churchman, in a martyrology, and in the Greek hagiographic tradition. It is corroborated in its broad outline by the Ḥimyarite inscriptions of the campaign themselves. It is one of the rare moments where the stones and the chronicles and the later memory converge.

The Quran preserves what looks very much like the memory of these martyrs. It preserves it not as a footnote but as a warning carved in moral fire. In the chapter named for the constellations, the recitation swears its oath and then curses those who burned the faithful in a pit. *By the sky of the constellations, and the promised day, and the witness and the witnessed. Slain were the companions of the trench, the fire well stocked with fuel, when they sat over it, and were themselves witnesses to what they did to the believers. They took vengeance on them for nothing except that they believed in God, the Mighty, the Praiseworthy, to whom belongs the dominion of the heavens and the earth, and God is witness over all things* (al-Burūj 85:1-9). The Arabic word for the trench is al-ukhdūd, the dug pit. The image is precise, a fire fed in a ditch and the persecutors seated around its rim to watch. The strongest historical candidate for the event behind these verses is the Najrān massacre of around 523, the burning of Christians who would not abandon the One God.

The Prophet ﷺ himself would later give his community the fuller story behind such a fire. It comes in one of the longest single narratives in the sound collection of Muslim, the account men have called the story of the boy and the king. He told of a tyrant king and a sorcerer. He told of a boy who learned the truth of the One God from a hidden monk, and who began to heal the blind and the leprous by the name of God, declaring that he healed nothing and that God alone was the healer. The king could not kill the boy by any means while the boy committed his death to God. At last the boy himself instructed him in the one way it could be done. When it was done, the people declared their faith in the Lord of the boy. The king was enraged that the very thing he feared had come to pass. He commanded trenches to be dug at the mouths of the roads and fires kindled in them, and he ordered that whoever would not turn from the faith be cast into the fire. The believers went into the flames. The narrative closes on a mother hesitating with her infant at the edge of the pit, and the infant given speech to steady her, be patient, mother, for you are upon the truth. The chapter of the constellations and the narration of the Messenger ﷺ are two witnesses to the same pattern. The powerful burn the faithful for nothing but their faith, and the faithful walk into the fire rather than deny the One to whom belongs the dominion of the heavens and the earth. The historian may identify the likely occasion in the Najrān of 523. The Prophet ﷺ cast it as the eternal shape of the trial. Both readings stand without crowding each other.

The retaliation came from across the water. The Christian king of Aksum, Kaleb, remembered also as Ella Asbeha, invaded Ḥimyar around 525 with Roman naval help. He defeated and destroyed Dhū Nuwās and installed Christian rule over the south. Out of the Aksumite occupation rose the man whose name the Arabian memory would not forget. Abraha was a general of the Ethiopian army who took power in Ḥimyar. In time he shook off the control of his Aksumite overlords and ruled as a Christian king of South Arabia in his own right. He governed from a position of recognized strength, and here again the stones speak for themselves rather than through legend. Abraha repaired the great dam at Marib. The long inscription he left to commemorate the work is datable to around the year 548, and it records not only the engineering but a gathering of envoys at his court. There were delegations from Rome, from Persia, from the Aksumite king, and from the Arab client kingdoms of the Ghassanids and the Lakhmids. The picture is of a southern monarch treated as a peer by the powers of the age. A second inscription, cut at a place called Murayghan and dated to around 552, records a military expedition Abraha led northward into central Arabia against the Arab tribal confederation of Ma'add, his forces reaching deep into the peninsula. In his capital at Sanaa, Abraha built a great church remembered in the Arabic sources as al-Qalīs. It was a structure splendid enough that tradition holds he intended it to draw the pilgrimage of the Arabs away from the ancient House at Mecca and toward his new cathedral in the south.

The Elephant and the House

It is from this Abraha that the Arabian memory dates its world. Tradition holds that the Christian king of the south, in the ambition that built his cathedral, marched at last upon Mecca itself to destroy the Ka'ba, the rival sanctuary that held the loyalty of the Arabs. His army, the sources say, included an elephant, a beast the Arabs of the Hijaz had never seen in war, and the campaign and the year took their name from it. The Year of the Elephant. The biographers carry the scene that the later tradition loved, foremost among them Ibn Ishāq in the recension of Ibn Hishām. It must be received at the weight of its genre, a biographical narration rather than a verse or a chain of the first rank. Even so, it is the moment that brings the grandfather of the Prophet ﷺ onto the stage. As Abraha's army neared Mecca it seized the camels of the valley, among them two

hundred belonging to ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib, the lord of Quraysh and keeper of the House. ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib went to the king to ask for his camels back. Abraha was astonished. He said he had expected the man to plead for the sanctuary his army had come to destroy, not for his livestock. The grandfather’s answer became a proverb of trust. I am the lord of the camels, he said, and the House has a Lord who will protect it. Then he returned to Mecca, took hold of the door of the Ka’ba, and prayed that God defend His own House. He withdrew with the people to the hills to watch what their Lord would do.

The Quran devotes a short and thunderous chapter to what He did. *Have you not seen how your Lord dealt with the companions of the elephant. Did He not turn their scheme into error, and send against them birds in flocks, pelting them with stones of baked clay, and make them like eaten chaff* (al-Fil 105). The army that came to pull down the House was itself pulled down. It was struck by a calamity the recitation renders as a storm of stones from the sky, and a host left like the chewed husks of grain after the seed is gone. The sanctuary stood. Its God had defended it. And the event was no mere legend of the genre, for the Prophet ﷺ would invoke it himself, decades later, in a moment recorded in the sound collection of Bukhārī. On the day his she-camel Qaṣwā’ knelt at the edge of the sanctuary at Ḥudaybiyya and would not rise, the people said she had grown stubborn. He answered that she had not grown stubborn and that it was not in her nature, but that she had been restrained by the One who restrained the elephant from Mecca. In his own mouth, at the threshold of the same sacred ground, the defense of the House against the elephant stood as a remembered act of God, set beside the restraining of his own mount at the gate of the truce.

Here the honest historian must lay one tension on the table, and reverence does not require hiding it. Abraha’s securely datable activity is the dam inscription of around 548 and the northern campaign recorded at Murayghan around 552. This sits roughly two decades before the year 570, to which the later Islamic tradition fixes both the Elephant and the birth of the Prophet ﷺ. The stones place Abraha’s power and his reach into the north in the late 540s and early 550s. The traditional chronology places his march on Mecca around 570. There are several honest ways to hold this. The expedition against the Ka’ba may have been a distinct campaign, later than the inscriptions that survive and therefore undated by them. The traditional synchronization of the Elephant with the birth may be a retrospective alignment, the naming of an epoch by a famous catastrophe, with the precise calendar tie fixed by memory generations afterward. The Prophet’s birth may fall somewhat earlier than the round number 570 that tradition settled upon. What is not in tension, and what carries the weight, is the event itself and its meaning. The Quran affirms the calamity of the Elephant and the divine protection of the House, and the Prophet ﷺ affirmed it as God’s act in a report of the first rank. The remembered year, named for the beast, served the Arabs as a fixed point in time. The naming and the protection are the secure ground. The exact mapping onto the modern calendar is a reconstruction, and it is held with the openness a reconstruction deserves. The container, a remembered year and a sanctuary saved, stands firm. The content, the precise date and its synchronization with the birth, remains a matter of careful and honest estimate. To insist on more certainty than the evidence carries would weaken, not strengthen, the foundation.

The two short chapters that the tradition reads as a pair make the consequence plain, and they should be read together as the Arabs read them. The destruction of the elephant army preserved the security of the sanctuary, and the security of the sanctuary was the whole basis of the life of the tribe that kept it. The chapter that follows the Elephant turns at once to that tribe. *For the accustoming of Quraysh, their accustoming to the journey of winter and summer, so let them worship the Lord of this House, who fed them against hunger and secured them against fear* (Quraysh 106). The God who broke the elephant is the God who fed Quraysh and made them safe. The only fitting return is worship of Him alone, and not of the idols crowded

into His House. The argument is already there, in the oldest layer of the recitation, before the Prophet ﷺ had spoken a word of it in public. The sanctuary that was saved would become the sanctuary that was cleansed.

The Sanctuary and the Trade

Mecca had nothing. This must be grasped plainly, because the later glory casts a false light backward. The valley held no river, no spring fit for agriculture, no field. The Quran preserves the prayer it attributes to Abraham (AS) at the founding of the place, and the prayer names the barrenness exactly. *Our Lord, I have settled some of my offspring in a valley without cultivation, by Your sacred House, our Lord, that they may establish the prayer. So make the hearts of people incline toward them, and provide them with fruits, that they may be thankful* (Ibrāhīm 14:37). Everything Mecca was, it was because of two things that occupied the same small ground. The first was the House, the Ka'ba, the cube of stone that the Quran identifies as the most ancient sanctuary raised for the worship of God, built up by Abraham (AS) and his son Ishmael (AS). The recitation sets the scene of its raising and the covenant that came with it. *And when We made the House a place of return for the people, and a sanctuary, and they took the station of Abraham as a place of prayer, and We charged Abraham and Ishmael, purify My House for those who circle it and those who seclude themselves in it and those who bow and prostrate. And when Abraham said, my Lord, make this a secure land, and provide its people with fruits, whoever of them believes in God and the Last Day* (al-Baqara 2:125-126). The second thing was the well of Zamzam, the water that made human life in the valley possible at all. The tradition traces the spring to the infant Ishmael (AS) and his mother Hagar in the same desolate valley, and the running between the two hills of Ṣafā and Marwa that the Quran later confirms among the rites of God, *indeed Ṣafā and Marwa are among the symbols of God* (al-Baqara 2:158).

Around the House lay the ḥaram, the sacred precinct within which the shedding of blood was forbidden. That prohibition was the engine of everything. A zone where no man could lawfully strike another, in a land governed by the blood feud, was a zone where strangers could meet, trade, and disperse in safety. The Quran would later name this security as a deliberate mercy and a sign. It contrasts the safety of the sanctuary with the violence of the lands around it. *Have they not seen that We made a secure sanctuary while people are snatched away all around them* (al-Ankabūt 29:67). The sanctuary made the market. The market made the town. And the town, for all its barrenness, the Quran would honor with a title above other settlements, the Mother of Cities, *that you may warn the Mother of Cities and those around it* (al-An'ām 6:92, and again al-Shūrā 42:7).

The keepers of this arrangement were the Quraysh. They were the tribe that had gathered control of the sanctuary and its offices under an ancestor named Qusayy ibn Kilāb, some generations before the Prophet ﷺ. Qusayy had consolidated the functions that mattered, and they remained the currency of Meccan prestige. There was the provision of water to the pilgrims, the siqāya, and the feeding of them, the rifāda, both expensive duties of honor. There was the keybearing of the Ka'ba itself, the right to open and close and tend the House. There was the war banner, the liwā', raised when the tribe took the field. And there was the council house, the dār al-nadwa, where the leading men deliberated. To hold one of these was to be a man of standing. The competition for them ran through the clans of Quraysh, and it would shape, in time, the resistance the Prophet ﷺ met from his own kin. For the message that there was no god but God struck at the value of the offices that managed the gods.

The wealth of Quraysh moved along the two roads the Quran names, the journey of winter and the journey of summer. The winter caravan went south to Yemen and the Indian Ocean trade. The summer caravan went north to Syria and the Roman markets. Mecca sat on the spine of the western Arabian route, a waystation

and a clearing house between the south and the Mediterranean. Here too the honest reader should resist the most romantic version of the story. An older scholarship pictured Mecca as a great emporium of the international luxury trade, its merchants grown fat on frankincense and silk and pepper bound for Rome. A sharp and influential challenge to that picture argued that the long-distance incense trade had largely declined by the sixth century, and that Meccan commerce was a humbler affair of leather, hides, raisins, and the goods of the peninsula itself, more local than imperial. The debate is not fully settled, and a careful account does not need it to be. What is secure beneath the argument is this. Quraysh were traders. Their trade required safe passage. Their safe passage rested on the prestige of the sanctuary they kept, and on the network of agreements and sacred truces that prestige bought. Whether their cargo was imperial luxury or peninsular staple, their security was sacred in its source, and a man who threatened the sacred threatened the trade.

Around the sanctuary and along the roads ran a calendar of truce and a season of words. Four months of the year were sacred, months in which fighting was forbidden across much of Arabia. It was a custom the Quran would later affirm and fix into the divine order of time itself. *The number of months with God is twelve, in the Book of God from the day He created the heavens and the earth, of which four are sacred. That is the upright religion, so do not wrong yourselves during them* (al-Tawba 9:36). In and around these months the great fairs convened, at ‘Ukāz and Majannah and Dhū al-Majāz, where commerce and tribal diplomacy and the recitation of poetry all happened in the same charged air. For the Arabs, poetry was not ornament. It was the supreme art and the chief glory of the tongue, the medium of honor and insult, memory and law. The most celebrated odes were said to be hung in honor, the mu‘allaqāt, the suspended poems. This was a civilization that judged greatness by the mastery of the Arabic word above almost any other measure. It matters enormously for what came next. Into a people who prized eloquence above gold, who could tell the work of a master poet from the work of a journeyman in a single line, there would be recited a book that staked its truth on the challenge to produce its like. The Quran would set the challenge in the plainest terms. *Say, if mankind and the jinn gathered together to produce the like of this Quran, they could not produce its like, even if they backed one another* (al-Isrā’ 17:88). And again, lowering the bar to a single chapter, *then bring a chapter like it, and call your witnesses besides God, if you are truthful* (al-Baqara 2:23). The miracle the Arabs were equipped to recognize was a verbal one. The ground had been prepared for it for centuries, fair by fair and ode by ode.

The Gods and the Seekers

The House that Abraham (AS) was said to have raised for the One God had, by the sixth century, become a crowd. The sound report of Ibn Mas‘ūd, carried by Bukhārī and Muslim, fixes the number. He described the Prophet ﷺ on the day Mecca was opened, entering upon the House with three hundred and sixty idols set around it, and striking them down one by one with a stick in his hand while reciting *truth has come and falsehood has vanished, indeed falsehood is ever bound to vanish* (al-Isrā’ 17:81). That scene belongs to a later Book, to the day of the cleansing. But the number it reports is the measure of the valley into which the Prophet ﷺ was born. Three hundred and sixty images were heaped upon the sanctuary of the One, one cult upon another across the generations. Chief among them stood Hubal, a great image associated with divination by the casting of arrows, consulted on matters of weight. Around the wider Hijaz were venerated three goddesses whom the Arabs called the daughters of God, al-Lāt of Ṭā’if, al-‘Uzzā of the valley of Nakhla, and Manāt of the coast at Qudayd. The Quran would name these three directly and strip them of their pretension. *Have you considered al-Lāt and al-‘Uzzā, and Manāt, the third, the other. Is the male for you and for Him the*

female. That, then, would be an unjust division. They are nothing but names you have named, you and your fathers, for which God has sent down no authority (al-Najm 53:19-23).

It is in the orbit of this same chapter that a much-discussed and much-disputed report sits, the so-called incident of the high cranes. In it the Prophet ﷺ is alleged to have momentarily uttered words of praise for the three goddesses before the verse was corrected. Reverence and honest source-criticism arrive here at the same verdict, which is rare and worth noting. The report's chains of transmission are judged defective by the weight of the ḥadīth critics, its lines broken or weak. Its narrative ill-fits both the surrounding text and the unbroken character of the mission. It survives in the conversation of the sources, and a complete account acknowledges that it was discussed, but its warrant is unsound, and nothing of substance rests on it. The text of the chapter stands without it.

The religion of pre-Islamic Mecca was not simple atheism dressed in stone, and the Quran's own argument against it depends on this. Beneath the crowd of idols the Arabs retained a knowledge of a distant high God, Allah ﷻ, the creator, whom even the pagans acknowledged as the maker of heaven and earth. The Quran presses exactly this point against them more than once. *If you ask them who created the heavens and the earth, they will surely say, God (Luqmān 31:25, and the same admission at al-'Ankabūt 29:61 and al-Zumar 39:38).* The idolatry was not the denial of the creator but the insertion of intermediaries beneath Him. The Quran captures the worshippers' own theology of brokerage in their own reported words. *We do not worship them except that they may bring us nearer to God in nearness (al-Zumar 39:3), and they worship besides God that which neither harms them nor benefits them, and they say, these are our intercessors with God (Yūnus 10:18).* It was a religion of go-betweens. The goddesses and the images were held to carry the petition up to a creator grown too remote to address. The jinn and the astral powers and the soothsayers and the ancestral totems were layered over a God who had built the House and then been buried under His own tenants.

And it carried at least one custom the Quran would name with particular horror, the burying alive of infant daughters, the wa'd al-banāt. The recitation drags the act into the light of the final judgment with a question that needs no answer, *and when the girl buried alive is asked, for what sin she was killed (al-Takwīr 81:8-9).* And it exposes the shame that drove it, the contempt for a daughter's birth that could end in her murder. *And when one of them is given news of a female, his face darkens and he is filled with grief. He hides from the people because of the bad news he has been given, shall he keep her in humiliation or bury her in the dust. Evil indeed is what they decide (al-Naḥl 16:58-59).* A civilization that could bury a daughter in the sand and could not name the sin was a civilization with a wound at its center. The Book that was coming would reopen the wound on the day of reckoning, and ask the buried child herself to testify.

And yet within it stirred a hunger that the Quran would gather under a single word, the ḥanīf, the seeker of the pure original religion, the upright monotheist of the way of Abraham (AS) before Jew or Christian had drawn their boundaries. The recitation makes Abraham (AS) himself the pattern of it, a whole nation in one man. *Indeed Abraham was a nation, devoutly obedient to God, a ḥanīf, and he was not of the polytheists (al-Naḥl 16:120).* And it commands the Prophet ﷺ to that same way, *then We revealed to you, follow the religion of Abraham, the ḥanīf, and he was not of the polytheists (al-Naḥl 16:123).* Against the rival claims of the older faiths the Quran would plant Abraham (AS) before all of them. *They say, be Jews or Christians and you will be guided. Say, rather the religion of Abraham, the ḥanīf, and he was not of the polytheists (al-Baqara 2:135).* And it states the matter flatly, *Abraham was neither a Jew nor a Christian, but he was a ḥanīf, a Muslim, and he was not of the polytheists (Āl 'Imrān 3:67).*

These were not only verses. They were living men in the generation before the mission, individuals who on their own had recoiled from the idols and gone looking for the God of Abraham (AS). The memory of Mecca preserved their names, and the sound tradition preserved one of them in particular. Zayd ibn ‘Amr ibn Nufayl refused to eat the meat sacrificed to the idols, denounced the burying of daughters, and died still searching for the religion he believed had been lost, before the Prophet ﷺ began to recite. Bukhārī carries the report of an encounter in the days before the revelation. The young Muhammad ﷺ was offered a meal of meat that had been slaughtered for the idols, and Zayd, who was present, declined it as the Prophet ﷺ declined it, saying he would not eat of what was sacrificed to other than God. The tradition remembers the Prophet ﷺ speaking of Zayd afterward with honor, that he would be raised on the Day of Resurrection as a single nation by himself, a man who had found the way alone in the dark. Others walked the same road. Waraqa ibn Nawfal, a cousin of the woman who would become the Prophet's first wife, had gone over to the scriptural faith and studied the books of the earlier revelations, and he would have his moment of recognition at the very threshold of the mission. Quss ibn Sā'idah was remembered, in reports of weaker chain that the tradition nonetheless preserved, as an eloquent preacher of the One God and the coming reckoning, declaiming at the fair of ‘Ukāz, and the Prophet ﷺ is said to have recalled him. Their existence is the quiet proof that the moment was pregnant. The peninsula was not a flat field of contented paganism into which monotheism fell from outside. It was a field already cracking, with seekers pushing up through the surface in the dark, feeling for a dawn they were sure was near.

What the seekers were feeling for had a name in the recitation that was coming, and the name turns their searching inside out. The Quran teaches that the knowledge of the one God is not a thing reasoned into a person from outside, but a thing set in him at his making, the original disposition upon which God shaped mankind, the *fiṭra*. *So set your face toward the religion, inclining to truth, the nature of God upon which He created people. There is no changing the creation of God. That is the upright religion, but most people do not know* (al-Rūm 30:30). And it teaches that the disposition rests on something older still, a covenant taken from every soul before the world began, when God drew from the loins of the children of Adam their own witness against themselves. *And when your Lord took from the children of Adam, from their loins, their descendants, and made them testify of themselves, am I not your Lord. They said, yes, we have testified* (al-A'raf 7:172). Every soul, on this teaching, has already said yes, and comes into the world carrying the print of that answer beneath whatever later overlays it. The idols were the overlay. The distant high God the pagans still named as the maker of the heavens and the earth was the print showing through. And the seekers who could not rest among the images, who refused the meat of the altars and went out alone to feel for a dawn, were not inventing a new thing but recalling an old one, the buried yes stirring under the weight of three hundred and sixty gods. The prophet who was coming would bring them no foreign creed. He would call them back to what they had affirmed before they were born, and the recoil they felt from the idols was the covenant turning in its sleep.

The Scriptural Horizon

The Arabia of the sixth century was ringed and threaded by the great scriptural faiths, and no honest portrait of the world before Islam can leave them at the margin. The Jewish presence was old and substantial. The oasis of Yathrib, the town that would become Medina, held powerful Jewish tribes, the Banū Qaynuqā', the Banū al-Naḍīr, and the Banū Qurayza, custodians of scripture and law and trade in a settlement otherwise dominated by the Arab tribes of Aws and Khazraj. Jewish communities and Jewish influence reached across

the peninsula, and in the south, as the inscriptions of Ḥimyar attest, a form of Judaism had touched the throne itself. With this presence came a culture of the written word, of law and learning, and an expectation. The Quran speaks directly of that expectation and of the recognition it should have produced. It declares of the People of the Book that *those to whom We gave the Scripture recognize him as they recognize their own sons, but a party of them conceal the truth while they know it* (al-Baqara 2:146). The sources remember that the Jews of Yathrib spoke of a prophet who was to come, an expectation that primed the Arab tribes of the town to listen when a prophet did. The recitation frames that prophet as one already written in their own books, *the unlettered Prophet whom they find written with them in the Torah and the Gospel, enjoining upon them what is right and forbidding them what is wrong* (al-A'rāf 7:157).

The Christian presence was as real and far more divided. To the north, on the Syrian frontier, the Arab kingdom of the Ghassanids served Rome as a client and held to the Miaphysite confession. To the northeast, at al-Ḥīra on the edge of Mesopotamia, the rival Arab kingdom of the Lakhmids served Persia, and Christianity flourished there in the form the Roman world called Nestorian, the Church of the East. In the south stood the martyred and rebuilt Christianity of Najrān. Across the Red Sea lay Christian Aksum. And along the trade roads moved monks and hermits, the solitary holy men of the desert margins whose cells dotted the routes the caravans followed. It is to one of these that the tradition attaches a famous story, the monk remembered as Baḥīrā. He is said to have seen upon the young Muhammad ﷺ, traveling with a Meccan caravan into Syria, the marks of the prophet foretold in the scriptures, and to have warned his guardians to protect him. The report belongs to the biographical tradition rather than to the strongest registers of transmission, and a careful reader will type it as such, a *sīra* narrative carrying the flavor of its genre, not a verse and not a chain of the first rank. Held at that weight, it still testifies to something true about the world it describes, a Hijaz crossed by caravans into Christian Syria, watched by Christian eyes that knew the language of prophecy.

The Christianity that surrounded Arabia was not one thing but a battlefield of definitions, and this matters for what the Quran would later say. The central quarrel of Late Antique Christendom was over the nature of Christ, and it had fractured the faith into bitter and politically armed camps. The imperial orthodoxy of Constantinople, defined at the Council of Chalcedon, held that Christ existed in two natures, divine and human, united in one person. Against it stood the Miaphysites, the Copts of Egypt, the Syriac Orthodox, the Armenians, the Ethiopians, and the Ghassanid Arabs, who held that the incarnate Christ was of one united nature. Against both stood the Church of the East in Persia, called Nestorian by its enemies, which drew the distinction between the natures more sharply still. These were not seminar disputes. They were causes for which men were exiled, deposed, and killed, and they ran along the political fault lines of the age, a Miaphysite east and south chafing under a Chalcedonian capital. The Arab Christians lived inside this fracture, some on each side of it. When the Quran later addresses the Christians, its interventions land with precision into these live wounds. It honors Jesus (AS), son of Mary, in the highest terms while refusing him divinity. *The Messiah, Jesus son of Mary, was only a messenger of God, and His word which He conveyed to Mary, and a spirit from Him. So believe in God and His messengers, and do not say "three." Desist, it is better for you. God is but one God* (al-Nisā' 4:171). It rejects the proposition that God is the third of three, *they have certainly disbelieved who say that God is the third of three, while there is no god except one God* (al-Mā'idah 5:73). And it recoils from the attribution of a son to the Merciful with an image of cosmic rupture, for the very heavens shudder at the word. *They say the Merciful has taken a son. You have done a monstrous thing. The heavens almost rupture from it, and the earth splits open, and the mountains collapse in devastation, that they attribute to the Merciful a son. It is not fitting for the Merciful to take a son* (Maryam 19:88-92). The Quran

did not enter an empty room. It entered a room full of people already shouting at each other about exactly these questions, and it spoke into the argument as a voice claiming to settle it, naming the Merciful, the same Raḥmānān the Ḥimyarite stones had named, as the one God who neither begets nor is begotten.

The age bred not only the many gods of the pagans and the three persons disputed in the churches, but a third answer that ran through the Persian world and the teaching of Mani that had spread out of it. It was a cosmos split between two eternal powers, a god of light and a god of darkness, locked from before time in a war neither could win. Against the two, as against the three and the many, the recitation set its one word. There is no second power beside God, no dark god to balance the light, no rival will dividing the dominion. Even the evil from which a man seeks shelter is named in the recitation a thing created and held in His hand, not a god to be feared beside Him. *Say, I seek refuge in the Lord of daybreak, from the evil of what He created* (al-Falaq 113:1-2). The darkness is a created darkness. The evil is a permitted evil. The whole of it is under one dominion and not two. What the dualist split into warring gods, the recitation gathered back under the single Lord. The evil in the world it traced not to a second maker but to the turning of a will that had been made free, the refusal that fell from light by its own pride, not a power equal to God but a creature in rebellion against Him.

The age was also saturated with the apocalyptic and the legendary, with stories of saints and kings and the last days carried in Syriac and Greek and circulated far beyond their origins. One strand of this shared literary world reaches directly into the Quran, in a way that a sophisticated reader should meet head-on rather than avoid. Among the most widespread legends of Late Antiquity was the tale of Alexander the Great refashioned as a servant of God. He travels to the ends of the earth and builds a great barrier of iron and bronze across a mountain pass, to seal the savage peoples of Gog and Magog behind it until the end of time. A Syriac version of this legend circulated in the seventh century in the orbit of the wars of Heraclius. The Quran tells, in the chapter of the Cave, of a figure called Dhū al-Qarnayn, the Two-Horned One, a just and God-conscious traveler who journeys to the setting and the rising of the sun, and at last, between two mountains, builds a rampart against the corruption of Ya'jūj and Ma'jūj, Gog and Magog. The recitation gives him a creed of power held under God. *He said, this is a mercy from my Lord, but when the promise of my Lord comes, He will level it, and the promise of my Lord is true* (al-Kahf 18:98). The shared motifs are unmistakable, the world-traveler, the barrier, the iron and the molten metal, the apocalyptic peoples held back until the appointed hour. Scholarship has argued at length over the relationship, and the argument is genuinely unresolved. It is complicated by the difficulty of dating the Syriac legend precisely against the likely date of the revelation, and by the deeper roots of the barrier motif in older traditions reaching back to the Alexander romances and to Josephus. The reverent and the rigorous reading do not collide here if each keeps its register. That a common Late Antique story-world existed, in which a righteous king seals Gog and Magog behind an iron wall, is a matter of texts and dates open to study. The Quran tells its version with its own moral and eschatological weight, a ruler who claims no power but God's, who judges justly at the limits of the earth, and who points past his own great work to the day it will fall. What the comparison can establish is the existence of a shared horizon of motifs. What it cannot adjudicate, because the question lives in a different register, is the status and the source of the Quranic telling. The motif-world is the container, attestable and dateable. The metaphysical claim of the recitation is the content, and it is not decided by tracing the motif. A reader who confuses the two has mistaken the map for the ground.

Beneath these named faiths lay a wider scriptural atmosphere, a common store of sacred narrative that moved through the region in sermon and song and story. The patriarchs and prophets of the Bible, Adam and Noah (AS) and Abraham (AS) and Joseph (AS) and Moses (AS), and the figures of the Gospels, Mary and Jesus

(AS) and John (AS), lived in the oral and written culture of the Christian and Jewish communities and in the para-scriptural literature that surrounded the canon. The Quran moves through this same gallery of figures with complete familiarity, retelling and correcting and completing, addressing a population that already knew the names. And into this expectant scriptural world it places one specific prophecy that the tradition holds dearest, set in the mouth of Jesus (AS) himself, foretelling by name the one who would come after. *And when Jesus, son of Mary, said, O children of Israel, I am the messenger of God to you, confirming what came before me of the Torah and bringing glad tidings of a messenger to come after me, whose name is Aḥmad* (al-Ṣaff 61:6). The scriptural horizon was the air the message breathed into. It was also the inheritance the message claimed to repossess. And one of its voices, the Quran insists, had already spoken the coming name.

The Hour Before Dawn

Stand back now and let the threads draw together, for they were about to be tied into a single knot. Two empires, the only powers the civilized world recognized, had spent themselves to exhaustion in a war that ended with both bankrupt, both depopulated, both holding frontier provinces seething with populations worn past loyalty. And a recitation not yet spoken had already named their reversal before it came. A plague confirmed in the bones of the dead had moved through those provinces in waves for a century. Whatever its true scale, it had not left the cities as full as it found them, and a teaching was on its way that would answer the plague with quarantine and patience where the age had answered it with terror and flight. The sky had failed within living memory, dimming the sun and chilling the harvests across decades, thinning the bodies that hunger and pestilence would take. In the south a kingdom had addressed the Merciful as Lord of heaven and earth two centuries early, the very name the recitation would carry on every chapter's tongue, and had burned in a pit those who would not abandon the One God, and the memory of that fire had reached into the chapter of the constellations and into the mouth of the Prophet ﷺ before either existed in time. The sanctuary of the north had been defended against an elephant and a king, and the trade-tribe that kept it had been fed and made safe by a God who asked, in the oldest verses, only to be worshipped without partners in the House the idols had crowded. And around the whole peninsula stood the scriptural faiths, the Jews awaiting their prophet whom their own books had written, the Christians at war over the nature of Christ, the seekers pushing up through the pagan crust toward a dawn they could feel but not see, and one prophecy already lodged in the tradition that named the coming one Aḥmad.

The geometry of it is hard to miss once it is seen. There was a seam in the world, the one peninsula that neither giant had been able to absorb, ungoverned by Rome and ungoverned by Persia. And at the moment the two giants reached the bottom of their strength, that seam was where the new thing came. It came not from the center of either empire, where the armies and the treasuries and the theologians were, but from the gap between them that both had ignored as a wasteland of poets and idolaters. The recitation names the reason for the place as well as the timing, for it was sent to a people who had received no warner in living memory and could not claim they had been passed over. *That you may warn a people whose forefathers were not warned, so they are unaware* (Yā Sīn 36:6), and again, *We sent you with the truth, a bringer of good news and a warner, and there was no nation but that a warner had passed within it* (Fāṭir 35:24). The unlettered people would receive an unlettered prophet from among themselves, exactly as Abraham (AS) had asked at the founding of the barren valley, when his prayer reached past his own generation to one not yet born. *Our Lord, and raise up among them a messenger from themselves, who will recite to them Your verses and teach them the Book and wisdom and purify them. Indeed You are the Mighty, the Wise* (al-Baqara 2:129). Centuries later the recitation would answer that prayer in the past tense, the asking and the granting bound across the gulf of

time. *It is He who sent among the unlettered a messenger from themselves, reciting to them His verses and purifying them and teaching them the Book and wisdom, though they were before in clear error* (al-Jumu'ah 62:2).

Into that exact convergence a child was born, in the year his people would name for the Elephant, in the valley of the inviolable House, among the Quraysh who kept it, of the clan of Hāshim. He was of the line that the Prophet ﷺ himself would describe in the sound report of Bukhārī as the chosen succession of the generations, sent from the best of the generations of the children of Adam, age after age, until he came forth in the age that bore him. The Prophet ﷺ would one day gather the whole of this convergence into a single sentence, in a report carried by Aḥmad and others and judged sound. He was asked about the beginning of his affair, and he answered that he was the supplication of his father Abraham (AS), and the glad tidings of his brother Jesus (AS), and that his mother saw, when she carried him, a light that lit for her the palaces of Syria. The prayer of Abraham (AS) at the barren valley, the prophecy of Jesus (AS) to the children of Israel, and the light seen by the mother in the dark, three threads from three ages, all converging on one birth in the Year of the Elephant. The recitation that was coming would call him exactly that, a light, *and a caller to God by His permission, and an illuminating lamp* (al-Aḥzāb 33:46). And it would state his purpose for the whole of creation in seven words that close the matter, *and We have not sent you except as a mercy to the worlds* (al-Anbiyā' 21:107).

The empires did not record it. The fairs did not pause. The seekers who had spent their lives feeling for the dawn had, most of them, already died in the dark without seeing it. The world had been preparing for this for a hundred years, dimming its light and thinning its peoples and exhausting its kings and stirring its monotheist hunger, and the world did not know what it had prepared for. His name was Muhammad ﷺ, the very Aḥmad of the prophecy, and the light his mother saw was the lamp the recitation would name. The long night was over. What it had been waiting for had come.

II • THE MECCAN PROPHET

He came as an orphan into the keeping of a tribe that did not yet know what it held. For forty years he lived among them as one of them. He herded their flocks, carried their trade, and was trusted with their disputes and their treasure, and they called him the Trustworthy. Then in a cave above the city a voice told him to recite, and the man they trusted became the man they tried to kill. This is the Meccan arc, from the silence of the orphan to the silence of the empty road north. Between them stand the first words of the recitation, the first blood of the faith, and the first long testing of a message that had nothing but the truth and the patience to carry it.

The Orphan of Quraysh

He was born into the clan of Hāshim. It was a clan of Quraysh honored for the offices it held at the House, but it was not the richest of the Meccan houses, and he was born already fatherless. His father, ‘Abd Allāh son of ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib, had died on a trading journey before the child drew breath. The boy was named Muhammad ﷺ, the Praised, a name rare among the Arabs. The recitation would later confirm that the prophet foretold to the children of Israel had carried the cognate name Aḥmad, the most praised, the two names from one root closing over a single man. By the custom of the noble Meccan families the infant was given out to a wet-nurse of the desert tribes, where the air was cleaner and the tongue purer, and he passed into the keeping of Ḥalīma of the Banū Sa’d. The biographers transmit that her flocks grew fat and her milk ran plentiful from the day she took him, the blessing the tradition saw flowing wherever he was. These reports carry the weight of the sīra, the remembered devotion of the community rather than the chains of the first rank.

One event of those desert years is preserved at the highest weight, in the sound collection of Muslim on the authority of Anas. While the boy was at play among the children of his foster family, figures came to him, opened his breast, and purified his heart. The tradition reads this cleansing as the first preparing of the vessel that would carry the revelation. The narration is sober and strange, and it sits in the sound register, and the community has held it as the sign that the child set apart for the Word was being readied long before the Word came. Ḥalīma, frightened, returned him to his mother.

The losses then fell upon him one after another, and the recitation would one day name them back to him as the very ground of God’s mercy. His mother, Āmina, died when he was about six, on the road returning from a visit to his father’s kin, and the boy who had never known a father now had no mother. His grandfather ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib, the lord of Quraysh who had stood at the door of the Ka’ba before the elephant, took him in and loved him, and died when the boy was about eight. Guardianship passed to his uncle Abū Ṭālib, ‘Abd Allāh’s full brother, a man of honor and slender means who would shelter his nephew for forty years and yet die outside the faith. The child grew up an orphan three times bereaved, poor, and protected only by the bond of blood. Years later the revelation seemed to halt, and in that long pause the Prophet ﷺ feared he had been abandoned. The recitation gathered all of this into a single consolation, naming his orphanhood as the first proof that he had never been left alone. *By the morning brightness, and by the night when it is still, your Lord has not forsaken you, nor does He hate you, and the last is better for you than the first, and your Lord will give you until you are satisfied. Did He not find you an orphan and give you shelter, and find you lost and guide you, and find you in need and make you free of want. So as for the orphan, do not oppress him, and as for the one*

who asks, do not repel him (al-Ḍuḥā 93). The orphan would be commanded never to oppress an orphan. The God who had sheltered him would make that shelter law.

The Trustworthy

He grew into a young man whose character the city read before he ever claimed a word from heaven. This is among the most important facts of the whole life, for the case the Prophet ﷺ would later make rested in part on what Mecca already knew of him. He herded sheep, the work of prophets before him, and he would say in later years that God sent no prophet who had not herded sheep. The biographers carry the journey he made as a youth with his uncle's caravan into Syria. There, at the edge of the Christian north, the report of the monk Baḥīrā places its recognition of the marks of prophecy upon him, a sīra narration received at the weight of its genre and treated already in the account of the world that ringed Arabia. What the city saw daily was steadier than any monk's vision. He was honest in a market of sharp dealing. He kept his word in an age that broke words. He was called al-Amīn, the Trustworthy, and al-Ṣādiq, the Truthful, titles given not by followers but by the very people who would later call him a liar and a sorcerer. That contradiction would one day be turned against them from the hill of Ṣafā.

In his youth he stood inside an event the tradition holds dear, the pact called the Ḥilf al-Fuḍūl, the League of the Virtuous. It was sworn in the house of a Meccan notable when the clans bound themselves to stand with any wronged person in the city, stranger or citizen, until justice was returned. The Prophet ﷺ witnessed it as a young man. Long after the revelation had come he spoke of it in words the biographers preserve, that he had witnessed in the house of 'Abd Allāh ibn Jud'ān a pact he would not exchange for the choicest of red camels, and that were he called to its like in Islam he would answer. A covenant of justice sworn by idolaters did not lose its worth because idolaters swore it. The man who would overturn the religion of his people kept the honor of the best of their customs, and named it good with his own mouth after prophecy.

Khadījah

A widow of Quraysh, Khadījah bint Khuwaylid, was a woman of standing and wealth who financed caravans and hired men of proven honesty to carry her goods. She heard of the young man called the Trustworthy and engaged him to take her trade north to Syria. He returned having dealt so well and so honestly that her servant's report of his conduct, together with what the journey was said to have shown of the signs that attended him, moved her to offer him marriage. She was about forty and he about twenty-five, and the marriage that followed was the great human anchor of his Meccan life. For as long as she lived he took no other wife. She bore his children. And when the weight of the first revelation fell on him and he came home shaking, it was Khadījah who held him and steadied him and was the first human being on the earth to believe him. The recitation does not name her, but the sound tradition raises her to a height few attain. Bukhārī and Muslim carry the report that Gabriel came to the Prophet ﷺ and told him to give Khadījah the greeting of peace from her Lord, and the glad tidings of a house in Paradise of hollowed pearl, in which there would be no clamor and no weariness. The angel of revelation carried God's own salutation to the woman who first believed. The Prophet ﷺ would say that the best of the women of her time was Khadījah, and he never ceased to honor her memory after her death, until the honoring of her wore on the heart of a later wife.

The Black Stone

When he was about thirty-five, Quraysh undertook to rebuild the Ka'ba, whose walls had been damaged. The rebuilding produced a quarrel that nearly drew the swords of the clans, and the city resolved it by turning, as it instinctively did, to the Trustworthy. The clans had raised the walls together. But when the work reached the setting of the Black Stone, the sacred stone of the corner, each clan claimed the honor of lifting it into place, and the dispute hardened until blood seemed near. They agreed at last to abide by the judgment of the next man to enter the precinct, and the next man was Muhammad ﷺ. When they saw him they said, here is the Trustworthy, we are content with him. His judgment was the judgment of a man who would later bind warring tribes into one community. He called for a cloak, laid the stone upon it with his own hands, and bid a representative of each clan take hold of an edge, so that all of them raised it together. Then he set it in its place himself. The honor was shared, the violence was averted, and the city had seen, before it heard a word of revelation, the hand that joined what was divided. The biographers carry this at the weight of the *sīra*, and it is among the episodes the community has loved most, for it shows the method of the man before the mission, the instinct for unity over precedence, the refusal to let pride spill blood.

The Cave and the Word

As he neared forty, something in him drew apart from the idolatry and the noise of the city. He took to retreating, for nights at a time, to a cave on the mountain the Meccans called Ḥirā', above the valley, to be alone with his thoughts and with the God of Abraham (AS) whom the seekers sought. The sound tradition preserves the beginning of revelation in one of the foundational narrations of the whole religion, carried by Bukhārī on the authority of 'Ā'ishah, and it deserves to be told as the tradition tells it. The first sign was true dreams, dreams that came to pass like the breaking of dawn. The love of solitude grew on him, and he would retire to Ḥirā' with provision and devote himself to worship across many nights before returning to Khadijah for more. Then, in the cave, the angel came to him and commanded, Recite. He answered that he was not a reader. The angel seized him and pressed him until he could bear no more, then released him and said again, Recite. Again he said he was not a reader, and again he was pressed, three times, until the words came down upon him.

Recite in the name of your Lord who created, created man from a clinging clot. Recite, and your Lord is the most Generous, who taught by the pen, taught man what he did not know (al-'Alaq 96:1-5). The first word of the final revelation was a command to read. It was given in a culture that prized the spoken word above the written, and given to a man who could not read, naming the pen and the teaching of what man did not know as the gifts of the most Generous. He came down the mountain with his heart pounding and the words in him, and he went to Khadijah and said, wrap me, wrap me, and they wrapped him until the fear left him. Then he told her, fearing for himself, and she answered him with the words the community has never forgotten, that God would never disgrace him, for he kept the bonds of kinship, bore the burden of the weak, gave to the destitute, honored the guest, and stood by the people in their afflictions. She took him to her cousin Waraqah ibn Nawfal, the aged scholar who had embraced the scriptural faith and read the earlier books. When Waraqah heard the account he said that this was the Nāmūs, the very keeper of revelation that God had sent down upon Moses (AS), and he wished he might be young and alive on the day the Prophet's people would drive him out. The Prophet ﷺ, startled, asked whether they would drive him out, and Waraqah answered that no man had ever brought the like of what he brought without being treated as an enemy, and

that if he lived to see the day he would help him with all his strength. Waraqah died soon after, and the world's first witness to the prophecy among the People of the Book passed before the mission was public.

Then the revelation paused. The interval the tradition calls the *fatra* fell over him, a silence in which the words did not come. By the reports the biographers carry, the Prophet ﷺ grieved and feared that he had been forsaken, that the Lord who had spoken had turned away. It was into this silence that the chapter of the morning brightness descended, the consolation of the orphan, your Lord has not forsaken you nor does He hate you. Beside it came the chapter of the expanding of the breast. *Did We not expand for you your breast, and remove from you your burden which weighed upon your back, and raise high for you your remembrance. So indeed, with hardship comes ease, indeed with hardship comes ease* (al-Sharḥ 94). The promise that with every hardship there comes ease, repeated twice so the heart would not miss it, was first spoken to a frightened man in a pause, and it became the verse the whole community would lean on in every pause since. When the revelation returned it returned with a command, the call to rise from the wrapping and take up the work. *O you who are wrapped in your cloak, arise and warn, and your Lord magnify, and your garments purify, and uncleanness shun* (al-Muddaththir 74:1-5). And it called him in the night to the long standing in prayer that would arm him for what was coming. *O you who are enwrapped, stand the night, except a little, half of it, or lessen from it a little, or add to it, and recite the Quran with measured recitation. Indeed We will cast upon you a weighty word* (al-Muzzammil 73:1-5). The weighty word had begun to fall.

Warn Your Nearest Kin

For three years the call was quiet, moving through the bonds of trust to those nearest him. Khadijah his wife believed first. After her, by the strong reports, came his young cousin 'Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib, a boy in his household, and his freedman and adopted son Zayd ibn Ḥārithah. From outside the house came his friend Abū Bakr, the merchant whose word carried weight in Mecca and who brought others after him, 'Uthmān and al-Zubayr and 'Abd al-Raḥmān ibn 'Awf and Sa'd and Ṭalhah, the early core of the faith. They prayed in secret and gathered in a house at the foot of Ṣafā. Then the command came to widen the circle to the family, and after the family to the city. *And warn your nearest kindred* (al-Shu'arā' 26:214), the recitation ordered. Then, raising the voice from the clan to all who would hear, it said, *so proclaim what you are commanded, and turn away from the polytheists, indeed We are sufficient for you against the mockers* (al-Ḥijr 15:94-95).

The day he took the message to the whole city is preserved in the sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim, and it turned upon the very name the city had given him. He climbed the hill of Ṣafā and called out clan by clan until Quraysh gathered to him. He asked them, if I told you that horsemen were advancing on you from behind this hill, would you believe me. They answered that they had never known him to tell anything but the truth. He said, then I am a warner to you before a severe punishment. The man whose truthfulness they had just affirmed was telling them of the reckoning, and the logic was a trap of their own making, for they could not at once call him truthful and call his warning a lie. His uncle Abū Lahab broke the silence with a curse, may you perish, is this why you have gathered us. And the answer to Abū Lahab came down from heaven as a chapter, naming him and his end. *Perish the two hands of Abū Lahab, and perish he. His wealth will not avail him, nor what he has earned. He will burn in a fire of blazing flame, and his wife, the carrier of firewood, around her neck a rope of twisted palm fiber* (al-Masad 111). A chapter of the Quran was given over to a single man's rejection, sealing his ruin while he yet lived. Abū Lahab lived on for years a disbeliever, the prophecy standing over him unbroken until his death confirmed it.

To grasp the Meccan years one must grasp the shape of the message that was descending, for it was not yet a code of law but an overturning of the way a human being saw the world. The early Meccan chapters were short and thunderous and built for the memory and the tongue, and they struck at three things together. They struck at the gods, declaring that there was no deity but God, one, without partner or daughter or rival, the creator the idolaters themselves admitted and then buried under their brokers. They struck at the denial of the reckoning, hammering on the resurrection and the Day with an urgency that left no room for the comfortable Meccan certainty that death was the end and wealth was the measure. And they struck at the moral order of the city, at the hoarding of wealth and the neglect of the orphan and the contempt for the weak. The recitation swore by the declining day that man was in loss, *by time, indeed mankind is in loss, except those who believe and do righteous deeds and counsel one another to truth and counsel one another to patience* (al-‘Aṣr 103). It warned the one who piled up wealth and counted it, thinking it would make him immortal (al-Humazah 104:1-3). It described the Day when the earth would convulse and give up its burdens and every atom of good and evil would be seen, *so whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it, and whoever does an atom's weight of evil will see it* (al-Zalzalah 99:7-8). It painted the splitting of the sky and the scattering of the stars and the seas set boiling, and asked the heedless man what had deceived him about his generous Lord (al-Infīṭār 82:1-6). This was the substance of the offense. It was not merely a new god. It was a new accounting, in which the proud were brought low and the buried daughter was asked for her crime and the hoarded gold became a fire. The men who ran Mecca understood at once that if it were true their whole world was overturned.

And to carry these claims the recitation did not merely assert them. It turned the eye of its hearers upon the world they already lived in, making the whole of creation its evidence. Against a people who admitted that God had made the heavens and the earth and then prayed to stones beside Him, it pointed again and again to the order of the made world as the standing proof of the One who made it, asking them to look at what was before their faces. *Do they not look at the camels, how they are created, and at the sky, how it is raised, and at the mountains, how they are set, and at the earth, how it is spread* (al-Ghāshiyah 88:17-20). It drew the signs from the most ordinary things, from the rain that revives the dead earth and the turning of the night into the day, from the sleep that is a little death and the waking that is a little raising, from the diversity of human tongues and colors, every one of them a sign for a people who would reflect. *And of His signs is that He created you from dust, then at once you are human beings spreading out. And of His signs is that He created for you mates from among yourselves that you may find rest in them, and He placed between you affection and mercy. And of His signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth and the difference of your languages and your colors* (al-Rūm 30:20-22). And it promised that the proof would only grow plainer with time, in the wide world and in the body of the seer himself, until denial had nowhere left to stand. *We will show them Our signs in the horizons and within their own selves until it becomes clear to them that it is the truth* (Fuṣṣilat 41:53). The strangest of these signs was the nearest, the one each person carried in his own making and overlooked because it stood too close to be seen, the standing wonder of his own existence. Toward it the recitation kept returning the heedless eye, for the mystery a man chased across the far horizon was breathing in him the whole time.

The message also leveled, and the leveling reached even the Prophet ﷺ himself in a rebuke the recitation did not spare him. One day he was occupied with the powerful men of Quraysh whom he hoped to win, and he turned away from a poor blind man, Ibn Umm Maktūm, who had come seeking knowledge. The correction came down upon the Prophet ﷺ in the third person, as a lasting verse in the Book that all would recite. *He frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him. And what would make you know, perhaps he*

would be purified, or be reminded so the reminder would benefit him. As for the one who considers himself self-sufficient, to him you give attention, though it is not upon you that he is not purified. But as for the one who came to you striving, while he fears, from him you are distracted (‘Abasa 80:1-10). The revelation that exalted the Prophet ﷺ also corrected him before his whole community, and the honesty of that is itself a sign, for a man fabricating a scripture to glorify himself does not write into it the record of his own error. And when Quraysh, unable to silence him, sought a compromise, offering to worship his God if he would worship theirs in turn, the answer refused every blending. *Say, O disbelievers, I do not worship what you worship, nor are you worshippers of what I worship, nor will I be a worshipper of what you worship, nor will you be worshippers of what I worship. For you your religion, and for me my religion* (al-Kāfirūn 109). There would be no half-measure between the One and the three hundred and sixty.

The Tortured

Mecca answered the message first with mockery, then with pressure, then with torture, and the torture fell hardest on those the city could harm without fear of their clans, the slaves and the poor and the friendless among the believers. The biographers and the sound reports together preserve the names. Bilāl, the Abyssinian slave, was laid on the burning sand under a great rock by his master and told to renounce the One God, and he answered only, One, One, refusing under the stone to name another, until Abū Bakr bought him and set him free. Abū Bakr spent his wealth buying and freeing the tortured slaves of the believers, and the recitation would later honor exactly such giving that seeks nothing but the face of the Most High (al-Layl 92:18-21, in the reports tied to him). The family of Yāsir bore the worst. Yāsir and his wife Sumayyah and their son ‘Ammār were tortured to force them from the faith. The Prophet ﷺ, the biographers transmit, would pass them under their torment and say, patience, family of Yāsir, your appointed place is Paradise. Sumayyah was killed under torture by Abū Jahl, and she became the first martyr of Islam, an aged woman who would not deny her Lord, the first of all who would die for this faith down the centuries. ‘Ammār, pressed past endurance, was made to utter words of disbelief with his tongue to save his life, and came to the Prophet ﷺ in anguish. The revelation eased him, exempting the one whose tongue is forced while his heart holds firm. *Whoever disbelieves in God after his belief, except one who is compelled while his heart is at rest with faith, but those who open their breasts to disbelief, upon them is wrath from God* (al-Nahl 16:106). The faith was learning, in blood, the difference between the heart and the tongue, and the Book was marking it down.

The Crossing to Abyssinia

When the persecution grew unbearable the Prophet ﷺ told the weakest and most exposed of the believers to cross the sea to Abyssinia, to the land of the Christian king the Arabs called the Negus, of whom he said that there ruled a king under whom no one was wronged. A first small party went, and then a larger, some eighty in time, the first migration of Islam, leaving the sanctuary of their birth for the protection of a Christian throne. Quraysh, alarmed that their runaways had found refuge, sent an embassy after them with gifts to demand their return. What followed is preserved in the sīra on the narration of Umm Salamah, who was there, and it is one of the great meetings of the early faith. The Negus summoned the believers and asked them to account for the new religion that had cut them off from their people without bringing them into his. Their spokesman was Ja‘far ibn Abī Ṭālib, the Prophet's cousin, and his answer became a portrait of Islam drawn for a Christian king. We were a people of ignorance, he said, worshipping idols, eating carrion, committing shameful deeds, severing kinship, the strong devouring the weak, until God sent among us a man

we knew for his truth and trust and purity, who called us to worship God alone and abandon the stones, to speak truth, keep trust, honor kinship, and cease from bloodshed and the wrongful eating of the orphan's wealth.

The Negus asked whether Ja'far had with him anything of what had come to the Prophet ﷺ from God, and Ja'far recited to him the opening of the chapter of Mary, the Quranic account of the Christian's own Lord, of Zechariah (AS) and John (AS), and of the virgin and her son. *And mention in the Book Mary, when she withdrew from her family to a place toward the east. Then she took, apart from them, a screen, and We sent to her Our spirit, and it appeared to her as a well-made man* (Maryam 19:16-17). The chapter goes on through the annunciation, the birth beneath the palm, and the infant Jesus (AS) speaking from the cradle in defense of his mother. *He said, indeed I am the servant of God. He has given me the Scripture and made me a prophet, and made me blessed wherever I am, and has enjoined upon me prayer and charity as long as I live, and dutifulness to my mother, and He has not made me arrogant or wretched* (Maryam 19:30-32). The Negus wept until his beard was wet, and his bishops wept, and he said that what Ja'far had recited and what Jesus (AS) brought came from the one lamp, and he refused to surrender the believers to Quraysh, returning the embassy's gifts. The first refuge of Islam was granted by a Christian who heard the Quran's account of Christ and recognized the same light, and the believers remained safe under him for years. The episode is *sīra* in its detailed narration, devotedly preserved, and it carries a truth the later centuries of dispute would obscure, that the recitation honored Jesus (AS) and Mary so highly that a Christian king wept to hear it.

The Years of the Siege and the Sorrow

Unable to reach the Prophet ﷺ while his clan protected him, Quraysh turned to pressure the whole clan of Hāshim, believers and unbelievers together. They imposed a boycott, a written ban posted at the Ka'ba forbidding any to marry the people of Hāshim, to trade with them, or to deal with them at all, until they surrendered the Prophet ﷺ to be killed. For about three years the clan withdrew into the valley quarter, the *shi'b* of Abū Ṭālib, hemmed in and hungry. The children cried with hunger by the biographers' reports, and the believers and the still-unbelieving kin of the Prophet ﷺ endured together for the bond of blood. The boycott broke at last when men of Quraysh, ashamed, moved to annul it, and the document was found, by the tradition's account, eaten away. But the years had worn down the two who had sheltered him most.

In the space of a short time, in the year the tradition calls the Year of Sorrow, the Prophet ﷺ lost both Khadijah and Abū Ṭālib. Khadijah, who had believed first and stood by him through every blow, died after a quarter century of marriage, and with her went the human refuge of his home and the great consolation of his heart. Abū Ṭālib, the uncle who had protected him for forty years against all Quraysh, lay dying. The Prophet ﷺ came to him and pleaded with him at the last to say the word of faith so that he might intercede for him, and Abū Ṭālib, with the chiefs of Quraysh at his bedside shaming him from the religion of his fathers, died upon the way of his fathers. The grief of it reached into the recitation, for the Prophet ﷺ longed to guide the uncle who had sheltered him, and the verse came down to teach him the limit of even a prophet's reach. *Indeed you do not guide whom you love, but God guides whom He wills, and He knows best the rightly guided* (al-Qaṣaṣ 28:56). The guidance of hearts belonged to God alone, and not even the Messenger ﷺ could place faith in a beloved heart that refused it. He had lost his wife and his protector in one season, and the city, sensing him exposed, pressed in harder.

Bereft and besieged, he carried the message out of Mecca to the town of Ṭā'if in the hills, hoping its people might receive what Mecca refused. They refused it more cruelly, setting their fools and children to pelt him with stones until his feet ran with blood. He withdrew, broken, and made the prayer the biographers preserve as among the most moving he ever uttered, complaining to God alone of his weakness and his helplessness before men, asking into whose care God would entrust him, and declaring that if God were not angry with him he did not care, for God's favor was wide enough for him. And the sound tradition, in Bukhārī on the narration of 'Ā'ishah, preserves what came next. When 'Ā'ishah later asked him whether he had known a day harder than the day of Uḥud, he answered that he had suffered much from Ṭā'if, and that the angel of the mountains had been sent to him there, offering to crush the people of the two mountains between them if he wished. He refused, saying rather that he hoped God would bring forth from their loins those who would worship God alone and associate nothing with Him. At the lowest point of his life, with his blood on the ground and the power to destroy his persecutors offered to him by an angel, he chose instead to hope for the faith of their grandchildren. The mercy to the worlds had been struck at its limit and answered with mercy.

The Night Journey

It was in this season of sorrow and rejection, by the strong reckoning of the tradition, that the Prophet ﷺ was given the journey that lifted him above all of it, the night journey and the ascension, the *Isrā'* and the *Mi'rāj*. The recitation opens its account in a single verse of glory. *Glory to the One who took His servant by night from the Sacred Mosque to the Farthest Mosque, whose surroundings We have blessed, to show him of Our signs. Indeed He is the Hearing, the Seeing* (al-Isrā' 17:1). In one night he was carried from the Ka'ba at Mecca to the sanctuary at Jerusalem, the Farthest Mosque, and from there raised through the heavens into the presence of his Lord. The sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim preserve the ascent in detail, on the narrations of Anas and others, and the deeper meaning of what was seen belongs to a later Book of this work, where the unseen horizon is taken up on its own. Here the event stands in its place in the life. He was carried on a mount the tradition names al-Burāq, and at Jerusalem he led the prophets who had gone before him in prayer, the seal of them praying at their head. Then he was raised through the seven heavens, meeting the prophets stationed in them, Adam in the nearest, and Jesus (AS) and John (AS), and Joseph (AS), and Idrīs (AS), and Aaron (AS), and Moses (AS), and Abraham (AS) at the seventh by the House that the angels circle as men circle the House below. He was taken to the lote tree of the utmost boundary, the *sidrat al-muntahā*, beyond which none may pass, of which the chapter of the star says *the sight did not swerve, nor did it transgress, he certainly saw of the greatest signs of his Lord* (al-Najm 53:17-18). And there the prayers were ordained, fifty in the day and night, until Moses (AS), by the narration, urged him to return and ask his Lord for relief, knowing the weakness of men. The Prophet ﷺ returned again and again until the fifty were reduced to five in deed and fifty in reward. The five daily prayers, the spine of the believer's day, were brought down not by an angel to the earth but received by the Prophet ﷺ himself in the highest heaven, the one ordinance the tradition holds was given above all the others, in the presence of God. When he returned and told Mecca of the night, the disbelievers mocked him, and some who had believed faltered, but Abū Bakr, hearing it, said that if the Prophet ﷺ had said it then it was true, and earned the name al-Ṣiddīq, the great affirmer of truth. The man rejected by Ṭā'if and bereaved of his wife and uncle had been raised, in the same season, above the seventh heaven.

The Pledges at Aqaba

The opening, when it came, came from the north, from the town that would become Medina. The oasis of Yathrib was torn by a long and exhausting feud between its two Arab tribes, the Aws and the Khazraj, and it lived alongside its established Jewish tribes who spoke of a coming prophet. It was a soil prepared in a way Mecca was not. At the season of pilgrimage the Prophet ﷺ would present himself to the tribes camped around Mecca, calling them to God. A small group of men from Khazraj heard him and recognized in him, the reports say, the prophet their Jewish neighbors had foretold, and they believed. They returned to Yathrib and spread the faith, and the next year a delegation came to meet the Prophet ﷺ secretly at a place called ‘Aqabah near Mecca. There twelve of them gave him a pledge, the first pledge of ‘Aqabah, swearing to worship God alone, to associate nothing with Him, not to steal or commit unlawful sexual intercourse, not to kill their children, not to slander, and to obey him in what was right, a pledge the sound tradition records in nearly the same terms as the later pledges of the women. He sent a teacher back with them to instruct the new community in the recitation, and the faith spread through the houses of Yathrib until there was hardly a house without it.

The following year a far larger group came, over seventy men and two women of the Aws and the Khazraj, and at the same ‘Aqabah, in the dark of night, they gave the second pledge. It was a pledge of a different order, for it was a pledge of protection and of war. They swore to receive the Prophet ﷺ into their city and to defend him as they defended their own wives and children, against all comers, knowing that to shelter him was to declare war on all of Arabia. One of them asked aloud what they would have if they kept the pledge and lost everything, and the answer was Paradise. They gave their hands on it. The believers of Mecca, hunted and worn, now had a city that had sworn to die for them. The Prophet ﷺ told them to depart for Yathrib, and quietly, family by family, the Muslims of Mecca began to slip away to the north, until almost none were left but the Prophet ﷺ, Abū Bakr, ‘Alī, and those held back by force or weakness.

The Migration

Quraysh saw the city emptying of believers and understood that the Prophet ﷺ was about to escape their reach into a fortified town that would shield him, and they resolved to end it before he could go. They gathered in the council house and settled on a plan the recitation itself would describe, that a young man of strength from every clan should strike him together, so that his blood would be spread across all the clans and his own clan of Hāshim could not avenge it against any single house. The Quran records the night and the One who outmatched their scheme. *And when those who disbelieved plotted against you, to imprison you or kill you or drive you out. They plot, and God plots, and God is the best of plotters* (al-Anfāl 8:30). The Prophet ﷺ, warned, had ‘Alī lie in his bed in his cloak to deceive the watchers. ‘Alī, a young man, gave his body to the assassins’ watch so the Prophet ﷺ could slip out, and was left also to return the trusts that the very people seeking to kill the Prophet ﷺ had still left in his keeping, for they trusted the Trustworthy with their valuables even as they plotted his death. He went to Abū Bakr, who had prepared two mounts and wept with joy at being chosen as the companion of the road, and the two of them left Mecca and went not north but south, to a cave in the mountain of Thawr, to hide while the search raged.

The hours in the cave of Thawr became one of the most beloved scenes of the faith, and the Quran sealed it into the Book in the verse of the second of two. The pursuers came so close that Abū Bakr, by the sound narration in Bukhārī, could see their feet at the mouth of the cave and feared for the Prophet ﷺ, whispering

that if one of them merely looked down at his feet he would see them. And the Prophet ﷺ answered him with the words the recitation would enshrine, what do you think of two whose third is God. The Quran gives the moment its eternal frame. *If you do not aid him, God has already aided him, when those who disbelieved drove him out, the second of two, when they were in the cave, when he said to his companion, do not grieve, indeed God is with us. So God sent down His tranquility upon him and supported him with soldiers you did not see* (al-Tawba 9:40). The tranquility came down, the searchers turned away, and the two emerged after three nights and took the desert tracks toward Yathrib. The tradition would later love to tell of a spider's web spun and doves nesting at the cave's mouth to make it seem long undisturbed, a detail of weaker chain that the community has cherished though it does not rest on the strongest reports, while the core of the scene, the two in the cave, the nearness of God, and the descended tranquility, stands in the Book itself.

On the road a Meccan named Surāqah ibn Mālik, lured by the bounty Quraysh had set on the Prophet's head, gave chase on his horse, and the sound tradition in Bukhārī carries what happened. As he closed the distance his horse's legs sank into the firm ground beneath him, and again when he rose and pursued, until he understood that he was held back, and he called out for safety and turned from hunter to suppliant. The Prophet ﷺ, fleeing for his life with a price on his head, promised the man who had come to kill him that he would one day wear the bracelets of Khosrow, the king of Persia. Years after the Prophet ﷺ had died, when the armies of Islam had broken the very Persia that had once seemed eternal, the bracelets and the regalia of the Persian king were brought to Medina, and Surāqah was called and the bracelets of Khosrow were placed on his arms. The promise made on the road of the Hijra by a hunted fugitive was kept against the treasure of a fallen empire. The thread runs straight back to the two exhausted giants with which this history began, for the God who had foretold Rome's return over Persia in the chapter of the Romans now set a Bedouin pursuer's hands inside the bracelets of the Persian king.

He came at last to the outskirts of Yathrib, to the village of Qubā', and the people of the city, who had been going out each morning to watch the road for him, met him with a joy the tradition remembers in song and welcome. He stayed at Qubā' and there laid the foundation of the first mosque of Islam, a mosque the recitation would later honor as founded upon piety from the first day (al-Tawba 9:108). Then he entered the city itself, and let his she-camel choose the place where she would kneel, and bought the ground where she stopped, and there he built his mosque and his household, the heart of what the city would become. Yathrib would take a new name from his coming, Madīnat al-Nabī, the City of the Prophet, Medina. The orphan of Quraysh, who had begun this life fatherless in a barren valley and had spent forty years as the Trustworthy and thirteen as the rejected warner, had crossed the empty road north and arrived in a city that had sworn to defend him with its life. The Meccan night was over. From the date of this crossing the Muslims would one day reckon their years, for the Hijra, the migration, was the hinge on which the faith turned from a persecuted voice into a community with a home. What that community would build, and the wars and the laws and the covenant that would make it, belongs to the next Book.

III • THE STATESMAN OF MEDINA

In Mecca he had been a warner with no power but the truth. In Medina he became something the world had not seen, a prophet who was also a head of state, a lawgiver, a judge, a commander, and the architect of a community bound not by blood but by a creed and a written covenant. The ten years between the Hijra and his death compressed into themselves the founding of a polity, the writing of its constitution, the fighting of its wars, and the cleansing of the House for which the whole story had been waiting. This is the Book of the statesman. The recitation that came down across these years came down no longer as warning alone but as law, as battle order, as the constitution of a people learning, often through their own failures, to be the community the Book described.

The City of the Prophet

The first work in Medina was not war but building, in stone and in bond. He raised his mosque on the ground his camel had chosen, a simple structure of palm trunks and mud brick. It had a shaded portion where the poorest of the emigrants, the people of the bench, the Ahl al-Şuffah, would live and learn, and beside it stood the chambers of his household. The mosque was not only a place of prayer. It was the assembly, the court, the school, and the seat of government of the new community, and from it the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ governed. He instituted the call to prayer, the adhān, after consultation, choosing the human voice to summon the believers rather than a horn or a bell, and Bilāl, who had said only One under the torturing rock, became the first to raise it.

Then he bound the community together by an act of deliberate engineering against the deepest law of Arabia, the law of blood. The emigrants from Mecca, the Muhājirūn, had arrived stripped of their property and their kin, strangers in a strange city. The believers of Medina, the Anşār, the Helpers, had homes and date-groves and families. The Prophet ﷺ paired them, man with man, in a brotherhood, the mu'ākhāh, in which each Helper took an emigrant into his house and his livelihood as though he were kin. The recitation honored the Helpers for a generosity that has few equals in the record of any people. *And those who were settled in the home and in faith before them, they love those who emigrated to them and find no want in their breasts for what they were given, and give preference over themselves even though they are in need. And whoever is protected from the stinginess of his soul, those are the successful* (al-Hashr 59:9). The recitation made the bond a matter of law and not only of love, declaring the emigrants and the helpers allies of one another, *indeed those who believed and emigrated and strove with their wealth and their lives in the cause of God, and those who gave shelter and aid, they are allies of one another* (al-Anfāl 8:72). A society was being built whose primary tie was no longer the tribe into which a man was born but the faith he had chosen, and that reordering of the foundations of human loyalty is among the most radical things the Prophet ﷺ did.

Over this community, and over the city as a whole, he set a written constitution, the document the sources preserve as the Şahīfah and that the historians of law have called the first written constitution of its kind. It bound the believers, emigrant and helper, into a single ummah, a single political community. And it brought the Jewish tribes of Medina into the same covenant as a confederated people, with their religion to themselves, sharing in the defense of the city, contributing to its costs in war, and bound to mutual aid against any who attacked Medina. It abolished the isolated blood feud in favor of collective responsibility under the new order, and it named the final reference for any serious dispute, that whatever the parties differed upon was to be referred to God and to Muhammad ﷺ. A city of feuding tribes and three faiths was

given, in a single document, a constitution that made it one polity with one defense and one supreme arbitration, while leaving each community its own law in its own affairs. The man who had joined the clans at the Black Stone with a shared cloak now joined a whole city with a written word.

That a state founded on the recitation should leave the Jews of the city their own religion and their own law was not a concession wrung from weakness but a thing the recitation laid down in principle, for it forbade the forcing of faith in the plainest words it uses anywhere. *There is no compulsion in religion. The right course has become clear from error* (al-Baqarah 2:256). Belief is the turning of the heart, and a heart cannot be turned by the sword, and the recitation knew it, asking the Prophet ﷺ whether he would compel what God had left free. *And had your Lord willed, all who are on the earth would have believed, all of them together. So will you compel the people until they become believers* (Yūnus 10:99). His office was to carry the message and to make it plain, not to drive men into it, the recitation fixing the limit again and again, that he was a reminder and not a tyrant over them. The God who sent him stood in need of no one's faith, rich beyond the worlds, and the worth of a faith lay in its being freely given, the uncoerced yes of a soul that could have said no. So the city the Prophet ﷺ bound into one polity was not bound into one creed. It was given one peace and one defense and one law of the common life, and within it the freedom to believe or to refuse was left where the recitation had placed it, in the keeping of each soul before its Lord.

The Change of the Qibla

For the first period in Medina the believers had prayed toward Jerusalem, the sanctuary of the earlier prophets, as they had in the last Meccan years. Then, in the second year, came a command that turned the body of the community in a new direction and announced its independence as a people in the line of Abraham (AS). The Prophet ﷺ had been turning his face to the sky in a kind of longing, and the recitation answered the longing by turning the qibla, the direction of prayer, from Jerusalem to the Ka'ba, the House of Abraham (AS) at Mecca. *We have certainly seen the turning of your face toward the heaven, so We will surely turn you to a qibla with which you will be pleased. So turn your face toward the Sacred Mosque, and wherever you are, turn your faces toward it* (al-Baqarah 2:144). The recitation knew the offense it would cause and met it head on, for the change would be seized upon by the doubters and the People of the Book as a sign of confusion. *The foolish among the people will say, what has turned them from the qibla they used to face. Say, to God belongs the east and the west, He guides whom He wills to a straight path* (al-Baqarah 2:142). The turning was a declaration. The new community was not a sect of an older faith facing an older center. It was the restoration of the religion of Abraham (AS), facing the House Abraham (AS) had raised, and the recitation framed the whole episode as a test that separated those who followed the Messenger ﷺ from those who would turn on their heels (2:143).

These same early Medinan years brought the great institutions of the believer's life into their settled form. The fast of the month of Ramadan was ordained, the recitation tying it to the very month in which the recitation had begun to descend. *The month of Ramadan in which was revealed the Quran, a guidance for the people and clear proofs of guidance and the criterion. So whoever among you sights the month, let him fast it* (al-Baqarah 2:185), and the command was given gently, that God intends ease and not hardship (2:185). Fasting was prescribed as it had been prescribed upon those before them, that they might attain God-consciousness (2:183). The charity of the believer, the zakāt, was being fixed as a due and not a favor. The pilgrimage would in time be made obligatory upon those who could reach it. The shape of the worshipping community was set in these years, its day turned five times toward the House, its year marked by the fast of the month of

revelation, its wealth purified by a fixed due to the poor, and the recitation that set it came down into the daily life of a city that was living it as it was revealed.

Badr

In the second year the long cold war with Mecca turned hot, and it turned upon a caravan. A great Meccan caravan under Abū Sufyān was returning from Syria along the route near the coast, and the Prophet ﷺ led out a force of a little more than three hundred to intercept it, lightly equipped, with few horses, expecting an easy seizure of goods rather than a battle. But Abū Sufyān, warned, diverted the caravan to safety and sent to Mecca for help. Mecca, its pride and its trade both stung, marched out near a thousand strong, armored and mounted, to crush the upstart of Medina once and for all. The two forces met at the wells of Badr. The believers, outnumbered more than three to one and stripped of the easy prize they had come for, now faced the full strength of Quraysh, and the recitation records that some of them argued against the fight as though being driven to death with their eyes open (al-Anfāl 8:5-6). The Prophet ﷺ consulted his men, and the emigrants and then the helpers pledged to follow him into the battle though it meant their lives, and he drew them up at the wells and seized the water.

Through the night before the battle and in its hour the Prophet ﷺ stood in his shelter and prayed, and the sound tradition in Muslim preserves the desperation of his supplication. He raised his hands and begged his Lord to grant the help He had promised, saying that if this small band were destroyed, God would not be worshipped on the earth, until Abū Bakr took his cloak and told him his Lord would surely fulfill His promise. And the help came. The recitation describes a reinforcement the eye did not see, the casting of sleep over the believers as a security, the sending down of rain to firm the sand beneath them, and the descent of the angels. *When you sought help of your Lord and He answered you, indeed I will reinforce you with a thousand of the angels, rank upon rank* (al-Anfāl 8:9), and again, *remember when your Lord inspired to the angels, I am with you, so strengthen those who believe* (8:12). The small force broke the great one. The chiefs of Quraysh who had led the persecution fell on the field, Abū Jahl among them, the man the Prophet ﷺ had called the Pharaoh of this community. And the recitation took from the victors the very thing that might have undone them, the pride of having won, declaring that the killing and the victory had not been theirs at all. *And you did not kill them, but God killed them. And you did not throw when you threw, but God threw, that He might test the believers with a good test from Him* (al-Anfāl 8:17). The day was named the Day of the Criterion, the yawm al-furqān, the day God distinguished truth from falsehood (8:41), and the recitation reminded them ever after that God had given them victory at Badr while they were utterly weak, that they might be grateful (Āl ‘Imrān 3:123).

The captives taken at Badr produced the first great question of policy the recitation answered, and it answered it as a rebuke. Quraysh sought to ransom their prisoners, and the believers, poor and in need, inclined to take the ransom, and the Prophet ﷺ allowed it. But the recitation came down stern, that a prophet should not hold captives until he had subdued the land, that the believers had looked to the goods of this world while God intended the Hereafter, and that had it not been for a prior decree from God a great punishment would have touched them for what they took (al-Anfāl 8:67-68). Here again the honesty of the revelation marks it, for it records the Prophet ﷺ and his community choosing, and then corrects the choice, in a Book they themselves recited. A fabricated scripture flatters its authors. This one reproved them on the morning after their greatest triumph.

Uhud

Mecca came back for revenge in the third year, and at the mountain of Uḥud outside Medina the believers learned the bitter underside of Badr, that the help of God is tied to obedience, and that it is withdrawn when obedience fails. Quraysh marched out some three thousand strong under Abū Sufyān, with the women led by Hind bint ‘Utbah beating their drums and crying for vengeance for the fathers and brothers slain at Badr. The Prophet ﷺ drew up his force of about seven hundred with their backs to the mountain, and he set fifty archers on a small hill to guard the army's rear and flank, commanding them not to leave their post whatever happened, whether the Muslims won or lost. The battle opened in the believers' favor, and the Meccan line broke, and the army of Medina fell to gathering the spoils of the fleeing enemy. And the archers on the hill, seeing the victory and fearing to lose their share of the plunder, abandoned their post against the explicit order of the Prophet ﷺ. The Meccan cavalry, under Khālīd ibn al-Walīd who had not yet entered Islam, swept around the undefended hill and fell on the believers from behind, and victory turned in an instant to rout.

The slaughter was grievous. Ḥamzah, the Prophet's uncle, the Lion of God who had fought like ten men, was killed and his body mutilated, his liver cut out by Hind in her vengeance. The Prophet ﷺ himself was struck down in the chaos, his face cut, a tooth broken, the rings of his helmet driven into his cheek, and a cry went up that he had been killed. The cry nearly finished the army, for men lost heart and some thought of surrender. But he was alive, and those around him rallied to him and drew him up the mountain to safety, and the line re-formed, and Quraysh, having bloodied them but unable to take the city, withdrew. The recitation devoted a long passage of the chapter of the Family of ‘Imrān to the lesson of the day, and it did not spare the believers. *And God had certainly fulfilled His promise to you when you were killing them by His permission, until the moment you lost courage and fell to disputing about the order and disobeyed, after He had shown you what you love. Among you are some who desire this world and among you are some who desire the Hereafter* (Āl ‘Imrān 3:152). The defeat was traced to its true cause, the disobedience of the archers and the love of the spoils, and the believers were told plainly that the wound they suffered was answered by a like wound they had given at Badr, and that God was sifting them, marking the true believers from the false (3:140, 3:166-167).

Two consolations were folded into the rebuke, and the community has leaned on both ever since. To those who grieved the dead, the recitation forbade the very word death over the martyrs. *And do not think of those killed in the way of God as dead. Rather they are alive with their Lord, receiving provision, rejoicing in what God has given them of His bounty* (Āl ‘Imrān 3:169-170). And to those who had nearly broken when they thought the Prophet ﷺ was slain, the recitation administered a hard and necessary truth, that the faith did not rest on the life of the man who carried it but on the God who sent him. *Muhammad is but a messenger. Messengers have passed away before him. So if he dies or is killed, would you turn back on your heels. And whoever turns back on his heels will never harm God at all, and God will reward the grateful* (Āl ‘Imrān 3:144). The verse was spoken to a frightened battlefield. It would be spoken again, with terrible force, on the day the Prophet ﷺ truly died, and it would hold the community together in that hour as it held them at Uḥud. And in the same passage the recitation drew from the wounds of the day a portrait of the Prophet's own character, that it was by a mercy from God that he was gentle with them, for had he been harsh and hard-hearted they would have scattered from around him, and so he was to pardon them and seek forgiveness for them and consult them in the matter (Āl ‘Imrān 3:159). The commander whose order had been disobeyed at the cost of

his army's blood and his own was commanded to pardon, to forgive, and to keep consulting the very men who had failed him.

The Treachery of the Tribes

The constitution of Medina had bound the Jewish tribes of the city into one defensive covenant with the believers, and the years of war brought that covenant to a series of breaking points. The account must be given plainly, neither softened into apology nor inflamed into the thing the enemies of the faith have made of it. What is at issue throughout is the breach, in time of existential war, of a signed pact of mutual defense, and the response of a head of state to treason within the walls of a besieged city.

After Badr the tribe of Banū Qaynuqā', by the sources, broke into open defiance and provocation, and after a confrontation they were besieged and then expelled from Medina with their movable property, their lives spared. After Uhud the tribe of Banū al-Naḍīr was found, by the account the biographers carry, to have conspired in a plot to kill the Prophet ﷺ while he sat by the wall of their settlement, and they too were besieged and expelled, departing with what their camels could carry, their date-groves left behind. The chapter of the Exile, al-Ḥaṣhr, was revealed concerning the expulsion of al-Naḍīr, opening with the gathering of the divine names and naming the event as God's own act. *It is He who expelled those who disbelieved among the People of the Book from their homes at the first gathering. You did not think they would leave, and they thought their fortresses would protect them from God, but God came upon them from where they did not expect* (al-Ḥaṣhr 59:2). These were expulsions, not killings, the penalty of broken covenant and conspiracy in a city at war, and the recitation tied them to the sovereignty of God over the affairs of the community.

The gravest episode came with the third tribe, Banū Qurayẓah, and it came at the worst possible moment, during the siege of the Trench, when the survival of the whole community hung by a thread, and it is taken up in its place below, for it belongs to that siege. It must be said here only that the modern reader will find scholarly discussion of the numbers and details transmitted in the biographical sources, which are sīra-grade in their particulars, while the broad event of the reckoning with Qurayẓah is referenced in the recitation itself, in the chapter of the Confederates. The container, a tribe that turned traitor during a siege that nearly destroyed Medina and was judged for it, stands in the Book. The exact figures and the fine details belong to the biographical tradition and carry its weight, and an honest account holds them at that weight rather than asserting them as certainties or denying them as inventions.

The Trench

In the fifth year Mecca tried to end the matter with one overwhelming blow, gathering a grand confederation, the Aḥẓāb, Quraysh and the tribe of Ghaṭafān and their allies and the expelled chiefs of al-Naḍīr, a host the sources put at some ten thousand, the largest army Arabia had yet assembled, marching on a Medina that could field perhaps three thousand. Against such numbers in the open the believers had no hope, and it was the counsel of a Persian companion, Salmān al-Fārisī, who knew the warcraft of his homeland, that saved the city. He advised the digging of a great trench, a khandaq, across the exposed northern approach to Medina, a thing the Arabs did not know in war, and the Prophet ﷺ took the spade with them and dug alongside the poorest, binding stones to his belly against the hunger, by the sound reports, as they worked. When the confederation arrived they found themselves halted before a ditch their cavalry could not cross, and the great army settled into a siege.

The siege was the severest trial the community had yet endured, and the recitation that came down through it, in the chapter of the Confederates, is among the most psychologically exact passages in the whole Book, for it describes not the battle but the fear. *When they came upon you from above you and from below you, and when the eyes shifted in terror and the hearts reached the throats, and you assumed about God every kind of assumption. There the believers were tested and shaken with a severe shaking* (al-Aḥzāb 33:10-11). The hypocrites of the city, the doubters who had professed faith without holding it, began to slip away with excuses, and some sought to spread despair (33:12-13). And in the midst of it the besieged community learned that Banū Qurayzah, the one Jewish tribe remaining under the covenant inside the defenses, had been turned by the chiefs of al-Naḍir and had broken the pact, opening the prospect of an attack from within the walls while the great army pressed from without, the eyes turning aside and the hearts at the throat exactly as the recitation said. The believers held. The recitation records the difference between the two responses to the terror, for when the true believers saw the confederates they said only that this was what God and His Messenger ﷺ had promised them, and it increased them in faith (33:22).

The siege broke not by a charge but by a wind. After weeks in the cold of the desert winter, with their supplies failing and their alliance fraying under the strain and the manoeuvres the Prophet ﷺ set among them to sow distrust, a fierce wind rose against the confederates in the night, tearing up their tents, scattering their fires, and breaking their will, and they struck camp and dispersed in the dark, and the greatest army Arabia had raised melted away without a battle. The recitation named the wind and the unseen hosts as God's own doing. *O you who believe, remember the favor of God upon you when armies came to you and We sent against them a wind and armies you did not see, and God is ever Seeing of what you do* (al-Aḥzāb 33:9), and again, *God turned back those who disbelieved in their rage, they gained no good, and God sufficed the believers in the fighting, and God is ever Powerful and Mighty* (33:25).

With the great army gone, the Prophet ﷺ turned at once to the treason within, to Banū Qurayzah, who had broken the covenant at the moment of the city's greatest danger. They were besieged in their fortresses and surrendered, and they asked that their fate be decided not by the Prophet ﷺ directly but by an arbiter, and they named Sa'd ibn Mu'adh, the chief of the Aws, who had been their old confederate before Islam, trusting that their former ally would be lenient. Sa'd, gravely wounded in the siege and soon to die of his wound, gave his judgment according to the law by which these very tribes lived, the law of the scripture they held, under which the men who made war and broke faith were put to the sword and the women and children taken captive. The recitation records the reckoning as God's act against those who had supported the confederates from their strongholds. *And He brought down those of the People of the Book who supported them from their fortresses, and cast terror into their hearts, so a group you killed and a group you took captive. And He made you inherit their land and their homes and their property* (al-Aḥzāb 33:26-27). The judgment was severe, and it was the judgment of treason in time of siege, rendered by an arbiter the condemned had themselves chosen, under the law of their own scripture. The honest reader holds the severity and the context together, and does not pretend the one away to spare the other. The community had been an arrow's flight from annihilation, betrayed from within at the hour of its greatest peril, and it answered the betrayal as the law of that world answered betrayal, through an arbitration the traitors had selected.

Hudaybiyah

In the sixth year the Prophet ﷺ did a thing his enemies could not have predicted. He announced not a campaign but a pilgrimage, and set out for Mecca with some fourteen hundred believers in the dress of

pilgrims, unarmed but for the traveler's sword, to perform the lesser pilgrimage at the House from which they had been driven. Quraysh, caught between their dread of being seen to bar the Arabs from the sanctuary and their refusal to let the man they had exiled enter in triumph, blocked the road. The Prophet ﷺ turned aside and halted at a place called Ḥudaybiyah on the edge of the sacred precinct, and there his she-camel Qaṣwā' knelt and would not rise, the moment carried in Bukhārī. He said she had not grown stubborn but was restrained by the One who had restrained the elephant from Mecca, and he took it as a sign to make peace rather than force the gate of the sanctuary with blood.

What followed tested the believers harder than any battle. A rumor that the envoy 'Uthmān, sent into Mecca, had been killed brought the Prophet ﷺ to call his people to a pledge beneath a tree, the Pledge of Good Pleasure, the Bay'at al-Riḍwān, in which they swore to stand with him to the death, and the recitation sealed God's pleasure with them in that hour. *Certainly was God pleased with the believers when they pledged to you under the tree, and He knew what was in their hearts, so He sent down tranquility upon them and rewarded them with a near victory* (al-Fath 48:18), and the pledge to the Prophet ﷺ was made a pledge to God Himself, *indeed those who pledge to you, they are but pledging to God, the hand of God is over their hands* (48:10). Then 'Uthmān returned alive, and a treaty was struck, and its terms looked to the believers like a humiliation. There would be a truce of ten years. The believers would turn back this year without entering Mecca, and come the next. Any Meccan who fled to Medina without his guardian's leave would be returned to Mecca, but any believer who deserted to Mecca would not be returned. 'Umar, fierce in his faith, came near to breaking under it, asking the Prophet ﷺ how they could accept disgrace in their religion, and the Prophet ﷺ answered only that he was the servant of God and His Messenger ﷺ and would not disobey Him. The believers, heartsick, were slow even to shave their heads and end the pilgrimage state, until the Prophet ﷺ, on the counsel of his wife Umm Salamah, shaved his own head first and they followed.

On the road back the recitation came down and turned the apparent defeat inside out, opening the chapter of the Victory with words that astonished them. *Indeed We have given you a clear victory* (al-Fath 48:1). And so it proved, for the truce that had seemed a surrender opened the roads, and in the two years of peace that followed, men entered Islam in numbers greater than in all the years of war before it, the faith spreading freely now that the swords were sheathed, so that the historians have called Ḥudaybiyah the greatest victory of all, won without a battle, the patience at the kneeling camel vindicated by the floods of the converted. The recitation even confirmed the true dream that had set the Prophet ﷺ on the road, that the believers would indeed enter the Sacred Mosque in security, their heads shaved, without fear, in God's good time (48:27). The statesman had traded a year's pride for a generation's harvest.

The Letters to the Kings

Secure in the truce, the Prophet ﷺ lifted his eyes past Arabia to the powers of the earth, and sent envoys bearing letters to the kings beyond the peninsula, calling them to the worship of the One God, to Heraclius the emperor of Rome, to Khosrow the king of Persia, to the Negus of Abyssinia, to the Muqawqis the governor of Egypt, and to the Arab rulers of the frontiers. The letters carried the Quranic invitation to common ground with the People of the Book. *Say, O People of the Book, come to a word equal between us and you, that we worship none but God and associate nothing with Him, and that none of us take others as lords besides God* (Āl 'Imrān 3:64). The responses are remembered, and two of them close circles this history opened in its first Book. Heraclius, the emperor who had broken Persia and walked the Cross back to Jerusalem, received the letter and, by the sound and famous report in Bukhārī, summoned the Meccan Abū

Sufyān, then in Syria with a caravan, and questioned him closely about the man who claimed prophecy, his lineage, his followers, whether he ever broke his word, whether his followers increased or fell away. From the answers, that he was of noble lineage, that his followers were the weak and the young and ever-increasing, that none turned back from his religion in displeasure, and that he never broke a covenant, Heraclius concluded that this was indeed the prophet whose coming he had read of, and said that if what he heard were true the man would one day rule the ground beneath his own feet, though the emperor's own people would not let him follow. Khosrow of Persia tore the letter in his pride, and when the Prophet ﷺ heard of it he said that God would tear his kingdom to pieces, and within years the kingdom of Persia was torn to pieces exactly so, the empire that had once held Jerusalem and sacked the Roman east undone, its regalia carried in time to Medina, the bracelets of its king placed on the arm of the Bedouin Surāqah as the Prophet ﷺ had promised on the road of the Hijra. The two exhausted giants of the opening Book reappear here at the hinge of the story, the one recognizing the truth and unable to follow it, the other tearing the summons and torn in turn.

Khaybar

In the seventh year the Prophet ﷺ moved against Khaybar, the great oasis of fortified Jewish settlements to the north that had become a center of hostility, sheltering the expelled chiefs who plotted against Medina. The reduction of its fortresses is remembered for the giving of the banner. On the eve of the assault the Prophet ﷺ said, by the sound report in Bukhārī and Muslim, that he would give the standard the next day to a man who loved God and His Messenger ﷺ and whom God and His Messenger ﷺ loved, and a man through whom God would grant the victory, and the men passed the night wondering who it would be. In the morning he called for ‘Alī, who was suffering in his eyes, and applied his saliva to them so that they were healed at once, and gave him the banner, and by his hand the strongest fortress fell. When Khaybar was taken its people were not expelled but left upon their land as cultivators, surrendering a share of its produce to Medina, an arrangement that became a model, the conquered people of the Book retained on their soil under terms rather than driven from it.

The Opening of Mecca

In the eighth year Quraysh broke the truce of Ḥudaybiyah, for a tribe allied to them attacked a tribe allied to the Prophet ﷺ, with Qurashi help, shedding blood within the sacred precinct. The Prophet ﷺ, the guarantor of his allies, called the believers to arms in secret and marched on Mecca with ten thousand, the largest force he had ever led, before Quraysh even grasped what was coming. The city that had tortured and exiled him, that had marched against him at Badr and Uḥud and the Trench, lay open before an army it could not resist, and Abū Sufyān, the old commander of the wars against him, came out and submitted and accepted Islam. The Prophet ﷺ, in his mercy, declared that whoever entered Abū Sufyān's house was safe, and whoever shut his own door was safe, and whoever entered the sacred Mosque was safe. The army entered Mecca from its several quarters with almost no blood shed, the conquest of the great prize achieved by overwhelming force held in almost complete restraint.

The Prophet ﷺ went to the House, the Ka'ba his ancestor had raised for the One God and his people had filled with idols, and he circled it and entered upon it, and there he did the thing the whole story had been moving toward since the first verses of Quraysh and the Elephant. The sound report of Ibn Mas'ūd in Bukhārī and Muslim records that there were three hundred and sixty idols set around the House, and the

Prophet ﷺ went among them striking them down one after another with the stick in his hand, reciting as each fell the verse of the chapter of the Night Journey, *truth has come and falsehood has vanished, indeed falsehood is ever bound to vanish* (al-Isrā' 17:81), and another verse, *truth has come, and falsehood can neither begin anything nor repeat it* (Saba' 34:49). The House of Abraham (AS) was cleansed of its tenants and returned to the worship of the One for whom it was built. The key of the Ka'ba, which the Prophet ﷺ might have kept for his own clan, he returned to its hereditary keeper, 'Uthmān ibn Ṭalḥah, declaring it a trust. And he climbed onto the roof of the House and had Bilāl, the slave who had said only One under the torturing rock, raise the call to prayer over the conquered city from the roof of the Ka'ba itself, the voice of the freed slave proclaiming the oneness of God from the highest point of Mecca.

Then came the moment that defined the conquest, the moment of mercy over vengeance. The Prophet ﷺ stood before the people of Mecca, his lifelong persecutors, who had done to him and his every cruelty, and who now stood at his mercy with their lives in his hand, and he asked them what they thought he would do with them, and they said they hoped for good, for he was a noble brother and the son of a noble brother. And he answered them with the words the Quran gives to the prophet Joseph (AS) forgiving the brothers who had thrown him in the well, *no blame upon you this day, God will forgive you, and He is the most Merciful of the merciful* (Yūsuf 12:92), and he declared them free. There was no slaughter, no settling of the long accounts of twenty years, no reprisal against the families who had buried his companions and broken his teeth. The conqueror of Mecca pardoned Mecca. And the recitation that came down near this culmination did not exult in triumph but turned the Prophet ﷺ toward humility and the nearness of his own death, the short chapter of Divine Help. *When the help of God has come, and the victory, and you see the people entering the religion of God in crowds, then exalt the praise of your Lord and ask His forgiveness, indeed He is ever accepting of repentance* (al-Naṣr 110). At the summit of his earthly success the command was not to celebrate but to praise God and seek forgiveness, and the perceptive among the companions understood that the chapter announcing the people entering the faith in crowds was also announcing that the Prophet's work was nearly done.

There is a pattern in that summit worth pausing upon, for it runs against the deepest grain of power. The recitation traces the first ruin of all to a single posture, the refusal of the one who would not bow because he reckoned himself the better. *I am better than him. You created me from fire and created him from clay* (al-A'rāf 7:12). It is the pride that takes its own origin for a warrant to stand above the common law of the creature, the self lifted into a god, and it is the root from which every tyranny grows. And here, at the one moment in his life when the Prophet ﷺ held absolute power over those who had wronged him, the city that had tortured and exiled him lying open and helpless in his hand, the recitation turned him not upward into the pride that had felled the first refuser but downward into the dust. He entered Mecca, the reports say, with his head bowed so low upon his mount that it almost touched the saddle, humbled before God in the very hour of his triumph. He took no revenge. He freed those who had earned death. And the word that came down upon the victory was the command to seek forgiveness. The conqueror at his summit did the opposite of what the fallen one had done at his, bowing where the other had refused to bow, ascribing the whole of it to God where the other had claimed it for himself, and the height the Prophet ﷺ reached was reached, exactly, by the lowering.

Hunayn and Taif

The conquest of Mecca was not the end of the year's fighting, for the great tribal confederation of Hawāzin and Thaḳīf, alarmed at the fall of Mecca, gathered to crush the believers before they could consolidate. The

Prophet ﷺ marched out against them with a vast force, twelve thousand now, ten thousand who had taken Mecca and two thousand of the newly submitted Meccans, the largest Muslim army yet. And at the valley of Ḥunayn this great host met its hardest lesson, for some of the men, looking at their own numbers, felt the confidence that comes before a fall, and the recitation names the failing exactly. The enemy, expert archers, had set an ambush in the narrow valley, and at the first onslaught in the dim of dawn the Muslim vanguard broke and the great army turned in rout, the numbers that had pleased them availing nothing. The Prophet ﷺ held his ground on his mule amid the flight, calling the believers back by name, by the bond of the pledge, until the line re-formed around him and turned and broke the enemy. The recitation took the day as a teaching against the pride of numbers. *God has already given you victory in many regions, and on the day of Ḥunayn, when your great number pleased you but availed you nothing at all, and the earth, vast as it is, closed in upon you, and you turned back fleeing. Then God sent down His tranquility upon His Messenger and upon the believers, and sent down soldiers you did not see, and punished those who disbelieved* (al-Tawbah 9:25-26). The victory at Badr had taught them that God gives the few the strength of the many. The near-disaster at Ḥunayn taught them that numbers without God are nothing, and that the tranquility comes down upon the patient, not the proud.

The vast spoils of Ḥunayn produced the last great test of the founding years, a test not of the sword but of the heart, and it fell upon the Anṣār, the Helpers who had given the Prophet ﷺ their city and their lives. In distributing the spoils the Prophet ﷺ gave generously, and especially to the chiefs of Mecca and the tribes newly come to Islam, those the recitation calls the ones whose hearts are to be reconciled, giving the new and the wavering large shares to bind them to the faith, while the Anṣār, who had borne the heat of the years, received little. A murmur arose among the younger Helpers, that the Prophet ﷺ had given to his own people of Quraysh and left them out, and word of it reached him, and he gathered the Anṣār alone and spoke to them words the sound tradition preserves and that the community has never read without emotion. He reminded them that he had come to them rejected and they had sheltered him, poor and they had enriched him, in fear and they had made him safe. Then he asked them whether they were troubled over the goods of this world, the sheep and the camels, by which he sought to bind men newly come to the faith, while he entrusted them, the Anṣār, with Islam itself. Were they not content, he asked, that the people should go back to their homes with the sheep and the camels, while they went back to their homes with the Messenger of God ﷺ. Would it not please them that, while others took the flocks, the Anṣār took the Prophet ﷺ to their houses. And he prayed for the Helpers and the children of the Helpers, until the men wept into their beards and said they were content with God and His Messenger ﷺ as their portion. The spoils were given to others. The Prophet ﷺ was the portion of the Anṣār, and they wept for joy at the trade.

There remained Ṭā'if, the town of Thaqīf that had stoned the Prophet ﷺ and driven him out in the Year of Sorrow, and now its survivors had fled behind their walls. The Prophet ﷺ laid siege to it, but the walls held, and rather than spend his men against them he lifted the siege and withdrew. When his companions asked him to invoke God against Thaqīf he prayed instead for their guidance, asking God to guide Thaqīf and bring them, and within a short time the people of Ṭā'if came of their own accord to Medina and entered Islam, the very town that had pelted him with stones submitting at last by its own feet. The prayer he had made years before at the lowest hour of his life, when the angel of the mountains offered to crush them and he had refused, hoping God would bring forth from their loins those who worshipped Him alone, was answered before his eyes. Mecca was open, the House was cleansed, the great confederations were broken, and the man who had crept out of Mecca by night with a price on his head had returned to it as the master of Arabia, and

pardoned it. Yet the work was not finished. There remained the far northern frontier and the expedition of Tabūk, the year in which the tribes of all Arabia would come to him in delegation, the final pilgrimage in which the religion would be declared complete, and the death that the chapter of Divine Help had quietly foretold. That completion is the matter of the Book that follows.

IV • THE COMPLETION

A work that began in the seam between two empires ended by swallowing them both. The last three years of the Prophet's life carried the message to the edge of the Roman frontier, drew the tribes of all Arabia into the faith in delegation after delegation, and reached its summit in a single pilgrimage and a single verse that declared the religion complete. Then the man who had carried it died, an ordinary human death in the arms of his wife, and the community he had built nearly broke on the shock of it, and was held together by one old friend reciting one verse. Within a few years of his death the people of the barren valley had taken Jerusalem from Rome and Ctesiphon from Persia, and the prophecy with which this history opened, the Romans defeated and then victorious, had given way to a third power neither giant had foreseen. This is the Book of the completion, of the perfected religion, the highest companionship, and the edifice of prophecy sealed with its final brick.

The March to Tabuk

In the ninth year word reached Medina that the Romans were massing on the northern frontier of Arabia for a strike against the new power in the Hijaz, and the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ called the believers to the hardest expedition of his life. It was the march to Tabūk on the edge of Syria, in the burning heat of high summer, across a waterless waste, against the greatest military power on the earth. The tradition called it the army of hardship, the *jaysh al-ʿusrah*, and the recitation used the march as a sieve, separating those whose faith was real from those who had professed it with their tongues. The hypocrites of Medina, who had slipped away at the Trench, now made their excuses to stay behind in the cool of the date-groves rather than march to the heat and the danger, and the chapter of Repentance, *Barāʾah*, came down in this period heavy with their exposure, rebuking those who said do not go forth in the heat, answering that the fire of Hell is hotter, if they would only understand (al-Tawbah 9:81). The recitation pressed the believers to go forth light or heavy and to strive with their wealth and their lives (9:41), and it stripped the excuses of the hypocrites bare one by one.

Three believers stayed behind not from hypocrisy but from a failure of will they could not afterward forgive themselves, and their story is preserved in one of the longest and most searching narrations in Bukhārī, told by one of the three himself, Kaʿb ibn Mālik. He had meant to prepare and march, and had delayed, and delayed again, until the army was gone and he was left behind with no excuse but his own weakness. When the Prophet ﷺ returned, Kaʿb would not lie to him as the hypocrites lied, but confessed plainly that he had no excuse. The Prophet ﷺ commanded that the three be shunned, and for fifty days no one in Medina spoke to them, until the earth, the recitation says, vast as it was, closed in upon them, and their own souls closed in upon them, and they knew there was no refuge from God except in Him. Then the forgiveness came down in the chapter of Repentance, naming the very state of their hearts. *And upon the three who were left behind, until the earth, vast as it was, closed in upon them, and their souls closed in upon them, and they knew there was no refuge from God except toward Him. Then He turned to them in mercy that they might repent. Indeed God is the Accepting of repentance, the Merciful* (al-Tawbah 9:118). Kaʿb said it was the greatest day of his life, the day his name was cleared from heaven. The honesty of the episode is its power, three faithful men who failed, who refused to cover their failure with a lie, and whose long ordeal of being cut off became a verse of mercy in the Book.

At Tabūk no Roman army appeared, the rumored invasion either dissolved or never gathered, and the Prophet ﷺ, having made his show of strength at the frontier, made treaties with the Christian and Jewish

border communities of the north, with the people of Aylah on the gulf and the oasis settlements beyond. They agreed to pay a tribute, the *jizyah*, in exchange for protection and the keeping of their faith, the arrangement the recitation set out for the People of the Book who came under the authority of the believers (al-Tawbah 9:29). The expedition of hardship was the last great campaign the Prophet ﷺ led, and it ended not in battle but in the extension of the new order's protection over the peoples of the frontier. On the return he ordered the destruction of a mosque that a faction of the hypocrites had built not for worship but as a base for division and intrigue, the mosque of harm, the *masjid al-ḍirār*, which the recitation exposed as a thing built upon falsehood, never to be stood in, against the mosque founded upon piety from the first day (al-Tawbah 9:107-108). Even a place of prayer, the recitation taught, is judged by the intention that raises it.

The Year of Delegations

With Mecca fallen and Arabia's great confederations broken, the peninsula made its decision, and it made it by sending its tribes to Medina. The ninth year is remembered as the Year of Delegations, the *ʿĀm al-Wufūd*, in which the tribes of all Arabia sent their representatives to the Prophet ﷺ to accept Islam and enter the new order, delegation following delegation through the year, the long resistance of the peninsula giving way to a flood of submission, exactly as the chapter of Divine Help had foretold, the people entering the religion of God in crowds. The people of Ṭāʾif came, the *Thaqīf* who had stoned him, submitting at last. The tribes of the center and the east and the south came. And among the most significant was the delegation of the Christians of Najrān, the very community whose martyred ancestors the chapter of the Trench had memorialized, who came to debate the nature of Christ with the Prophet ﷺ. When the argument over whether Jesus (AS) was the son of God reached its limit, the recitation proposed a solemn test, the *mubāhalah*, that both parties call down the curse of God upon the liars among them, each bringing their sons and their women. *Then whoever argues with you about it after the knowledge has come to you, say, come, let us call our sons and your sons, our women and your women, ourselves and yourselves, then let us pray earnestly and invoke the curse of God upon the liars* (Āl ʿImrān 3:61). The Prophet ﷺ came out for the imprecation with his own family, his daughter Fāṭimah, her husband ʿAlī, and their two sons, and the Christians of Najrān, seeing the gravity with which he staked his own household on the truth, drew back from the curse and made a treaty instead, agreeing to a tribute and keeping their faith and their churches under the protection of the believers. The community that had been burned for monotheism in the chapter of the Trench was now received in treaty by the bearer of the final monotheism, allowed its religion under a covenant of protection.

The same year the Prophet ﷺ sent Abū Bakr to lead the pilgrimage to Mecca, and behind him sent ʿAlī to proclaim the opening verses of the chapter of Repentance to the assembled pilgrims, the verses that ended forever the old order of idolatrous pilgrimage at the House. They declared a disassociation from the treaties with the idolaters who had broken faith, gave them four months of safe passage, and then closed the sanctuary to idolatry, that after that year no idolater would make the pilgrimage and no one would circle the House naked as the pagans had done. *And a proclamation from God and His Messenger to the people on the day of the greater pilgrimage, that God is free of the idolaters, and so is His Messenger* (al-Tawbah 9:3). The House of Abraham (AS), cleansed of its idols at the conquest, was now cleansed of idolatrous pilgrimage, reserved for the worship of the One alone. The whole movement of the chapters of Quraysh and the Elephant, the sanctuary saved that it might be worshipped at, reached here its completion. The House was the House of the One God again, in stone and in rite both.

The Farewell Pilgrimage

In the tenth year the Prophet ﷺ made the pilgrimage to Mecca that would be his only complete Hajj and his last, and the tradition calls it the Farewell Pilgrimage, the Ḥajjat al-Wadāʿ, for he seemed to know it was a leave-taking. He gathered to himself the greatest assembly of his life, more than a hundred thousand believers from across Arabia, to perform the rites of Abraham (AS) purified and to hear him deliver the summation of all he had brought. On the plain of ʿArafāt, mounted on his camel before the vast gathering, he delivered the sermon that the sources preserve in its substance from many witnesses, and it stands as the charter of the community and the distillation of the message. He declared the blood and the property and the honor of every person sacred and inviolable to every other, as sacred as that day, that month, that city. He placed his foot upon the practices of the age of ignorance and abolished them, the blood-vengeance of the old feuds, beginning with the unavenged blood of his own family, and the usury of the old economy, beginning with the interest owed to his own uncle, taking nothing for himself first so that none could say he spared his own. He charged the believers concerning the rights of women, that they had rights over the men as the men had rights over them, and to treat them with kindness, for they were a trust from God. He declared all believers brothers, no Arab superior to a non-Arab nor a non-Arab to an Arab, no white superior to a black nor a black to a white, except by God-consciousness. And he told them he had left among them that which, if they held fast to it, they would never go astray, the Book of God. Then he asked the great assembly whether he had conveyed the message, and they answered that he had, and he raised his finger to the sky and brought it down upon the people and said, O God, bear witness, three times. The sermon was the message made law for a civilization, the sanctity of life, the equality of souls, the rights of the weak, the end of the old cruelties, and the Book as the abiding guide.

It was on that day, on ʿArafāt, in the midst of the Farewell Pilgrimage, that the verse came down which the community has always held to be the announcement of completion, the seal upon the whole revelation. *This day I have perfected for you your religion, and completed My favor upon you, and approved for you Islam as religion* (al-Mā'idah 5:3). The religion was declared complete. There would be no addition to it, for it wanted nothing. The favor of God upon the believers, begun with the first command to recite in the cave of Ḥirāʾ twenty-three years before, was now full. And the perceptive among the companions wept when they heard it, ʿUmar among them by the reports, for they understood that a thing declared complete and perfect is a thing that is finished, and that the completion of the message meant the nearness of the end of the messenger. The verse of perfection was, to those with ears, also a verse of farewell. The work for which the orphan of Quraysh had been raised up was done.

The Final Illness

The Prophet ﷺ returned to Medina, and within a short time the final illness took him, a fever that grew heavier by the day. The biographers and the sound reports together preserve the signs of leave-taking that gathered about him in those weeks. He went out to the martyrs of Uḥud and prayed over them as one bidding farewell, and he went to the graveyard of al-Baqīʿ in the night and prayed long for the dead, as though he were soon to join them. He told the believers from the pulpit that God had given one of His servants the choice between the goods of this world and what is with Him, and that the servant had chosen what is with God, and Abū Bakr, understanding that the Prophet ﷺ spoke of himself, wept, for he alone grasped that the Prophet ﷺ was announcing his own departure. As the fever worsened the Prophet ﷺ asked the leave of his wives to be nursed in the chamber of ʿĀ'ishah, and they gave it, and there he lay. He distributed the last of

what he had, distressed by the reports to find a few coins still in his keeping that he had not yet given away, unwilling to meet his Lord with hoarded wealth, and he freed his servants. And when he grew too weak to lead the prayers himself, he commanded that Abū Bakr lead the people in prayer in his place, and the community read the sign in it, that the man the Prophet ﷺ set to stand in his place at the prayer was the man to stand in his place over them.

In a last interval of strength he came out, supported between two men, his feet dragging, and sat by Abū Bakr at the prayer, and looked upon the ranks of the believers at their worship, the community he had built from nothing, and the reports say his face shone with what looked like joy at the sight, and he smiled to see them in their rows. It was nearly the last the people saw of him. The sound tradition holds that no prophet dies until he is shown his place in Paradise and then given the choice to remain or to go on, and the Prophet ﷺ, by ‘Ā’ishah’s narration, had been given that choice and had made it.

The Death

He died in the chamber of ‘Ā’ishah, his head resting against her, on a day of the month of Rabī’ al-Awwal in the eleventh year of the Hijra, at the age of sixty-three. The sound reports preserve the small human details of the end with a tenderness that has never faded, the cup of water by him into which he dipped his hand and wiped his face, saying there is no god but God, that death has its agonies, the fresh tooth-stick that he wanted at the last and that ‘Ā’ishah softened for him so that he cleaned his teeth with it in his final hour. And his last words, by her narration, were raised to the choice he had been given, repeating, with the highest companionship, O God, the highest companionship, the rafīq al-a’lā, choosing the company of the prophets and the truthful and the martyrs over the life of this world, until his hand fell and he was gone.

The community shattered. The man who had been the voice of heaven among them, the center of their every day, the leader they had followed out of Mecca and into a hundred dangers, was dead, and many could not bear it or believe it. ‘Umar, the fiercest of them, stood in the mosque and refused to accept it, declaring that the Prophet ﷺ had not died but had gone to his Lord as Moses (AS) had gone, and would return, and threatening any who said he was dead. The faith hung in that hour on a knife’s edge, the grief tipping toward a denial that could have broken the community’s grip on the truth. And it was Abū Bakr who held them. He came in, and went to the chamber, and uncovered the face of the Prophet ﷺ, and kissed him, and wept, and said that he was as good in death as in life. Then he came out into the mosque, and quieted ‘Umar, and spoke to the people the words that have anchored the community in every dark hour since, that whoever had been worshipping Muhammad, let him know that Muhammad was dead, and whoever had been worshipping God, let him know that God is living and never dies. And then he recited the verse that had been revealed at Uhud, when the false cry of the Prophet’s death had nearly broken the army, the verse now landing with the full weight of its true occasion. *Muhammad is but a messenger. Messengers have passed away before him. So if he died or was killed, would you turn back on your heels. And whoever turns back on his heels will never harm God at all, and God will reward the grateful* (Āl ‘Imrān 3:144). And the companions said it was as though they had never heard the verse until Abū Bakr recited it that day, and ‘Umar said his legs would not carry him and he fell to the ground knowing the Prophet ﷺ was truly dead. The faith had been built so that it did not rest on the life of the man who carried it but on the God who sent him, and at the death of the man that foundation held. The community grieved, but it did not break.

Saqifah and the Succession

The Prophet ﷺ left no son who survived him and, by the understanding that prevailed, no explicit written appointment of a successor read out to the whole community, and so the question of who would lead after him fell upon the companions in the very hours after his death, before he was even buried. The Helpers gathered at a roofed hall, the Saqifah of the Banū Sā'idah, to deliberate, and the leading emigrants joined them, and there, after discussion and some tension between the Helpers and the emigrants over where the leadership should rest, the gathering pledged itself to Abū Bakr. He was the companion who had been the Prophet's friend from the first days, the second of the two in the cave, the man he had set to lead the prayers in his illness, and Abū Bakr became the first Khalifah, the first successor, the head of the community after the Prophet ﷺ. The general pledge of the people followed.

The deeper question of the succession, of whether the leadership ought to have passed to the Prophet's nearest kinsman 'Alī and to remain in the house of the Prophet ﷺ, became in the generations that followed the central point of difference between the two great streams of the tradition, and a faithful history records the divergence without arbitrating it, for it is a question of interpretation over which sincere believers have differed since. What the record carries plainly is the event, that Abū Bakr was chosen and pledged to in those first hours and led the community through its first and most dangerous crisis, and that 'Alī, whatever the circumstances and the timing the differing traditions relate, was among the foremost of the companions and would himself in time hold the same office. The Prophet ﷺ was buried where he had died, in the chamber of 'Ā'ishah, beneath the floor of the room, on the principle the companions recalled that a prophet is buried where he passes, and the chamber that had been the place of his death became the place of his rest, and remains so, within the mosque that grew around it.

The Ridda and the Empire That Swallowed the Giants

The death of the Prophet ﷺ was the signal for much of Arabia to test whether the new order would survive its founder, and a wave of apostasy and rebellion broke across the peninsula, the wars the tradition calls the Riddah. Tribes that had submitted to the Prophet ﷺ refused now to pay the zakāt to his successor or fell away from the faith altogether, and a series of false prophets, who had arisen even in the Prophet's last days, gathered the disaffected, Musaylimah in the center of Arabia, who had claimed prophethood and a revelation of his own, Ṭulayḥah among the northern tribes, Sajāḥ in the east, and al-Aswad al-'Ansī in Yemen, the counter-prophets who rose to claim the mantle and divide the inheritance. Abū Bakr, in the most consequential decision of his short rule, refused every compromise and held the community to the whole of what the Prophet ﷺ had established, declaring that he would fight any who tried to separate the prayer from the alms, and he sent the armies of Islam against the rebellions and the false prophets and broke them one after another, Musaylimah falling at the fierce battle of Yamāmah, the peninsula reconsolidated under the faith within little more than a year. The cost of Yamāmah, where many of those who had memorized the recitation by heart were killed, moved the community to its first great act of preservation, the gathering of the scattered written and memorized portions of the Quran into a single collected text under Abū Bakr, a work later standardized and copied under the third successor, 'Uthmān, so that the recitation the Prophet ﷺ had received was secured against loss in one agreed form, the text the believers recite to this day.

With Arabia secured, the armies of the people of the seam turned outward to the two exhausted giants between which this history began, and what followed in a single generation closed the great frame of the

whole story. Under Abū Bakr and then under ‘Umar, the second successor, the believers struck into Roman Syria and Sasanian Iraq at once, and the two empires that had bled each other to exhaustion across the decades this work opened with, depopulated by plague and cold and war, had nothing left to stop them. The Roman army was broken at the Yarmūk in the year 636, and Syria fell, and in 638 Jerusalem itself, the holy city the Persians had sacked and Heraclius had walked the Cross back into, surrendered to the believers, and ‘Umar entered it not in conquering splendor but humbly, by the reports, in worn travelling clothes, and guaranteed its people their lives and their churches and their faith. The Persian army was broken at al-Qādisiyyah, also in the year 636, and Ctesiphon, the capital of the king who had torn the Prophet’s letter, fell, and the regalia and the treasure of the kings of Persia were carried back to Medina, and among the spoils were the bracelets of Khosrow, and ‘Umar called for the old Bedouin Surāqah ibn Mālik, who had pursued the Prophet ﷺ on the road of the Hijra and been promised those very bracelets by a hunted fugitive with a price on his head, and the bracelets of the king of Persia were placed upon the arms of Surāqah, and the promise made on the road of the migration was kept against the treasure of the fallen empire. By the year 642 the back of Sasanian Persia was broken at Nihāwand, and the empire that had held Jerusalem and seemed eternal passed out of history altogether.

The frame closes here, exactly where it opened. The history began with two giants staring across a frontier, certain the only danger was each other, and with a recitation that foretold, when Persia looked invincible, that Rome would be defeated and then would conquer within a few years, and the believers would rejoice on the day of the help of God. The recitation’s prophecy was fulfilled at Nineveh in the Prophet’s lifetime. And then, within a few years of his death, the deeper turn came that no one in the chapter of the Romans had needed to spell out, for the power that rose from the ignored seam between the giants absorbed them both, taking Persia entirely and tearing the Roman east away, the people of the barren valley with the cube of stone in it inheriting the world that the watchers had been too tired to watch. The God who had foretold Rome’s reversal over Persia had been raising, in the gap the empires despised, the third thing that would outlast them.

The Brick

What had been completed was not only a religion and a community but an edifice that the prophets before him had been building across the ages, and the Prophet ﷺ described his own place in it in an image the sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim preserve, the parable of the brick. He likened himself and the prophets who came before him to a man who built a beautiful house and finished it perfectly except for the place of a single brick in one corner, so that people walking around it would marvel at the house and ask only why that one brick had not been set. I am that brick, he said, and I am the Seal of the Prophets. The recitation had named him so, the last of the line, completing what was begun. *Muhammad is not the father of any of your men, but he is the Messenger of God and the Seal of the Prophets, and God is ever, of all things, Knowing* (al-Aḥzāb 33:40). The house of prophecy, raised by Adam and Noah (AS) and Abraham (AS) and Moses (AS) and Jesus (AS) and all the messengers between, stood finished with his coming, the last brick in its place, the favor of God upon mankind completed as the verse on ‘Arafāt had said, the religion perfected and approved.

He had come an orphan into a barren valley in the year his people named for an elephant, and he had been the supplication of Abraham (AS) and the glad tidings of Jesus (AS) and the light his mother saw in the dark. He had spent forty years as the Trustworthy and twenty-three as the Messenger ﷺ, and he had been mocked and tortured out of his own city and had returned to it as its master and pardoned it. He had bound feuding tribes into one community by a creed and a covenant, faced the armies of his people at Badr and Uḥud and

the Trench and outlasted them, and cleansed the House of Abraham (AS) of its three hundred and sixty idols and returned it to the One for whom it was raised. He had received in the highest heaven the prayer that anchors the believer's day, and recited a Book that overturned the moral order of a civilization, and delivered on a plain before a hundred thousand the charter of the sanctity of every life and the equality of every soul, and heard from heaven that the religion was complete. And he had died an ordinary death, his head against his wife, choosing the highest companionship, and the empire of the giants had fallen to the people of his seam within a generation, and the edifice of prophecy stood sealed.

The chronological life is told. What remains is to see the man himself more closely than the march of events allows, the face and the daily rhythm and the household and the mercy of him, and to set out the law he left and the unseen horizon he opened and the chain of prophets he sealed. To those closer portraits the following Books turn, no longer following the calendar but circling the man and the message from the angles the narrative could not pause upon. The statesman has finished his work. The portrait begins.

V • THE LIVING PORTRAIT

The chronicle has shown what he did. This Book shows what he was. The companions who lived beside him preserved his face and his gait and the fragrance of him, the way he ate and dressed and slept, the few things he owned, the jokes he made and the tears he shed, his tenderness with children and animals and the weak, the rhythm of his days, and the worship that ran beneath all of it like a hidden spring. They preserved these because they loved him, and because the recitation had told them that in him was the pattern they were to follow. This is the portrait the lovers drew, set down detail by detail, so that a reader fourteen centuries away might see, as nearly as words allow, the human being through whom the Book came.

The Face and the Form

Those who saw him strained to describe him, and the descriptions they left agree in their portrait of a man of arresting and gentle presence. They were gathered above all in the collection of Tirmidhī known as the *Shamā'il* and scattered through the sound books. He was of middle height, neither tall nor short, yet the companions said that when a tall man walked beside him the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ seemed the taller of the two. His complexion was radiant, neither stark white nor brown but luminous, and the sound reports say his face shone like the moon, and that when he was glad his face brightened until it was as though a piece of the moon shone from it. His hair fell between his ears and his shoulders, black, neither tightly curled nor wholly straight. His eyes were large and dark, the lashes long, with a natural appearance of kohl about them. His brow was broad, his beard full, his teeth slightly spaced, and when he smiled, which was often, the light caught them. Between his shoulders was the Seal of Prophethood, a raised mark of flesh the size of a small egg or a clustered mole, which the companions Jābir ibn Samurah and others reported in the sound collection of Muslim. It was the sign the People of the Book were said to look for, and the boy who would become a companion was lifted as a child to see it.

He walked, the reports say, as though he were descending a slope, leaning forward with purpose, covering the ground swiftly, so that those with him hurried to keep pace. He turned his whole body to face the one who addressed him rather than only his head, giving each person the sense of his full attention. His voice carried. His silences were long and thoughtful. And a particular detail the companions never tired of recording was his fragrance, for they said the scent of him was sweeter than any perfume, that his sweat was like pearls and smelled of musk, and that a street he had passed through kept his fragrance after him so that people knew the Prophet ﷺ had walked there. Anas, who served him as a boy for ten years, said he had never touched silk or brocade softer than the palm of the Prophet ﷺ, nor smelled any scent finer than his.

Among the most beloved of all the descriptions is one given not by a companion but by a Bedouin woman during the Hijra itself, Umm Ma'bad, at whose tent the Prophet ﷺ and Abū Bakr stopped on the road to Medina, and whose account her husband recorded, a portrait carried in the biographical and traditional sources at the weight of its transmission. She described to her husband a man of conspicuous beauty and radiant face, neither thin nor heavy, with dark eyes and long lashes, a resonant voice, a long neck, a full beard. When silent he was dignified, and when speaking he was crowned with light, the sweetest and most striking of men from a distance and the finest and most beautiful up close. His words were clear and measured, neither too few nor too many, falling like a string of pearls, neither overbearing nor weak, and his companions

surrounded him, hanging on his word and rushing to his command. A stranger meeting him for an hour on the road had seen what those who loved him saw across a lifetime.

The Character

Of all that can be said of him the recitation said the highest thing first, before the companions ever drew their portraits, for God Himself testified to his character in a single verse. *And indeed you are of a great character* (al-Qalam 68:4). His character was the foundation of his prophethood, and when his widow ‘Ā’ishah, who knew him as no one else did, was asked to describe that character, she gave the answer the community has treasured above all descriptions, recorded in the sound tradition, that his character was the Quran. He was the recitation walking, the living embodiment of what the Book commanded, and the recitation made him for that reason the pattern every believer was to follow. *There has certainly been for you in the Messenger of God an excellent example, for anyone who hopes in God and the Last Day and remembers God often* (al-Aḥzāb 33:21).

The portrait the companions drew of that character is consistent across hundreds of reports. He was the most humble of men despite being the most honored. He sat among his companions so that a stranger entering could not tell which of them was the Prophet ﷺ, and he disliked men standing for him in deference. He mended his own sandals, patched his own garment, helped with the work of the house, and served himself. He never, the sound reports say, struck a servant or a woman or any creature with his hand, except in the cause of God in battle. He answered the invitation of the poor and the slave, accepted the gift however small, and would not refuse a request he could grant. Anas, who entered his service at the age of about ten and stayed ten years, testified in the sound books that in all that time the Prophet ﷺ never once said to him the smallest word of rebuke, never said why did you do this or why did you not do that, never said even uff, the lightest expression of annoyance in the Arabic tongue. He was more modest, the companions said, than a virgin secluded in her chamber, and when something displeased him they read it only in his face, for he would not shame a man to his face. He kept every promise. He never broke faith, the very trait by which Heraclius recognized him. He was the most truthful of men and would not lie even in jest. And the recitation drew his tenderness toward his community in terms that almost ache, naming his grief at their suffering and his yearning for their wellbeing. *There has certainly come to you a messenger from among yourselves. Grievous to him is what you suffer. Concerned is he over you. To the believers he is kind and merciful* (al-Tawbah 9:128).

The Day and the Night

His day was built upon the prayer, and the prayer threaded it from before dawn to the depth of the night. He rose for the night prayer in the last third of the dark, and after it slept a little, and woke for the dawn prayer, going out to the mosque to lead the believers while the sky was still grey. After the dawn prayer he would sit in the mosque in the remembrance of God until the sun rose, and then turn to the affairs of the community, the judgments, the delegations, the teaching, the gathering of companions who sat in a circle around him drinking in his words. He took the midday rest the Arabs called the qaylūlah, and led the noon and afternoon prayers, and gave his afternoons and evenings to his family, going among the chambers of his wives. After the sunset and night prayers he disliked idle talk and turned early to sleep, that he might rise for the night. He slept on his right side, his hand under his cheek, and had taught a litany for the lying down and the waking,

beginning the night with the Name of God and the verses of refuge and ending it with praise, so that even his sleep was framed in remembrance.

The hidden engine of his days was the night prayer, the tahajjud, which the recitation had made a special charge upon him, *and from the night, pray with it as additional worship for you, that your Lord may raise you to a praised station* (al-Isrā' 17:79). He stood in it so long, the sound reports of Bukhārī and Muslim record, that his feet would swell and crack, and when 'Ā'ishah asked him why he burdened himself so when God had forgiven him all his sins past and to come, he gave the answer that has shamed and inspired the worshippers of every generation since, asking should he not then be a grateful servant. The forgiven one worshipped not from fear of punishment but from gratitude, and his standing through the night was the thanksgiving of a heart that owed everything to its Lord. Through the day his tongue was never still of the remembrance of God, and he sought forgiveness, by the sound reports, seventy times in a day, and by another a hundred times, the sinless one asking pardon more than any sinner, teaching by his own practice that nearness to God is not a possession to rest in but a longing that grows the nearer it comes.

The Table

He ate as a man eats who has set his heart on the next world and not on this one, and the simplicity of his table is among the most striking things the companions preserved, for he was the master of Arabia and lived as its poorest. 'Ā'ishah reported in the sound books that whole months would pass, two and three new moons together, without a fire being lit in the houses of the Prophet ﷺ for cooking, and that they lived in those stretches on the two black things, dates and water, with sometimes a little milk from a neighbor's gift. His family never ate wheat bread to fullness three days running until he died. He never in his life ate at a table laid high, nor from fine dishes, but on the ground, as the poor ate. And he never once, the sound reports of Abū Hurayrah record, found fault with a food set before him. If he had an appetite for it he ate it, and if he disliked it he simply left it, and never said a word of complaint, for to disparage what God had provided was a thing his gratitude would not allow.

He ate with the right hand and with three fingers, and licked them clean when he finished, saying that one does not know in which part of the food the blessing lies. He began with the Name of God and ended with praise of Him, and he taught that the food of one suffices two and the food of two suffices four, urging the sharing of the table. He forbade eating while reclining, eating as a free man sitting upright and not as a king sprawled at his ease, and he taught moderation against the gluttony he saw as a sickness of the soul, saying, in a report the collections carry, that the son of Adam fills no vessel worse than his stomach, and that a few morsels to keep his back straight are enough, and if he must eat more, then a third for his food, a third for his drink, and a third for his breath. He said that the believer eats in one stomach and the ungrateful in seven, the contentment of the grateful heart asking little where the appetite of the heedless never fills. He had foods he loved within that simplicity, the sweetness of honey and the sweetness of dates, and he was fond of the gourd, picking it out from around the dish, and he praised honey as a healing, the recitation itself having named it so, *there comes from within the bee a drink of varying colors, in which is healing for people* (al-Nahl 16:69). His was not the asceticism of one who despised God's gifts, for he received them with thanks and enjoyed the good among them, but the discipline of one who would not be owned by them, who could feast at a wedding and fast for days, and whose heart was anchored past the reach of the table.

The Cloak and the Possessions

His dress was as plain as his table. He wore what was available, wool and cotton and the rough cloth of the Yemen, and he loved white garments above all, saying the believers should wear white and shroud their dead in it. He wore a lower wrap and an upper cloak, a mantle thrown over the shoulders, and a turban whose end he sometimes let fall between his shoulders, and simple sandals with two straps. He kept himself clean and combed and fragrant, for cleanliness and good scent he loved and counted part of faith, but of finery and display he wanted nothing. He wore a single silver ring, engraved in three lines with the words Muhammad, the Messenger, of God, which he used as a seal upon his letters to the kings, and he forbade gold and silk to the men of his community while permitting them to the women.

What he owned in the world could be carried by a few hands. He had his weapons, kept for the defense of the faith, several swords among them the one the tradition names Dhū al-Fiqār, taken at Badr, and bows and shields and a coat of mail, and his war banner, black, that the companions called the Eagle. He had his mounts, horses that he loved and named, the camel Qaṣwāʾ that knelt at Ḥudaybiyah and bore him on the Farewell Pilgrimage, a white mule given him by a foreign king that he called Duldul, and a donkey. He had the household goods of a poor family, a few vessels, a leather water-skin, a mat to sleep on that left its marks pressed into his side, a mattress of palm fiber. And the most eloquent fact of all about his relation to the world is the state in which he left it, for the sound report of ʿĀʾishah in Bukhārī records that when the Prophet ﷺ died, the master of all Arabia, to whom the treasure of the conquered would soon be flowing, his armor was pawned with a Jewish neighbor of Medina as security for a debt of barley he had taken to feed his family, and was not yet redeemed. He had said of himself, in a report the collections carry, that his relation to this world was as a traveler who shelters an hour in the shade of a tree and then rises and leaves it. He died owing barley with his shield in pawn, and left no wealth, only what he gave away.

The Healer's Knowledge

The tradition preserved, alongside his teaching of the soul, a body of guidance for the care of the body, the prophetic medicine the scholars call the ṭibb al-nabawī, and it should be received for what it is. It is the counsel the Prophet ﷺ gave his people on health and healing, part general wisdom of moderation and cleanliness, part specific remedy, and held at the weight the tradition assigns it. He set its first principle as hope, teaching in the sound collection of Muslim that God had sent down no disease without sending down for it a cure, known to those who know it and hidden from those who do not, save one disease for which there is no cure, old age, and so he urged his people to seek treatment and not to despair. He commended particular remedies the Arabs knew, honey above all, which the recitation had named a healing, and he is reported in Bukhārī to have directed a man whose brother suffered in the belly to give him honey, and when the man returned saying it had not helped, to repeat it, saying that God had spoken truly and the man's brother's belly had lied, until the cure took. He praised the small black seed, the ḥabbat al-sawdāʾ, saying in the sound books that in it was a cure for every disease but death. He practiced and recommended cupping, the ḥijāmah, and named days he favored for it. And the spine of all his health counsel was the same moderation he taught at the table, the warning against filling the stomach, the third for food and third for drink and third for breath, for he saw overeating as the root of bodily sickness as he saw heedlessness as the root of the soul's. Alongside the remedies of the body he taught the healing of word and prayer, the recitation of the chapters of refuge over the sick, the ruqyah, breathing the verses upon the ailing, so that the believer met illness with both the means God had placed in creation and the turning of the heart to the One who

placed them. His was a medicine that joined the cure to the Curer, that took the remedy and trusted the Lord, and that met the plague, as the first Book of this work recorded, with quarantine and patience rather than terror and flight.

The Laughter and the Tears

The gravity of his mission did not make him grim, and the companions were careful to preserve his lightness, for they had known a man who smiled more than he laughed and who carried a gentle humor that never once crossed into falsehood. His laughter was mostly a smile that showed his teeth, and he joked with his companions and his family, but when they asked whether he jested with them he answered that he did, but that he spoke only truth even in his jest. So when an old woman asked him to pray that she enter Paradise and he told her, in a report the Shamā'il tradition carries, that no old woman would enter Paradise, and she turned away weeping, he explained gently that the women of Paradise are made young, that none enters it old, the jest true beneath its surprise. When a man asked him for a mount to carry him, he answered that he would carry him on the child of a she-camel, and when the man protested that a camel's child could not bear him, he laughed and asked what else but a she-camel bears a camel, every full-grown mount being the child of one. He called a companion, in play, the father of two ears. And his tenderness with children was without limit. He would prolong his prostration in prayer when his grandsons Ḥasan and Ḥusayn climbed upon his back, not rising until the child climbed down, and he carried them on his shoulders and called them his sweet basil. He noticed the small griefs of children, asking the little brother of Anas, whose pet bird had died, in a phrase the sound books preserve in its very rhyme, Abū 'Umayr, what happened to the little sparrow, comforting a child's loss as gravely as a man's.

And he wept. The same eyes that lit when he smiled overflowed easily, in the night prayer and at the recitation of the Quran and at the death of those he loved. When he asked Ibn Mas'ūd to recite the Quran to him and Ibn Mas'ūd protested that it had been revealed to the Prophet ﷺ and not to him, the Prophet ﷺ said he loved to hear it from another, and as Ibn Mas'ūd recited the chapter of the Women and reached the verse asking how it will be when a witness is brought from every nation and the Prophet ﷺ is brought as a witness against them, he said enough, and Ibn Mas'ūd looked and his eyes were overflowing. When his infant son Ibrāhīm, born to him in his old age of Māriyah, lay dying in his arms, the tears fell from the Prophet's eyes, and a companion, surprised, asked whether even he wept, and he gave the answer that has taught the believers how to grieve, that the eye sheds tears and the heart grieves, but that we say nothing except what pleases our Lord, and that he was sorrowful at the parting. He grieved as a man and submitted as a prophet, and the two were not at war in him, the tears and the surrender held together in one heart.

The Mercy to All Creatures

The recitation had defined his whole purpose in seven words, *and We have not sent you except as a mercy to the worlds* (al-Anbiyā' 21:107), and the worlds his mercy reached included the beasts, in an age and a place that gave animals no thought at all. He taught that there was a reward in every living thing, and the sound books of Bukhārī and Muslim carry his teaching of both edges of it. There was the woman who was punished in Hell on account of a cat she had imprisoned until it starved, neither feeding it nor freeing it to feed itself, and there was the man whose every sin was forgiven because, finding a dog dying of thirst at a well, he climbed down and filled his shoe with water and gave it drink, the Prophet ﷺ saying that in every creature with a

living liver there is a reward. He forbade the overloading of beasts of burden and the leaving of them hungry, and rebuked an owner whose camel, the report in Abū Dāwūd records, complained to the Prophet ﷺ of its hunger and overwork, weeping when the Prophet ﷺ stroked it, so that he turned to the man and asked whether he did not fear God in this animal that God had placed in his hand. He forbade the use of any living thing as a target for sport, the setting of beasts to fight, the branding of an animal on the face, and the killing of any creature beyond need. He told of a prophet before him who burned an anthill in anger over a single ant's bite and was rebuked by God for destroying a whole nation of creatures that glorified Him. He returned the chicks to a distressed bird that fluttered over the companions who had taken them, asking who had grieved this bird for its young. When he commanded the slaughter of animals for food he commanded it be done with mercy, the blade sharpened and hidden from the animal's sight, the killing swift, no beast slaughtered before another.

And his mercy to the weak among people was the same mercy extended, the orphan and the widow and the slave and the poor and the woman, all of whom the world of his birth had counted as nothing. Of the orphan whose burying alive the recitation had condemned, he made a charge of the highest honor, raising two fingers together and saying that he and the one who cares for an orphan would be in Paradise like these two. Of the slaves the markets traded as goods, he said in the sound books that they are your brothers whom God has placed under your hand, so feed them from what you eat and clothe them from what you wear and do not burden them beyond their strength, and if you burden them then help them, and he himself freed his servants and married the freed to the free. He commanded the kindness to women that his civilization had never imagined, charging the men with their good treatment as a trust from God, and made the care of daughters, the very daughters the pagans had buried, a path to Paradise, saying that whoever is tested with daughters and treats them well, they will be a shield for him from the Fire. The mercy to the worlds was not a phrase. It was a man who would not let an ant be burned or a cat be starved or a dog die of thirst or a daughter be despised, in a world that thought none of these worth a thought.

The Households

His domestic life has been examined and misrepresented more than any part of him, and it deserves to be set out plainly and with reverence both. For the first twenty-five years of his marriage he had one wife only, Khadijah, and took no other while she lived, and she was some fifteen years his senior. The plural marriages all came after her death, in the Medinan years, and the great majority of them were marriages of alliance, protection, and instruction, not of appetite. They bound the tribes of Arabia to him through kinship, gave shelter and honor to the widows of fallen companions, and raised up among his wives teachers of the religion who would carry the intimate knowledge of the Prophet's practice to the whole community after him. Through 'Ā'ishah alone, the young wife of his later years who outlived him by decades, came a vast portion of the law and the example, for she had seen him in the privacy of the home as no man could, and the community learned its prayer and its conduct and its fasting in part from what she transmitted. His wives, the Mothers of the Believers as the recitation named them, were Sawdah and 'Ā'ishah and Ḥafṣah, Zaynab bint Khuzaymah who was called the mother of the poor for her charity and died soon after the marriage, Umm Salamah, Zaynab bint Jahsh, Juwayriyah and Umm Ḥabībah and Ṣafīyyah and Maymūnah, and the Coptic Māriyah who bore him Ibrāhīm, several of these the widows of companions or captives freed and honored by marriage, several the daughters of chiefs whose tribes were drawn to the faith by the bond.

Within the house he was, by ‘Ā’ishah’s own report in the sound books, in the service of his family, helping with their work until the call to prayer drew him out, and he was gentle and playful and just among them. The recitation legislated his household as it legislated the community, and two episodes within it became scripture. When his wives, in a season of difficulty, pressed him for more of the comforts of the world than his ascetic house provided, he was commanded to set before them a clear choice, the verse of the choosing. *O Prophet, say to your wives, if you desire the life of this world and its adornment, then come, I will provide for you and release you in a handsome manner. But if you desire God and His Messenger and the home of the Hereafter, then indeed God has prepared for the doers of good among you a great reward* (al-Aḥzāb 33:28-29). He offered them their freedom and the world if they wanted it, and every one of them, beginning with ‘Ā’ishah, chose God and His Messenger ﷺ and the poverty of his house over the comfort he offered to give them. And the marriage that the enemies of the faith have most attacked, his marriage to Zaynab bint Jaḥsh, the divorced wife of his freedman and adopted son Zayd, the recitation itself addressed directly and turned into the abolition of a false custom, for the Arabs held an adopted son’s wife forbidden as a true son’s would be, and God broke that fiction by commanding the very marriage, that the believers might know the wives of their adopted sons were not forbidden to them, adoption conferring love and care but not the lineage and the prohibitions of blood. *So when Zayd had no longer any need of her, We married her to you, in order that there be no discomfort upon the believers concerning the wives of their adopted sons when they no longer have need of them. And the command of God is to be fulfilled* (al-Aḥzāb 33:37). The marriage that the slanderers cast as desire was, in the recitation’s own framing, a legislation against a falsehood, the dismantling of a custom by the Prophet ﷺ submitting to bear the discomfort of it himself.

The gravest trial of his household was the slander cast at ‘Ā’ishah herself, the affair the tradition calls the ifk, the lie. She was left behind by accident on the return from an expedition and brought back to the army by a companion who found her, and the hypocrites of Medina seized on it to whisper a vile accusation against her chastity, and the whisper spread until it tormented the Prophet ﷺ and his family for a month. ‘Ā’ishah wept and fell ill, not knowing the talk at first and then crushed by it, until she could only say, as the prophet Jacob (AS) had said in his grief, that beautiful patience was hers and God’s help was sought against what they described. And her vindication came not from a man’s word but from heaven, the recitation descending to clear her name for all time and to scourge the slanderers, in the chapter of Light. *Indeed those who brought forth the lie are a group among you. Do not think it bad for you, rather it is good for you. For every person among them is what he has earned of the sin, and he who took upon himself the greater part of it will have a great punishment* (al-Nūr 24:11). The recitation declared the slander itself a manifest lie, rebuked the believers who had repeated it without bringing witnesses, and laid down the law of slander against chaste women to protect every woman after her, turning the agony of his own wife into a shield for the honor of all the believing women to the end of time. ‘Ā’ishah said ever after that she had never imagined God would reveal concerning her affair words of the Quran to be recited, so small did she count herself, and that her innocence came down from the seventh heaven.

His children were born almost all to Khadījah, the sons al-Qāsim and ‘Abd Allāh who died in infancy, and the four daughters Zaynab, Ruqayyah, Umm Kulthūm, and Fāṭimah, and his last child Ibrāhīm born of Māriyah in his old age and dying as an infant. He buried, in the course of his life, every one of his children save Fāṭimah, who survived him by only months. Of Fāṭimah, the youngest and dearest, he said that she was a part of him, that whatever angered her angered him, and the love between them was a tenderness the whole community remembered. He who had begun life an orphan, fatherless and then motherless, ended it having buried his wife of a quarter century and six of his seven children, and bore each grief with the submission he

had shown at the deathbed of the infant Ibrāhīm, the eye in tears and the heart grieving and the tongue saying only what pleased its Lord.

The Worshipper

Beneath the statesman and the commander and the lawgiver, beneath the husband and the father and the friend, the foundation of the man was the worshipper, and unless this is seen the portrait is not complete, for everything else he was rested upon his relation to his Lord. He worshipped as no one before or since, and he worshipped despite the assurance, which he alone among men possessed, that he was already forgiven. The night prayer that swelled his feet, the gratitude that answered ‘Ā’ishah’s question, was the center of his hidden life, the long standing in the dark when the world slept, the recitation and the bowing and the prostration drawn out hour upon hour. He fasted often beyond the obligation, the Mondays and the Thursdays, the bright days of the middle of each month, much of the month of Sha‘bān, and the day of ‘Āshūrā’, and in the last ten nights of Ramadan he withdrew into the mosque in seclusion, the i’tikāf, seeking the Night of Power in which the recitation had first descended. His tongue kept the remembrance of God in every state, and he asked forgiveness scores of times a day. And he had said of the prayer itself a thing that reveals the whole orientation of his soul, that the coolness of his eye, the delight and the rest of him, had been placed in the prayer, so that what other men sought in wealth and ease and the comforts of the world he found in standing before his Lord. The Prophet ﷺ who owned nothing and gave away what came to him, who lived on dates and water and died with his shield in pawn, was the richest of men in the only wealth he counted, the nearness to God that he pursued through the night long after he had been promised Paradise.

Seen rightly, his worship was not one province of the man set beside the others, the statesman here and the worshipper there, but the truing of the whole of him to a single measure. The recitation speaks of a balance God set into the very frame of creation. *And the heaven He raised, and He set the balance, that you not transgress within the balance. And establish weight in justice, and do not fall short in the balance* (al-Raḥmān 55:7-9). It is the just proportion by which the heavens are held, and by which a life is held no less. To be God-conscious, to have taqwā, was on this measure to stand true to that order, to bring the inner man and the outer act into one line, so that the prayer in the dark and the justice in the market and the mercy to the beast and the truthfulness in jest were not separate virtues laid side by side but one alignment showing many faces, the single orientation of a self set right with its Lord. And because the measure was God-consciousness and nothing else, the rank it conferred ran by no other currency. The recitation had cut every rival claim away. *O mankind, indeed We created you from a male and a female, and made you peoples and tribes that you may know one another. Indeed the most noble of you in the sight of God is the most God-conscious of you* (al-Ḥujūrāt 49:13). The Prophet ﷺ had said the same from the camel on ‘Arafāt, that no Arab stood above a non-Arab and no white above a black except by the fear of God. The man whose plainness hid him among his companions held the only height the recitation recognized, and he held it by the same taqwā that bowed him lowest.

This was the man, then, that the lovers drew. The radiant face that shone like the moon and the fragrance that lingered in the street. The character that God called great and that ‘Ā’ishah called the Quran, the humility that hid him among his companions, the gentleness that never said uff to a servant in ten years. The day built on prayer and the night given to it, the table of dates and water that he never once disparaged, the single silver ring and the pawned armor, the honey and the black seed and the mercy that met the plague with patience. The smile that showed his teeth and the jest that was always true, the prolonged prostration under a child

climbing his back and the tears at an infant's death, the cat and the dog and the thirsting beast and the despised daughter all gathered under his mercy, the household of honored widows and the wife whose innocence came down from heaven, and beneath it all the worshipper standing in the dark in gratitude. He was the excellent example the recitation named, not a distant ideal but a human being the companions could touch and smell and follow, and they followed him, and they set down what they saw, so that he might be followed still. What this character became when it was made into law, the rights it secured and the justice it rendered and the covenants it kept, is the matter of the Book that follows.

VI • THE COVENANT-KEEPER

A character becomes a civilization only when it is made into law, and the mercy and justice that the previous Book showed in the man, this Book shows in the order he built. He was not only a prophet and a worshipper but a head of state who wrote a constitution, a judge who decided between disputants, a commander who set the laws of war, a maker of treaties who never once broke faith, and a lawgiver who placed fixed rights in the hands of the women and the orphans and the slaves and the poor whom his world had counted as nothing. The recitation that came down across these years came down as legislation, and the legislation bears everywhere the same signature, the binding of the strong and the protection of the weak, justice rendered without regard to status or creed, and the covenant kept absolutely. This is the Book of the law he left, the outward form of the inward man.

The Constitution of Medina

The first act of his statecraft was a written document, and the historians of law have recognized it as a constitution in the full sense, perhaps the first of its kind. It was drawn up in the earliest days of Medina to order a city of feuding tribes and rival faiths into a single polity. The document the sources preserve as the *Ṣaḥīfah* did several things at once that no Arabian custom had done. It declared the believers, emigrant and helper, a single community, an *ummah*, distinct from all others, their primary bond now the faith and not the tribe. It brought the Jewish tribes of the city into one defensive confederation with the believers, naming them a community alongside the believers, with their religion to themselves and the believers' religion to the believers, each bearing its own expenses but all sharing in the defense of Medina against any who attacked it. It abolished the old order in which each clan pursued its own blood-vengeance in isolation, binding the parties of the covenant to stand together against aggression and to ransom their captives in kindness and justice among themselves. And it named the supreme arbitration of the new order, that whatever any of the parties disagreed upon in a serious matter was to be referred to God and to the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. A city of three faiths and warring tribes was made, by a single written instrument, into one polity with one defense, one supreme court of appeal, and freedom of religion for each community in its own affairs. The reordering was radical, and it held, and it became the template for the relation of the new order to the peoples within it.

The Judge

He sat in judgment between people daily, and his judicial practice established principles that the law of the believers would build upon for centuries. The first was that he judged as a man judges, by the evidence presented to him, and that his verdict bound the outward case but could not change the inward truth before God. The sound report in Bukhārī and Muslim preserves his own statement of this, that he was only a human being, and that disputants came to him, and that one of them might be more eloquent in his argument than the other so that the judge ruled in his favor according to what he heard, and that whoever was thereby awarded something of his brother's right by a false plea was awarded only a piece of the Fire, and should not take it. The judge decides by the evidence, and the man who wins a false verdict has won his own damnation. He laid down the burden of proof, that the claimant must bring evidence and the one who denies must swear the oath, the principle that has governed the courts of the believers ever since.

The second principle was that the law was no respecter of persons, and he enforced it against his own most beloved kin in words that became the charter of equal justice. When a woman of the noble clan of Makhzūm was caught in theft and her family, unwilling to see one of their rank punished, sought to have the most beloved of the companions intercede with the Prophet ﷺ to set aside the penalty, he rose in anger, the sound books record, and said that the nations before them had been destroyed precisely because when a noble among them stole they let him go and when a weak one stole they applied the penalty, and he swore by God that if Fātimah the daughter of Muhammad herself were to steal, he would cut off her hand. The law fell on the high and the low alike, and not even the Prophet's own daughter, were she a thief, would be spared it, and not even the dearest companion's intercession would lift it. And the third principle was that justice was owed to every person regardless of faith, that the believer's court was not a partisan instrument for the believers against others. When a Muslim of Medina committed a theft and tried to cast the blame upon an innocent Jew, and his clan sought to use the Prophet's authority to shield their man and condemn the Jew, the recitation itself came down to forbid it and to clear the innocent, commanding the Prophet ﷺ to judge by the truth God had shown him and not to be an advocate for the treacherous. *Indeed We have revealed to you the Book in truth, that you may judge between people by what God has shown you. And do not be an advocate for the deceitful* (al-Nisā' 4:105). The recitation made the standard absolute and named the temptation it forbade, the bending of justice toward one's own. *O you who believe, be persistently standing firm in justice, witnesses for God, even if it be against yourselves or parents and relatives* (al-Nisā' 4:135), and it forbade even the hatred of an enemy as a ground for injustice. *And do not let the hatred of a people lead you to be unjust. Be just, that is nearer to righteousness* (al-Mā'idah 5:8). Justice was owed to the relative and the stranger, the friend and the enemy, the believer and the unbeliever, without exception, for it was owed first to God.

The Sanctity of Blood and Right

The charter he proclaimed on the plain of 'Arafāt at the Farewell Pilgrimage, the inviolability of every person's blood and property and honor, was not a sermon only but the foundation of his law, and it overturned the order of an age in which the strong took the weak's life and goods as a matter of course. He abolished the endless blood-feud of the tribes, in which a single killing could set clans warring for generations, and replaced it with a measured law of justice. The recitation legislated retaliation for murder, the qīṣāṣ, but bounded it strictly against the old excess in which a tribe might kill many for the loss of one, and it opened wide the door to forgiveness and blood-money in place of vengeance, and it named the wisdom of the law in a phrase of compressed brilliance. *And there is for you in legal retribution life, O people of understanding, that you may become righteous* (al-Baqarah 2:179). A known and limited penalty, applied by the community and not by the feud, and openable to mercy, was itself the preservation of life, ending the cycles of escalating vengeance that the old order's lawlessness had fed. And the recitation set the value of the single human life at the value of all life, in words that have no parallel in the codes of the ancient world. *Whoever kills a soul, unless for a soul or for corruption in the land, it is as if he had killed all of mankind. And whoever saves one, it is as if he had saved all of mankind* (al-Mā'idah 5:32). The murder of one was the murder of humanity, and the saving of one was the saving of humanity, and upon that measure the sanctity of blood was built into the law.

The Treaties and the Pledges

He was a maker of covenants, and the fidelity with which he kept them is among the most documented features of his statecraft, attested even by his enemies, for it was the keeping of his word that Heraclius named

as a mark of the true prophet. He bound communities to him by written treaty, the Constitution with the people of Medina, the truce of Ḥudaybiyah with Quraysh whose humiliating terms he honored to the letter though they galled his followers, the covenant with the Christians of Najrān that guaranteed them their faith and their churches and their priests under his protection in exchange for a tribute, the terms with the people of the northern frontier, the settlement with the Jews of Khaybar who remained on their land. And the principle that governed all of them was the absolute keeping of the covenant, a fidelity the recitation made law. *And fulfill the covenant, for the covenant will be questioned* (al-Isrā' 17:34), it commanded, and it opened the chapter of the Table with the same charge, *O you who believe, fulfill the contracts* (al-Mā'idah 5:1). Even where he feared a treaty partner might betray him, he was forbidden to break faith secretly, but commanded to renounce the treaty openly and on equal terms first, so that there could be no treachery on his side. *And if you fear betrayal from a people, throw back to them their treaty on equal terms. Indeed God does not love the treacherous* (al-Anfāl 8:58). And he was commanded to honor in full the treaties of those who had kept faith with him, to their term (al-Tawbah 9:4). The covenant extended its protection over the non-Muslim who lived under the authority of the believers, the dhimmī, the protected person, and the Prophet ﷺ set a fearful guard over that protection in a report the collections carry, declaring that whoever wronged a covenanted person, or burdened him beyond his capacity, or took from him anything without his consent, he himself, the Prophet ﷺ, would be that person's adversary on the Day of Resurrection. The man who broke no covenant with a king made himself, in the next world, the prosecutor of any believer who broke covenant with a protected non-believer.

The Letters and the Wider World

When the truce of Ḥudaybiyah opened a space of peace, he turned his statecraft outward to the powers beyond Arabia, and the letters he sent to Heraclius and Khosrow and the Negus and the governor of Egypt and the Arab kings of the frontiers were instruments at once of religion and of diplomacy, opening formal relations with the empires while calling their rulers to the One God. The letters were sealed with his silver seal, carried by chosen envoys schooled in their delivery, and framed upon the Quranic invitation to the shared ground of monotheism. *Say, O People of the Book, come to a word equal between us and you, that we worship none but God and associate nothing with Him, and that none of us take others as lords besides God* (Āl 'Imrān 3:64). They were the act of a head of state announcing his polity to the world on equal terms, neither cringing before the empires nor needlessly provoking them, and the responses, the emperor's grave recognition and the Persian king's contemptuous tearing, became, as the chronicle has shown, the seeds of the two empires' opposite fates.

The Law of War and Peace

He made war when war was forced upon him, and in making it he established a discipline of restraint that stands centuries ahead of the practice of his age and of ages long after it. The recitation set the cause and the limit together, permitting the fighting of those who fought the believers while forbidding the transgression of bounds. *And fight in the way of God those who fight you, but do not transgress. Indeed God does not like transgressors* (al-Baqarah 2:190). And it made peace the preferred end, commanding the inclining to peace whenever the enemy inclined to it. *And if they incline to peace, then incline to it, and rely upon God* (al-Anfāl 8:61). Within the fighting itself the Prophet ﷺ and the commanders he instructed laid down prohibitions the sound reports preserve, that the non-combatant was not to be touched, no woman killed, no child, no

aged person, no hired laborer, none of the monks and hermits secluded in their cells, that there was to be no mutilation of the dead, no treachery, no breaking of a pledge of safety, no killing of one who had been granted safe-conduct, the amān, that crops and trees and wells were not to be wantonly destroyed, that the enemy's dead were to be left their dignity. And the captive, the recitation taught, was to be fed and clothed, the believers praised for giving their own food to the captive and the orphan and the poor for the love of God, seeking no reward and no thanks (al-Insān 76:8-9). The man who lay among the prisoners of war in the hand of the early Muslims was, by the Prophet's command, to be fed from what his captor ate and clothed from what his captor wore. A law of war that spared the woman and the child and the monk, that forbade mutilation and treachery, that protected the crop and the well, and that fed and clothed the captive, was a thing the ancient world had not seen, and it flowed from the same character that would not let an ant be burned.

The Economy and the Poor

His legislation reached into the wealth of the community and bound it to justice, and at the center of his economic order stood a war on the two evils he saw devouring the poor, the usury that fed on their need and the hoarding that starved their share. The recitation declared usury, the riba by which the lender multiplied his return upon the borrower's distress, a thing against which God and His Messenger ﷺ declared war, in language used nowhere else in the Book. *O you who believe, fear God and give up what remains of interest, if you are believers. And if you do not, then be informed of a war from God and His Messenger* (al-Baqarah 2:278-279), permitting the lender his principal but forbidding him the increase, that he wrong not and be not wronged. And the Prophet ﷺ abolished the usury of the old order at the Farewell Pilgrimage, beginning with the interest owed to his own uncle, taking nothing for his own family first. Against the hoarding of wealth the recitation pronounced a terrible warning, that those who hoard gold and silver and do not spend it in the way of God will have it heated in the fire of Hell and their foreheads and sides and backs branded with it (al-Tawbah 9:34-35). And in place of hoarding it established the right of the poor in the wealth of the rich, the zakāt, not a charity bestowed at whim but a fixed due, a known right, that the recitation located within the very definition of the righteous. *And in their wealth was a known right for the petitioner and the deprived* (al-Dhāriyāt 51:19), and it named the categories upon whom the zakāt must be spent, the poor and the needy and the debtors and the wayfarer and the freeing of slaves and the rest (al-Tawbah 9:60). He commanded honest dealing in trade, fair measure and full weight, and the recitation opened a chapter with woe to the defrauders who take in full measure from people and give them short (al-Muṭaffifīn 83:1-3). And he disowned the cheat altogether, declaring in the sound collection of Muslim, when he thrust his hand into a heap of grain for sale and found it wet beneath the dry surface and the seller admitted the rain had touched it, that the seller ought to have put the wet on top for the buyer to see, and that whoever deceives is not of him. The economy he built was an economy of justice, the increase of usury forbidden, the hoard condemned, the poor given a fixed right, the measure made honest, and the cheat cast out of the community.

The Covenant with the Weak

The deepest and most lasting work of his law was the placing of fixed, enforceable rights into the hands of those whom his world, and most of the world before and long after him, had held as property or as nothing, the women and the orphans and the slaves and the poor. For the women of a society that had buried its daughters and inherited its widows as goods, the recitation legislated a revolution. It gave women a fixed and

guaranteed share of inheritance where they had owned nothing and had themselves been inherited, declaring that for men is a share of what parents and relatives leave, and for women is a share of what parents and relatives leave, a portion made obligatory (al-Nisā' 4:7), and it set out the shares in detail (4:11-12). It made the marriage-gift, the dower, the woman's own property to keep, not a price paid to her guardian. It required her consent to her marriage. And it forbade outright the old practice of inheriting women against their will and of mistreating them to seize back their property, commanding instead that they be lived with in kindness (al-Nisā' 4:19). For the orphan whose property the strong had devoured, it set a fierce guard, commanding the giving of orphans their property and forbidding the exchange of the bad for the good and the consuming of their wealth, and warning that those who consume the property of orphans unjustly consume only fire into their bellies and will burn in a blaze (al-Nisā' 4:10). For the slave it opened every door to freedom, making the freeing of a slave an expiation for sins and a supreme act of virtue, the steep path the recitation praised, the freeing of a neck (al-Balad 90:11-13), and it established the contract of self-purchase by which a slave could buy his own freedom, commanding the masters to make the contract with those slaves who sought it and to give them from the wealth of God (al-Nūr 24:33). And it gathered the whole circle of those owed kindness into a single sweeping command that placed the weak beside the worship of God Himself. *Worship God and associate nothing with Him, and to parents do good, and to relatives, and orphans, and the needy, and the near neighbor, and the distant neighbor, and the companion at your side, and the traveler, and those your right hands possess* (al-Nisā' 4:36). The law was the institution of the mercy the portrait had shown, the same tenderness that returned the bird its chicks and gave the thirsting dog its water now written into the rights of the widow and the orphan and the slave, made binding and enforceable, secured not by the goodwill of the strong but by the command of God.

This, then, was the order he built, the outward form of the inward man. The constitution that made one polity of warring tribes and rival faiths. The justice that fell on the noble thief and the Prophet's own daughter alike and stood firm for the innocent Jew against the guilty Muslim. The sanctity of blood that valued the single life at the value of all life. The covenants kept so absolutely that an emperor knew the prophet by his faithfulness, and the protection thrown over the non-believer under his rule so completely that the Prophet ﷺ made himself the adversary of any who wronged him. The law of war that spared the woman and the monk and fed the captive. The economy that warred on usury and the hoard and gave the poor a fixed right. And the rights placed in the hands of the women and the orphans and the slaves, made law where they had been air. The character whose name was the Quran had become a polity whose law was justice, and the covenant-keeper kept faith with God by keeping faith with every soul his order touched. Yet the law governs the seen world only, the realm of the courts and the markets and the treaties. The Prophet ﷺ also opened a window upon the unseen, upon the realities beyond the reach of the law and the senses, and to that horizon the next Book turns.

VII • THE UNSEEN HORIZON

The law of the previous Book governs the seen world, the courts and the markets and the treaties. But the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ was sent to open a window upon the world the senses cannot reach, the realities behind the veil, and the recitation and the sound tradition carry his testimony to them in detail no other founder of a religion has left. He was taken in a single night above the seven heavens to the Lote Tree of the utmost boundary. He carried back the words in which his Lord speaks of Himself. He described the majesty and the light, the Hour and its signs, the breaking open of the graves and the gathering of all who ever lived, the terror of the standing and the mercy of the intercession, the Basin where the believers drink and the Bridge over the Fire that all must cross, and at the summit of it all the felicity beyond which there is no felicity, the sight of the Face of God. This Book follows him to that horizon. It is written in the register the matter demands, and it holds to what the Book and the sound reports transmit, presenting the imagery in its own power as the tradition received it.

The Ascension

The Night Journey was set in its chronological place in the second Book, the carrying of the Prophet ﷺ from the Sacred Mosque at Mecca to the Farthest Mosque at Jerusalem and the raising of him through the heavens, and the recitation's opening of it was given there, *Glory to the One who took His servant by night from the Sacred Mosque to the Farthest Mosque, whose surroundings We have blessed, to show him of Our signs* (al-Isrā' 17:1). Here the journey is opened to its summit, for it was the single greatest disclosure of the unseen ever granted to a human being, and the chapter of the Star describes its furthest reach in verses of veiled and tremendous restraint. After leading the prophets in prayer at Jerusalem he was raised, by the sound narrations of Bukhārī and Muslim, through the seven heavens, and at each he met a prophet stationed there, Adam in the first and Jesus (AS) and John (AS) in another and Joseph (AS) and Idrīs (AS) and Aaron (AS) and Moses (AS), until at the seventh he came to Abraham (AS) seated against the Frequented House, the Bayt al-Ma'mūr, the heavenly sanctuary that seventy thousand angels enter each day never to return, the celestial pattern of the House on earth that the angels circle as men circle the Ka'ba below.

Beyond the seventh heaven he was brought to the boundary of the created order itself, to the Lote Tree of the utmost limit, the Sidrat al-Muntahā, past which no creature passes, and the chapter of the Star renders what occurred there in language that says everything by withholding everything. *And he certainly saw him in another descent, at the Lote Tree of the Boundary, near it is the Garden of Refuge, when there covered the Lote Tree that which covered it. The sight did not swerve, nor did it transgress. He certainly saw of the greatest signs of his Lord* (al-Najm 53:13-18). Something covered the Lote Tree that the words will not name, a radiance or a host of angels or a glory beyond utterance, and the gaze of the Prophet ﷺ neither turned aside in fear nor strained past its bound in presumption, the perfect courtesy of the seeing, and he saw of the greatest signs of his Lord. The chapter speaks also of a nearness almost beyond the bearing of language, that the Prophet ﷺ drew near and came down, or was drawn near, until he was at the distance of two bow-lengths or nearer, *then he approached and descended, and was at a distance of two bow-lengths or nearer, and He revealed to His servant what He revealed* (al-Najm 53:8-10). What was revealed in that nearness, the recitation leaves sealed.

And it was there, at that summit, that the five daily prayers were ordained, not sent down to the earth by an angel but received by the Prophet ﷺ in the highest place a created being has ever stood, the one ordinance given above all the heavens, fifty at the first that were lightened, on Moses (AS)' counsel and the Prophet's

returning, to five in the doing and fifty in the reward. The believer who stands five times a day stands in the gift brought back from the Lote Tree. As to the deepest question the Ascension raises, whether the Prophet ﷺ saw his Lord with the eye of his head on that night, the companions themselves differed, and the difference is an honored one that the tradition has never forced to a single answer. ‘Ā’ishah held that what he saw at the Lote Tree was Gabriel in his immense angelic form, filling the horizon, and that no eye in this life encompasses God. Others among the companions, Ibn ‘Abbās foremost, held that the Prophet ﷺ was granted a vision of his Lord, whether with the eye or with the heart. The recitation in the chapter of the Star says only that the heart did not lie about what it saw and that the sight did not swerve, and the tradition has been content to leave the seeing where the Book left it, in a reverent silence that affirms the greatness of what was shown without prying into its manner. What is certain is that a son of Adam was carried to the boundary of creation and shown the greatest signs of his Lord, and brought back the prayer and the certainty, and that no one before or after has stood where he stood.

The Words of the Lord

The Prophet ﷺ carried back, and continued to receive, a body of sayings in which God speaks in the first person, the Divine sayings the tradition calls the Ḥadīth Qudsī, distinct from the Quran in their wording yet conveying the speech of God, and through them the unseen Lord discloses His nearness and His mercy in terms of overwhelming intimacy. The greatest of them, preserved in the sound collection of Muslim on the authority of Abū Dharr, has God address His servants directly across the whole of creation, declaring that He has forbidden injustice to Himself and made it forbidden among them, so let them not wrong one another, that all of them are astray but those He guides, so let them seek His guidance, all of them hungry but those He feeds, all of them naked but those He clothes, so let them ask Him, and that were the first of them and the last, the human of them and the jinn, to stand as one upon the most God-conscious heart among them, it would add nothing to His dominion, and were they to stand upon the most wicked, it would take nothing from it, for it is only their own deeds that He counts up for them and then repays them in full, so whoever finds good, let him praise God, and whoever finds otherwise, let him blame only himself. The infinite self-sufficiency of God and the utter dependence of the creature are stated in that saying with a force the philosophers never matched.

And against that majesty the same sayings disclose a tenderness that has no equal. God says, in the sound report of Bukhārī and Muslim, that He is as His servant thinks of Him, and that He is with His servant when the servant remembers Him, and that whoever draws near to Him by a hand's span, He draws near to by an arm's length, and whoever draws near by an arm's length, He draws near to by a fathom, and whoever comes to Him walking, He comes to running. He says that His mercy prevails over His wrath, or precedes it, a saying written, the tradition holds, above His Throne. He tells of dividing mercy into a hundred parts, sending down but one to the whole of creation, by which every mother tends her child and every beast its young, and keeping ninety-nine with Himself for the Day of Resurrection. And He descends, in the saying of the night that Bukhārī and Muslim preserve, in the last third of every night to the nearest heaven, and calls, who is calling upon Me that I may answer him, who is asking of Me that I may give him, who is seeking My forgiveness that I may forgive him, until the dawn. The unseen God of the Prophet's disclosure is not a remote first cause but a Lord who descends in the dark to ask His sleeping servants whether any will turn to Him. And in the saying of the friends of God, the awliyā', in Bukhārī, He declares that He makes war on whoever shows enmity to a friend of His, that His servant draws near to Him by nothing more beloved than

the duties He has made obligatory, and continues to draw near by the voluntary acts of devotion until He loves him, and that when He loves him He becomes the hearing with which he hears and the sight with which he sees and the hand with which he grasps and the foot with which he walks, and that were such a servant to ask Him, He would give, and were he to seek refuge in Him, He would protect him. The servant beloved of God is so wholly governed by God's will that his very faculties move in obedience, the soul so surrendered that the action of God flows through it. The tradition has received these sayings in their full power, affirming the nearness and the descent and the love as God has stated them.

The Light and the Majesty

The Prophet ﷺ disclosed the majesty of the God behind the veil, and the recitation set the seal upon it in the verse the believers have held the greatest in the Book, the Verse of the Throne. *God, there is no deity except Him, the Living, the Sustainer of all. Neither drowsiness overtakes Him nor sleep. To Him belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth. Who is it that can intercede with Him except by His permission. He knows what is before them and what is behind them, and they encompass nothing of His knowledge except what He wills. His Throne extends over the heavens and the earth, and their preservation tires Him not. And He is the Most High, the Most Great* (al-Baqarah 2:255). The Throne over the heavens and the earth, the knowledge that nothing escapes, the sustaining of all things without fatigue, the permission without which not even intercession can be offered, this was the God the Prophet ﷺ proclaimed, named by the most beautiful names, the Merciful, the Sustainer, the Forgiver, the Mighty, the names by which the believer calls upon Him. The recitation set that Throne at the summit of an order made in measured stages, telling that God created the heavens and the earth and all between them in six days and then established Himself over the Throne, the establishing the Book states and does not explain, leaving its manner where it leaves the manner of all His attributes, in a knowledge it does not hand to the creature. *Indeed your Lord is God, who created the heavens and the earth in six days, then established Himself over the Throne. He covers the night with the day, each chasing the other in haste, and the sun and the moon and the stars are subjected by His command. Unquestionably, His is the creation and the command. Blessed is God, the Lord of the worlds* (al-A'raf 7:54). And the recitation marked the deepest difference between this account and the older tellings the Arabs had heard, that the Maker of the six days did not rest upon a seventh, nor tire at all, for weariness belongs to a thing that is itself held up, and He holds all things and is held by none. *And We created the heavens and the earth and what is between them in six days, and no weariness touched Us* (Qāf 50:38). The six days are the making, and the establishment over the Throne is the dominion, and the rest that the older tellings granted their Creator the recitation refuses Him, for the One who holds the heavens and the earth lest they cease has no need to pause. And the Prophet ﷺ described the veil between that God and His creation as a veil of light, saying in the sound collection of Muslim that God does not sleep and that it does not befit Him to sleep, that He lowers the scale and raises it, that the deeds of the night are raised to Him before the deeds of the day and the deeds of the day before the deeds of the night, and that His veil is light, and were He to remove it the glories of His Face would burn away everything of His creation that His sight reached. The Face whose unveiling would consume creation is the Face the believers are promised they will look upon in the Garden, and the distance between those two truths, the burning and the beholding, is the whole mystery of the mercy.

Read to its depth, the Verse of the Throne is not only a proclamation of majesty but the ground of an entire understanding of what it is to exist. The Living, the Sustainer of all, al-Ḥayy al-Qayyūm, is the One who stands by Himself and by whom all else is made to stand. Drowsiness and sleep belong to a thing that is held

up from outside itself, that must pause and be renewed, and the verse strips both from God in one breath, for He is sustained by nothing and sustains everything. Every other thing that is, the heavens and the earth and all that lies between, is carried in being from one moment to the next by a hand it does not see, and would slip back into nothing the instant that holding ceased, as the recitation says elsewhere, that God holds the heavens and the earth lest they cease, and that were they to cease, none could hold them after Him (Fāṭir 35:41). Nothing in creation owns its own existence. The sun does not kindle itself, the heart does not beat by its own command, and the recitation states the truth of it without ornament, that everyone upon the earth will perish, and there remains the Face of your Lord, full of majesty and honor (al-Raḥmān 55:26-27; cf. al-Qaṣaṣ 28:88). He alone is the First, before whom there is nothing, and the Last, after whom there is nothing, the Outer and the Inner (al-Ḥadīd 57:3), and beside Him all things are lent and passing, lit by a light not their own. To see this is the root of the worship the Prophet ﷺ called men to, for the one who knows that he is held every instant above nothing by a Lord who need not hold him turns to that Lord with the whole of himself, and finds Him, as the sayings of the night disclose, nearer than the holding itself.

Behind the veil lay an unseen creation the Prophet ﷺ unveiled in part, the angels who do not disobey God in what He commands and who do as they are commanded, the bearers of the Throne, the recording angels at every person's shoulders, the angel of death, Gabriel of the revelation whom the Prophet ﷺ saw twice in his true form filling the horizon with six hundred wings. He disclosed the jinn, the unseen creation of smokeless fire, a company of whom heard him reciting the Quran and believed, the recitation devoting a chapter to their testimony, *say, it has been revealed to me that a company of the jinn listened, and they said, indeed we have heard an amazing recitation that guides to right conduct, so we have believed in it* (al-Jinn 72:1-2). And he disclosed the writing of the decree, telling that the first thing God created was the Pen and that He commanded it to write, and it wrote all that would be until the Day of Resurrection, the whole of what would come inscribed in the Preserved Tablet that the recitation names as the place of the glorious Quran itself. *Rather, it is a glorious Quran, in a Preserved Tablet* (al-Burūj 85:21-22). Behind the seen world the Prophet ﷺ showed a created order of angels and jinn and a written decree, all of it sustained by the Living who neither slumbers nor sleeps.

The written decree raised at once the question that has tried every people, how a man can be answerable for a deed already written before he was made, and the recitation neither hid the difficulty nor undid it by surrendering one of its sides. It held both at their full strength. The decree is total, for not a leaf falls but He knows it, and there is nothing wet or dry but it is in a clear record (al-An'ām 6:59), and the Pen has written what will be. And the choice is real, for the recitation makes the human deed the very thing the Judgment weighs, lays the turning toward good to God and the turning toward harm to the self, *whatever good befalls you is from God, and whatever evil befalls you is from yourself* (al-Nisā' 4:79), and sets the matter before each soul as a road it must walk by its own feet, *say, the truth is from your Lord, so whoever wills, let him believe, and whoever wills, let him disbelieve* (al-Kahf 18:29). The two are not balanced against each other as rivals, the one stealing what the other claims. The knowing and the writing are God's, encompassing all, and the doing and the earning are the servant's, real enough to be judged, and the recitation closes the circle by setting the human will within the divine and not against it, *and you do not will except that God wills, the Lord of the worlds* (al-Takwīr 81:29). The Prophet ﷺ taught his companions accordingly to labor as though everything turned on their striving and to trust as though everything turned on their Lord, and forbade them to make the decree a pillow for idleness, telling them to act, for each is eased toward that for which he was made. The dignity the recitation gave the human creature was exactly this, that inside a decree which misses nothing he is

still the one who answers, the one whose yes or no is his own to give, the turning that Adam made when he fell and rose, and that the refuser would not.

The Hour and Its Signs

He spoke much of the Hour, the end of the world and the Day of Resurrection, with a certainty about its coming and a refusal to name its time that the recitation made the model of all knowledge of it. When he was asked when the Hour would be, he answered, in the famous report of the angel Gabriel who came in the form of a man to question him before his companions, that the one asked knew no more of it than the questioner, that its time was known to God alone, and the recitation said the same, that the knowledge of the Hour is with God (Luqmān 31:34), and commanded him, when they pressed him about it, to say only that its knowledge is with his Lord (al-Aʿrāf 7:187). But though its hour was hidden, its signs he named, telling Gabriel in the same report that among its tokens would be that the slave-girl would give birth to her mistress, and that the barefoot, naked, destitute herdsmen of the desert would be seen competing in the raising of tall buildings. And he taught that his own coming was itself a sign that the Hour was near, holding up two fingers side by side and saying, in the sound books, that he and the Hour were sent like these two, the nearness of the one finger to the other the nearness of his age to the end.

He described the greater signs that would precede the Hour, the upheavals that the tradition transmits in detail, the appearance of the great deceiver, the false messiah the Dajjāl, who would claim divinity and try the faith of all the earth with his wonders, and the descent of Jesus (AS) son of Mary, the prophet whose place in the chain the next Book will set, who would return to break the cross and slay the deceiver and rule by the law of the final revelation. He told of the release of Gog and Magog, the corrupting hordes whom Dhū al-Qarnayn had walled away in the first Book of this work and whose barrier the recitation said would be leveled when the promise of God came, pouring forth at the end as the recitation foretold (al-Anbiyāʾ 21:96). He named the rising of the sun from its setting place in the west, after which no faith would profit a soul that had not believed before, and the smoke, and the Beast, and the great sinkings of the earth, and the fire that would drive mankind to their final gathering. And then the blowing of the Trumpet, the recitation describing two blasts, the first at which all in the heavens and the earth would fall dead in terror except whom God willed, and the second at which they would rise and stand, looking on. *And the Trumpet will be blown, and whoever is in the heavens and whoever is on the earth will fall dead, except whom God wills. Then it will be blown again, and at once they will be standing, looking on* (al-Zumar 39:68). The world would end, and then the dead of all the ages would stand. The recitation gave that ending an image of a thing rolled shut and put away, *the Day We will fold the heaven like the folding of a scroll for the records. As We began the first creation, We will repeat it, a promise binding upon Us. Indeed, We will do it* (al-Anbiyāʾ 21:104). The sky that had stood spread above every generation as the very figure of permanence would be furled like a written page, and only the One who had spread it would remain.

The Resurrection and the Gathering

The raising of the dead was the doctrine the idolaters of Mecca had mocked above all others, that crumbled bones could live again, and the recitation answered their mockery by pointing to the One who made them the first time. *And he presents for Us an example and forgets his own creation. He says, who will give life to bones while they are decayed. Say, He will give them life who produced them the first time, and He is, of all creation, Knowing* (Yā Sīn 36:78-79). The God who made a man from nothing could remake him from dust, and the

recitation declared He could restore even the fine ridges of his fingertips. *Does man think We will not assemble his bones. Yes, We are able to proportion his fingertips* (al-Qiyāmah 75:3-4). And the Prophet ﷺ described the gathering that would follow the second blast, all who had ever lived raised from their graves and assembled upon one ground, and he described their state in the sound report of ‘Ā’ishah, that they would be gathered barefoot, naked, and uncircumcised as they were first created, and when ‘Ā’ishah, startled, asked whether the men and women would not then look upon one another's nakedness, he answered that the matter of that Day would be too grave, too overwhelming, for any of them to give a thought to such a thing. He described the sun drawn near above the heads of the assembled, the people sunk in their sweat each according to his deeds, the standing prolonged across an immensity of time, the whole of creation halted in dread before the Judgment, none able to speak except by permission. The length of that Day is past all earthly reckoning, for the recitation measures it not in the days of men but in a scale that dwarfs them, naming a Day whose measure is fifty thousand years (al-Ma‘ārij 70:4), and teaching that the very counting of time is not the same before God as it is below. *And they urge you to hasten the punishment. But God will never fail in His promise. And indeed a day with your Lord is like a thousand years of those which you count* (al-Ḥajj 22:47). The measures by which a man weighs his brief life are not the measures of the One before whom he will stand. It is from the agony of that standing, the tradition teaches, that the great intercession would be sought.

The Intercession

The most consoling of all the Prophet's disclosures of the unseen is the great intercession, the Shafā’a al-Kubrā, and he told it in the sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim as a scene that places him above all the prophets at the moment of mankind's greatest need. The people, crushed beyond endurance by the length and terror of the standing, would seek someone to intercede with their Lord to begin the Reckoning and relieve them, and they would go first to Adam, the father of mankind, and ask him to intercede, and he would excuse himself and send them to Noah (AS). And they would go to Noah (AS), and he would excuse himself and send them to Abraham (AS), and Abraham (AS) would send them to Moses (AS), and Moses (AS) to Jesus (AS), each of the greatest prophets saying, in the narration, myself, myself, conscious before that majesty of his own station, until they came at last to Muhammad ﷺ, and he would say, I am for it, I am the one. And he would go and fall in prostration beneath the Throne of his Lord, and God would open upon him praises and glorifications of Himself that the Prophet ﷺ had not known before, and he would remain prostrate until it was said to him, raise your head, ask and you will be given, intercede and your intercession will be accepted. This is the Praised Station, the Maqām Maḥmūd, that the recitation had promised him at the end of the verse of the night prayer, *and from the night, pray with it as additional worship for you, that your Lord may raise you to a Praised Station* (al-Isrā’ 17:79), the station of universal intercession at which the Reckoning of all creation begins by his asking.

His intercession would not end there, for the Prophet ﷺ taught that he would intercede again and again, for the entering of the believers into Paradise, and most movingly for the sinners of his own community. He said in the sound books that every prophet had been given one supplication that God would surely answer, and that each had hastened to use his, but that he had withheld his own, reserving it as an intercession for his community on the Day of Resurrection, so that the dearest gift granted him he had saved not for himself but for them. And he declared, in the report the collections carry, that his intercession was for the people of the grave sins of his community, the very ones who most needed it, that even those of his followers who had fallen into great wrong, so long as they had died upon the faith, would not be abandoned, but reached at the last by

the intercession he had saved for them. The hope of the believer rests in no small part upon that withheld supplication, the prayer the Prophet ﷺ kept back through all his life of need, to spend it on his community when nothing else could save them.

The Basin and the Bridge

He described two things that wait for his community at the crossing into the next world, a mercy and a trial, the Basin and the Bridge. The Basin, the Ḥawḍ, is the great pool granted to the Prophet ﷺ at which his community will drink before the Judgment, and he described it in the sound books in the language of a man who had seen it, its water whiter than milk and sweeter than honey and cooler than snow, its fragrance finer than musk, its cups as many as the stars of the sky, its breadth a month's journey, fed by the heavenly river of abundance, al-Kawthar, the river the recitation gave him in the chapter of that name, *indeed We have granted you al-Kawthar* (al-Kawthar 108:1), and he said that whoever drinks of the Basin a single draught will never thirst again. He told too, with sorrow, that some who claimed to be of his community would be driven away from his Basin for having turned back after him, and that he would say of them, my Lord, they are of my people, and be told that he did not know what they innovated after him.

And he described the Bridge, the Širāt, stretched over the back of Hell, that every soul must cross to reach the Garden, finer, in the narrations, than a hair and sharper than the edge of a sword, over which the people would pass according to their deeds, some like the blink of an eye, some like lightning, some like the wind, some like swift horses, some running, some walking, some crawling, and some snatched by hooks and cast into the Fire below, while the messengers stood at its edge calling out, Lord, deliver, deliver. The believers would cross by their own light, the light the recitation says will run before them and on their right (al-Ḥadīd 57:12), each according to the measure of his faith. And above the crossing the Scales would be set, the Mīzān in which the deeds are weighed, the recitation promising that no soul will be wronged in the least, *and We place the scales of justice for the Day of Resurrection, so no soul will be treated unjustly at all. And if there is even the weight of a mustard seed, We will bring it forth, and sufficient are We as accountant* (al-Anbiyā' 21:47), the one whose scales are heavy with good in a pleasant life and the one whose scales are light in the abyss (al-Qārī'ah 101:6-9). And the books of deeds would be given out, into the right hand of the saved who would call to their companions to come and read their record, and behind the back or into the left hand of the lost (al-Ḥāqqah 69:19-25). The crossing of the next world is, in the Prophet's disclosure, a passage of light and weight and water, the Basin of his mercy before it and the Bridge of the Reckoning across it.

The Garden and the Fire

At the end of the crossing lay the two final abodes, and the Prophet ﷺ described them as the tradition has always described them, in vivid and unflinching imagery, and this Book presents that imagery as he gave it. Of the Fire he spoke as a reality of terrible heat and depth and grief, the recitation naming it the crusher that mounts to the hearts (al-Humazah 104:4-7), and the tradition transmitting its descent and its punishment, a warning held over the heedless and the cruel and the deniers, dwelt upon not for its own sake but as the alternative the mercy labored to spare them. Over the Fire, the recitation says, are nineteen, and in the same breath it discloses that the number itself was set as a trial, a thing the deniers would seize upon and scoff at while it only deepened the certainty of those who believed, the one sign read two ways by two kinds of heart. *Over it are nineteen. And We have made the keepers of the Fire none but angels, and We have not made their*

number except as a trial for those who disbelieve, that those given the Scripture may be certain and those who believe may increase in faith, and that those given the Scripture and the believers may not doubt, and that those in whose hearts is disease and the disbelievers may say, what does God intend by this as an example. Thus does God send astray whom He wills and guide whom He wills. And none knows the soldiers of your Lord but He (al-Muddaththir 74:30-31). The strangeness that hardened the scoffer settled the believer, and the recitation named the number plainly as a thing sent down to divide the two. But it is upon the Garden that the Prophet ﷺ and the recitation lingered, the abode of the merciful named on nearly every page of the Book, the gardens beneath which the rivers flow, the phrase that recurs more than any other promise. He described its levels rising one above another, and named its summit al-Firdaws, the highest Garden beneath the Throne of the Merciful, from which the rivers of all the Garden spring. The recitation described its rivers, *rivers of water unspoiled, and rivers of milk whose taste never changes, and rivers of wine delicious to the drinkers, and rivers of purified honey* (Muhammad 47:15), and its dwellings and its shade and its fruit ever near. And the Prophet ﷺ disclosed a thing about the joy of it that lies past all description, a Divine saying preserved in the sound books in which God declares that He has prepared for His righteous servants what no eye has ever seen, and no ear has ever heard, and what has never crossed the heart of any human being. The deepest pleasure of the Garden is that God removes from the hearts of its people every trace of rancor and grudge they carried, so that they enter it as brothers upon couches facing one another (al-Hijr 15:47), and they say, the recitation records, praise be to God who has removed from us all grief (Fāṭir 35:34), and who fulfilled His promise (al-Zumar 39:74).

And above the rivers and the dwellings and the removal of all grief, at the very summit of the felicity of the Garden, the Prophet ﷺ disclosed the gift beside which all the rest is small, the Vision of the Face of God, and the recitation states it plainly, in the chapter of the Resurrection, in words the tradition has affirmed exactly as they stand. *Faces, that Day, will be radiant, looking at their Lord* (al-Qiyāmah 75:22-23). The radiant faces of the saved will look upon their Lord, and the recitation seals the truth of it from the other side by declaring that the wicked will be veiled from their Lord on that Day (al-Muṭaffifin 83:15), the veiling of the lost the proof of the beholding of the saved, and by promising the doers of good the best reward and something more (Yūnus 10:26), the something more, the ziyādah, that the tradition has always understood as the Vision itself. The Prophet ﷺ described it in the sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim, telling his companions that they would see their Lord on the Day of Resurrection as they see the moon on the night it is full, with no crowding and no doubt and no difficulty in the seeing, plainly and without obstruction. And he taught, in the sound collection of Muslim, that when the people of the Garden have entered it, God will ask them whether they wish Him to give them anything more, and they, having every delight, will not know what more there could be, until He removes the veil, and they look upon His Face, and the Prophet ﷺ said that they will not have been given anything more beloved to them than the looking upon their Lord. The Face whose unveiling in this world would burn away creation is unveiled in the Garden to the radiant faces of the saved, and the beholding of it is the summit of every felicity, the something more, the reward past the reward. The tradition affirms this Vision as the supreme gift, real and granted, holding to the words of the Book without prying into the manner of a seeing that no likeness can capture.

This is the horizon the Prophet ﷺ opened, the world the law of the previous Book could not reach. The Ascension to the Lote Tree and the prayer brought back from the boundary of creation. The words of the Lord who descends in the dark to ask who will turn to Him and whose mercy prevails over His wrath. The majesty of the Throne and the veil of light, the angels and the jinn and the written decree. The Hour whose time is hidden and whose signs were named, the Trumpet and the rising of the dead and the gathering of all

the ages upon one ground. The intercession at the Praised Station where the Reckoning begins by his asking, and the supplication he withheld through all his life to spend upon his community's sinners. The Basin of his mercy and the Bridge of the Reckoning, the Scales and the books of deeds. And at the summit, past the rivers and the dwellings and the removal of every grief, the Vision of the Face, the something more. The Prophet ﷺ who opened this horizon is himself woven through it, the one carried to the Lote Tree, the one who will stand at the Praised Station, the one at whose Basin the believers will drink, the last of the prophets whose stations he passed in his ascent through the heavens. And it is to those prophets, the messengers before him whom he met in the heavens and whose testimony he carried, that the final Book now turns.

VIII • THE CHAIN OF PROPHETS

He did not claim to bring a new religion. He claimed to seal an old one. The recitation he carried placed him at the end of a single line of messengers stretching back to the first man, all of them sent by the one God with the one message, all of them brothers in a brotherhood of prophecy, and his own coming the completion of the house they had been building across the ages. He met them in the heavens on the night of his Ascension, and he spoke of them with a familiarity and a love that the previous Books have touched, and he taught his community to believe in every one of them and to make no division between them. This final Book follows his testimony along that chain, from Adam the first to Jesus the last before him, and arrives at the place the whole work has been moving toward, the Seal of the Prophets, the final brick in the wall, the man foretold by Abraham's prayer and Jesus's glad tidings whose coming completed the favor of God upon mankind.

The One Message

The deepest claim of the recitation about prophecy is that there has only ever been one of it. Every messenger God sent, from the first to the last, brought the same message at its core, the worship of the one God and the rejection of all besides Him, and the recitation states this as the unvarying content of all revelation. *And We sent not before you any messenger except that We revealed to him that there is no deity except Me, so worship Me* (al-Anbiyā' 21:25). To every nation a warner was raised with that single summons, *and We certainly sent into every nation a messenger, saying, worship God and shun false gods* (al-Nahl 16:36). The forms of the law differed from prophet to prophet, the rites and the rulings shaped to each people and each age, but the creed beneath them was one, and the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ expressed the relation of the prophets to one another in an image the sound books preserve, that the prophets are brothers of one father by different mothers, their religion one and their mothers, the differing laws, many. They were a single family carrying a single faith, and so the recitation made belief in all of them a condition of belief in any, the believers professing that they make no distinction between the messengers of God. *The Messenger believes in what has been revealed to him from his Lord, and so do the believers. All of them believe in God and His angels and His books and His messengers, saying we make no distinction between any of His messengers* (al-Baqarah 2:285). To honor Muhammad ﷺ was to honor Moses (AS) and Jesus (AS) and Abraham (AS) and all of them, and to reject any one of the messengers was to break the chain that ran through all of them. The Prophet ﷺ did not come to replace the prophets before him but to seal and confirm them, and his community was bound to love them as he loved them.

That the message was always one, beneath all the differing laws, is the surface of a deeper unity the recitation never tires of pressing. The one God is not one among many, nor the greatest of a company, but the One in the sense the chapter of sincerity gives Him. *Say, He is God, One. God, the Eternal Refuge. He neither begets nor is born, and there is none comparable to Him* (al-Ikhlās 112:1-4), the Source on whom all things hang and to whom all things return, beside whom there is no second power and no rival will. The whole of creation is the single work of that single hand, ordered without seam or flaw, and the recitation dares the eye to find a crack in it. *Who created seven heavens in layers. You do not see in the creation of the Most Merciful any inconsistency. So return your gaze. Do you see any rifts. Then return your gaze twice again. Your sight will come back to you humbled and exhausted* (al-Mulk 67:3-4). Because the Maker is one and His work is one, the worship He calls for is the gathering of the whole self toward Him and away from all besides, and the sin the prophets were every one of them sent to break, the setting up of partners with God, is at root not a mistaken

opinion but a misdirection of the heart, the turning of a face made for the One toward the many. To worship is to orient, and to worship rightly is to orient toward the highest, and there is nothing higher than the One from whom height itself descends. The prophets differed in their centuries and their tongues and their laws, but they stood, all of them, pointing one way, calling a scattered mankind to face again the single Source it had turned from, and the Seal of them gathered the whole long summons into the word that opens the faith, that there is no god but God.

Adam, the First

The chain began with Adam, the first man and the first prophet, whom God created with His own hand and into whom He breathed of His spirit, and whom He taught the names of all things, so that Adam knew what the angels did not. *And He taught Adam the names, all of them, then He showed them to the angels and said, inform Me of the names of these, if you are truthful. They said, glory be to You, we have no knowledge except what You have taught us. You are the Knowing, the Wise. He said, O Adam, inform them of their names* (al-Baqarah 2:31-33). God commanded the angels to prostrate before Adam in honor of the knowledge placed in him, and they prostrated, all but Iblīs, who refused out of pride, claiming superiority as a being of fire over a being of clay, and so fell from grace and became the enemy of Adam's children (al-A'raf 7:11-13). Adam dwelt in the Garden and was tried with the single tree, and he and his wife, deceived by the enemy, ate of it and were sent down to the earth, but Adam did not fall as Iblīs fell, for he turned back to his Lord in immediate repentance, and the recitation gives the prayer of his returning, the prayer of all who sin and turn back. *They said, our Lord, we have wronged ourselves, and if You do not forgive us and have mercy upon us, we will surely be among the losers* (al-A'raf 7:23), and God received his repentance, *then Adam received from his Lord words, and He accepted his repentance, for He is the Accepting of repentance, the Merciful* (al-Baqarah 2:37). The first prophet was also the first penitent, and the pattern of the human story was set in him, the fall and the turning back and the mercy that receives it. The Prophet ﷺ met Adam in the nearest heaven on the night of his Ascension, the father of mankind, who looked to his right and smiled at the souls of the blessed among his descendants and looked to his left and wept at the souls of the wretched. And the Prophet ﷺ spoke of Adam's creation in a report the sound books carry and that the tradition has received as it stands, that God created Adam in His form, and tall, sixty cubits in height, the first of a creation made noble and then humbled and then offered the way back.

That offered way back is the deepest dignity the recitation grants the children of Adam, and it is the very thing that set Adam apart from the one who would not bow. The difference between them was not that the one sinned and the other did not. It was that when Adam was shown his wrong he owned it and turned, while the refuser, shown his, defended it and hardened. The prayer of Adam's returning, set down just above, is the prayer of every soul that comes after him, and the turning it carries is the thing. And the recitation throws that door open to every soul that carries Adam's pattern, calling even those who have wronged themselves past all counting not to despair. *Say, O My servants who have transgressed against themselves, do not despair of the mercy of God. Indeed God forgives all sins. Indeed it is He who is the Forgiving, the Merciful* (al-Zumar 39:53). And the Prophet ﷺ taught that the door of return stays open while life is in a man, that God stretches out His hand by night to receive the one who sinned by day and stretches it out by day to receive the one who sinned by night, until the sun rises from its setting place. To be a child of Adam is to be the creature who can fall and rise again, and the whole recitation is, in one of its faces, the long calling of that

creature home through the door its father was the first to walk, the door that no sin shuts while the heart still beats.

Noah (AS), Abraham (AS), and the Fathers

After Adam the messengers came in succession, and the recitation tells of Noah (AS), the prophet of the long mission, who called his people to the one God for centuries and was met with mockery and refusal, until God commanded the building of the ark and sent the flood upon the deniers and saved Noah (AS) and those who believed, the recitation naming him a grateful servant, *O descendants of those We carried with Noah. Indeed he was a grateful servant* (al-Isrā' 17:3). Noah (AS) was the first of the messengers the tradition calls the people of firm resolve, the ulū al-'azm, the greatest of the prophets who bore the heaviest trials, Noah (AS) and Abraham (AS) and Moses (AS) and Jesus (AS) and Muhammad ﷺ, the five upon whom the chain most strongly rests.

Greatest among the fathers was Abraham (AS), whom God took as an intimate friend, the only one the recitation honors with that name, *and God took Abraham as a friend* (al-Nisā' 4:125). Abraham (AS) is woven through the whole of this work, for it was his House at Mecca that the first Book described and his prayer at its founding that asked God to raise a messenger from his progeny, the prayer the Prophet ﷺ named as his own origin. Abraham (AS) broke the idols of his people with his own hands and was cast into the fire for it, and God commanded the fire to be cool and safe for him, *We said, O fire, be coolness and safety upon Abraham* (al-Anbiyā' 21:69), so that the flame that was meant to consume him did not harm a hair of him. He was tried with the command to sacrifice his son, and he submitted, and his son submitted with him, and at the moment of the knife God ransomed the boy with a great sacrifice, the trial that the recitation records in the chapter of the Ranged Ones and that the pilgrimage of the believers commemorates to this day. *And when he reached with him the age of striving, he said, O my son, I have seen in a dream that I am sacrificing you, so see what you think. He said, O my father, do as you are commanded. You will find me, if God wills, of the patient* (al-Şāffāt 37:102). He built the House with his son Ishmael (AS) and raised its foundations praying for its acceptance, and he was the pattern of the pure monotheist, the ḥanīf, neither Jew nor Christian, whose religion the recitation commanded the Prophet ﷺ himself to follow. The Prophet ﷺ met Abraham (AS) at the seventh heaven, seated against the Frequented House at the summit of creation, and said that of all mankind he himself most resembled Abraham (AS), the friend of God whose prayer had asked for him across the gulf of two thousand years.

Moses (AS), the Speaker

Of all the prophets before him, none is mentioned in the recitation as often as Moses (AS), the prophet to whom God spoke directly, without intermediary, the distinction the recitation marks with a special verb. *And God spoke to Moses directly* (al-Nisā' 4:164). Moses (AS) was raised in the very house of the tyrant Pharaoh who had ordered the slaughter of his people's sons, and God called him from a fire in the desert night, the burning bush, and spoke to him and gave him the staff that became a serpent and the hand that shone white, and sent him to confront Pharaoh who claimed to be a god, the recitation telling the confrontation across many chapters in greater detail than any other prophet's story. *Has the story of Moses reached you, when his Lord called to him in the sacred valley of Ṭuwā* (al-Nāẓi'āt 79:15-16). When Pharaoh pursued the fleeing Israelites to the sea, God parted it for Moses (AS) and his people and drowned Pharaoh and his hosts in it, the

great deliverance the recitation recounts again and again as the type of God's rescue of the oppressed. Moses (AS) received the Torah, the scripture of guidance and light, and went apart to his Lord for forty nights, and it was Moses (AS) who, longing to see the One who spoke to him, asked the request that the Ascension of the Prophet ﷺ would answer differently. *And when Moses came at Our appointed time and his Lord spoke to him, he said, my Lord, show me Yourself, that I may look at You. He said, you will not see Me* (al-A'raf 7:143), and the mountain crumbled at the unveiling and Moses (AS) fell senseless. The vision Moses (AS) sought on the mountain and was not granted in this world, the Prophet ﷺ was carried toward at the Lote Tree, and the believers are promised in the Garden. The Prophet ﷺ met Moses (AS) in the heavens on the night of his Ascension and found him weeping, and when he asked why, Moses (AS) said it was because a young man sent after him would bring more of his community into the Garden than Moses (AS) would of his own, the prophet of the Exodus weeping not from envy but from love of the salvation of souls. And it was Moses (AS) who, in his concern for the Prophet's community, sent him back again and again to ask his Lord to lighten the burden of the fifty prayers, until they were five, so that the daily prayer of every believer carries within it the compassion of Moses (AS) for a people not his own.

David (AS), Solomon (AS), and the Kings

The chain ran on through prophets who were also kings and prophets who were tried in their bodies and their fortunes, and the Prophet ﷺ honored them all. David (AS), to whom God gave the Psalms, the Zabūr, and whom He made a mighty king, and for whom the mountains and the birds were made to echo the praise of God, *and We subjected the mountains to glorify with David, and the birds, and We were doing so* (al-Anbiyā' 21:79), and whose worship the Prophet ﷺ loved above all others, saying that the most beloved fasting to God was the fasting of David (AS), who fasted one day and broke his fast the next, and the most beloved prayer the prayer of David (AS), who slept half the night and prayed a third and slept a sixth. Solomon (AS), the son of David (AS), to whom God gave a kingdom such as none after him would have, the wind subjected to his command and the jinn to his labor and the speech of the birds and the ants made known to him, the recitation telling of the ant that warned its colony of Solomon's (AS) approaching host and of Solomon (AS) who smiled at her speech, and of the queen of Sheba, the Saba of the first Book of this work, whom Solomon (AS) called to the worship of the one God. Job (AS), Ayyūb, the prophet of patience, tried with the loss of his wealth and his children and his health and never ceasing to praise his Lord, the recitation naming him an excellent servant, ever returning to God (al-Anbiyā' 21:83-84). Jonah (AS), Yūnus, who fled his mission in anger and was swallowed by the great fish and called upon his Lord from the threefold darkness of the night and the sea and the belly of the fish, *there is no deity except You, glory be to You, indeed I have been of the wrong-doers* (al-Anbiyā' 21:87), and was answered and delivered, the Prophet ﷺ teaching his humility toward the prophets by saying that no one should claim him better than Jonah (AS) son of Matta. And Joseph (AS), Yūsuf, whose story the recitation calls the most beautiful of stories, thrown into the well by his brothers and sold into slavery and raised by God to power in Egypt and tried with temptation and prison and brought at last to forgive the brothers who had wronged him, the very words of his forgiveness the words the Prophet ﷺ would speak over conquered Mecca, no blame upon you this day.

Jesus (AS), Son of Mary

Among all the prophets before him the recitation gives the fullest and most tender treatment to Jesus (AS), the son of Mary, and his place in the chain must be set out with the care the first Book's account of the Christological wars demands, for the recitation honors Jesus (AS) supremely while refusing him the divinity that the empires around Arabia fought over. He was born of a virgin by the direct creative word of God, the recitation telling of Mary withdrawing in her purity and the angel announcing to her a son though no man had touched her, and of the infant Jesus (AS) speaking from the cradle in defense of his mother, declaring himself the servant of God given the scripture and made a prophet (Maryam 19:30). The recitation names him in terms it gives no other prophet, the Messiah, the Word of God which He bestowed upon Mary, and a spirit from Him, *the Messiah, Jesus son of Mary, was a messenger of God and His word which He conveyed to Mary and a spirit from Him* (al-Nisā' 4:171). God gave him miracles by His permission such as no other prophet was given, that he healed the blind and the leper and gave life to the dead and fashioned from clay the form of a bird and breathed into it so that it became a living bird, all by the permission of God, the recitation careful at every miracle to add that it was by God's leave, lest the gift be mistaken for divinity. *And he will be a messenger to the Children of Israel, saying I have come to you with a sign from your Lord, that I design for you from clay the form of a bird, then I breathe into it and it becomes a bird by the permission of God, and I heal the blind and the leper and give life to the dead by the permission of God* (Āl 'Imrān 3:49). He gathered his disciples, the ḥawāriyyūn, the helpers in the cause of God.

On the central matters the empires had divided over, the recitation is clear. Jesus (AS) was not God, nor the son of God, but the servant and messenger and Word and spirit of God, who himself worshipped the One who sent him. And to the wonder upon which the world had built a godhead, the birth from no father, the recitation gave the answer that dissolved the false inference without diminishing the miracle, setting Jesus (AS) beside the first man as twin signs of a single power. For if a birth without a father proved divinity, then Adam, made with neither father nor mother, would carry the greater claim, and the recitation laid the two side by side and named the principle behind both. *Indeed the likeness of Jesus before God is as the likeness of Adam. He created him from dust, then said to him, Be, and he was* (Āl 'Imrān 3:59). The miracle was real and the inference was false, for God creates by His word alone, needing no father and no means, and when He decrees a thing He has only to say to it Be, and it is. Jesus (AS) was called the Word of God not because he was God but because he was brought to be by the word God speaks over everything that comes into being, the same word that raised Adam from dust and that will raise the dead, and to make of the spoken miracle a second god was to mistake the gift for the Giver, which the recitation refused at every turn. And he was not killed, the recitation declaring that the crucifixion the world believed in did not happen as the world believed, but that it was made to appear so to them, and that God raised Jesus (AS) to Himself. *And they did not kill him, nor did they crucify him, but it was made to appear so to them. And those who differ over it are in doubt about it. They have no knowledge of it except the following of assumption, and they did not kill him for certain. Rather, God raised him to Himself, and God is ever Mighty, Wise* (al-Nisā' 4:157-158). Jesus (AS) was raised, not slain, and he will return at the end of time, as the seventh Book recounted, to break the cross and slay the deceiver and rule by the truth. And it was Jesus (AS), the recitation insists, who gave the clearest of all the prophetic foretellings of the one who would come after, naming him by name, *and giving glad tidings of a messenger to come after me whose name is Aḥmad* (al-Ṣaff 61:6). The Prophet ﷺ spoke of his own nearness to Jesus (AS) in a way he spoke of no other prophet, saying in the sound collections of Bukhārī and Muslim that he was the nearest of all people to Jesus (AS) son of Mary in this world and the next, that the prophets were brothers of one father by different mothers and there had been no prophet between Jesus (AS) and himself.

The chain that had run from Adam through all the messengers reached, in Jesus (AS), the prophet who pointed directly at its end, the brother who announced the coming of the Seal.

The Seal

And the Seal came. The recitation that had named Muhammad ﷺ the last of the prophets gave him a title that closed the chain forever, the Seal of the Prophets, the one after whom no prophet would come, the completion of the line that began with Adam. *Muhammad is not the father of any of your men, but he is the Messenger of God and the Seal of the Prophets, and God is ever, of all things, Knowing* (al-Aḥzāb 33:40). Where the prophets before him had each been sent to a single people for a single age, he was sent to the whole of mankind for the whole of the time remaining, the universality that no prophet before him had claimed, the recitation commanding him to proclaim it. *Say, O mankind, indeed I am the Messenger of God to you all* (al-Aʿrāf 7:158), and again, *and We have not sent you except comprehensively to mankind, as a bringer of good tidings and a warner, but most people do not know* (Sabaʾ 34:28). His mission was not to a tribe or a nation but to the worlds, the mercy to the worlds the recitation had named, the final messenger of the one God to all who would come after.

The recitation discloses that the coming of this final Prophet ﷺ had been written into the chain from the beginning, that God had taken a covenant from the prophets themselves, every one of them, that when the final Messenger came confirming what they had brought, they would believe in him and support him. *And when God took the covenant of the prophets, saying, whatever I give you of Scripture and wisdom, and then a messenger comes to you confirming what is with you, you must believe in him and support him. He said, do you affirm and take upon that My covenant. They said, we affirm it. He said, then bear witness, and I am with you among the witnesses* (Āl ʿImrān 3:81). The whole chain of prophets, by this covenant, pointed forward to the Seal, every one of them pledged in advance to the one who would complete them, so that Abraham's (AS) prayer for a messenger from his progeny and Jesus's (AS) glad tidings of Aḥmad were not isolated foretellings but the keeping of a covenant the prophets had all sworn. And the Prophet ﷺ gave the relation of himself to the prophets before him its final image, the parable of the brick that the fourth Book of this work recorded, the beautiful house built by all the prophets and finished but for the place of a single brick, and he himself that brick, set in its place, the Seal of the Prophets, the house of prophecy complete.

The Final Brick

The whole of this work has been the laying of that brick, and at its end the convergence the first Book described comes fully into view. The world into which he was born had been prepared across a century, the empires bled white, the cities thinned by plague and cold, the southern kingdom that named the Merciful and burned its martyrs, the sanctuary defended against the elephant, the seekers pushing up through the pagan crust toward a dawn they could feel but not see. And into that seam between the exhausted giants came the child who was the supplication of Abraham (AS), the glad tidings of Jesus (AS), and the light his mother saw in the dark, the last brick of a house the prophets had been building since Adam. He lived an orphan and rose to be the Trustworthy. He received the Word in the cave and was driven from his city for it and returned to it as its master and pardoned it. He bound the tribes into one community by a creed and a covenant, faced the armies of his people and outlasted them, and cleansed the House of Abraham (AS) of its three hundred and sixty idols and returned it to the One for whom it was raised. He delivered to his people a law of justice

that bound the strong and freed the weak, and he opened to them a horizon beyond the seen, the Ascension and the intercession and the Vision of the Face. He died an ordinary human death, his head against his wife, choosing the highest companionship, and the recitation he carried declared on the plain of ‘Arafāt before a hundred thousand that the religion was complete and the favor of God upon mankind was full. *This day I have perfected for you your religion, and completed My favor upon you, and approved for you Islam as religion* (al-Mā'idah 5:3).

He was the Seal, the last of the brothers, the prophet whom all the prophets had been pledged to and pointed toward, the brick that finished the house. The chain that began with the first man and ran through Noah (AS) and Abraham (AS) and Moses (AS) and David (AS) and Solomon (AS) and Jonah (AS) and Joseph (AS) and Jesus (AS) and all the messengers between, the single message of the one God carried across the ages by a brotherhood of prophecy, reached its completion in him and was sealed, and after him the house stood finished, wanting nothing, the favor complete and the religion perfected, the mercy to the worlds delivered and the final brick in its place. He had been the supplication of Abraham (AS) and the glad tidings of Jesus (AS), and he became the answer to every prophet and the seal of them all.

The portrait is drawn, the law is set out, the horizon is opened, and the chain is sealed. There remains only to set down, for the reader who would weigh the sources, a brief account of how this life is known and how its reports are graded, and to lay out the calendar of its events in order. To that apparatus the work now turns, the scholarship that stands beneath the reverence, so that what has been told may be both believed and examined. In the Name of the One God, the Lord of the worlds, and peace upon His Messenger, the Seal of the Prophets, Muhammad ﷺ, and upon all the prophets who came before him, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

A CHRONOLOGICAL SYNOPSIS

The dates of the early life, before the Hijra, are traditional and approximate, and the reader should hold them with appropriate openness, particularly around the Year of the Elephant. The dates from the Hijra forward are firm. Years are given in the common era, with the year of the Hijra, the AH, added from the migration onward.

The long wars of Rome and Persia, intermittent across the sixth century, reaching their climax between 602 and 628. The Justinianic plague erupting in 541 and recurring in waves thereafter. The dust-veil and the failed summers beginning in 536, opening the Late Antique cold. The massacre of the Christians of Najrān, around 523, the event behind the Companions of the Trench. The Aksumite conquest of Ḥimyar, around 525, and the rise of Abraha thereafter. Abraha's dam inscription around 548 and his northern campaign recorded around 552.

The Year of the Elephant and the birth of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, by tradition around 570. The death of his mother Āminah when he was about six. The death of his grandfather 'Abd al-Muṭṭalib when he was about eight, and the guardianship of his uncle Abū Ṭālib. His marriage to Khadījah, when he was about twenty-five. The rebuilding of the Ka'ba and the arbitration of the Black Stone, when he was about thirty-five.

The first revelation at the cave of Ḥirā', around 610, when he was about forty. The years of the secret call, then the public call from the hill of Ṣafā, around 613. The Persian sack of Jerusalem in 614, the low point of Rome from which the chapter of the Romans foretold its return. The first migration to Abyssinia, around 615. The boycott of the clan of Hāshim in the valley quarter, roughly 616 to 619. The Year of Sorrow, the deaths of Khadījah and Abū Ṭālib, around 619, and the rejection at Ṭā'if. The Night Journey and the Ascension, in the same season of sorrow by the strong reckoning. The pledges at 'Aqabah, around 620 to 622, and the spread of the faith in Yathrib.

The Hijra to Medina, in 622, the first year of the Islamic calendar, and the writing of the Constitution and the building of the brotherhood. The battle of Nineveh, around 627, at which Heraclius broke Persia and fulfilled the prophecy of the Romans' return. The change of the qibla and the ordaining of the fast of Ramadan, in 2 AH, 624, and in the same year the battle of Badr. The battle of Uḥud, in 3 AH, 625. The battle of the Trench and the reckoning with Banū Qurayṣah, in 5 AH, 627. The treaty of Ḥudaybiyah and the letters to the kings, in 6 AH, 628, and the reduction of Khaybar in 7 AH. The opening of Mecca and the cleansing of the House, in 8 AH, 630, and immediately after it the battle of Ḥunayn and the siege of Ṭā'if.

The expedition to Tabūk, in 9 AH, 630, and the Year of Delegations in which the tribes of Arabia entered the faith, and the delegation of Najrān and the proposed mutual imprecation, and the pilgrimage led by Abū Bakr at which the House was closed to idolatry. The Farewell Pilgrimage, in 10 AH, 632, and the sermon on the plain of 'Arafāt and the verse of the perfection of the religion. The death of the Prophet ﷺ in the chamber of 'Ā'ishah, in the month of Rabī' al-Awwal of 11 AH, 632, at the age of sixty-three, and the gathering at the Saqīfah and the succession of Abū Bakr, and the wars of the apostasy that followed and the first gathering of the Quran into one collected text.

The conquests that closed the frame. The breaking of the Roman army at the Yarmūk and the breaking of the Persian army at al-Qādisiyyah, both in the year 636. The surrender of Jerusalem to the believers in 638. The final breaking of Sasanian Persia at Nihāwand, around 642, and the passing of the empire of Khosrow out of

history, and the bracelets of its king placed upon the arm of Surāqah, as the Prophet ﷺ had promised on the road of the Hijra. Within a single generation of the death, the people of the seam between the two exhausted giants had inherited the world the giants had emptied, and the long convergence with which this history opened had reached its end.

A NOTE ON THE SOURCES AND THEIR GRADING

This life has been told reverently, but it has not been told credulously, and a reader is owed a plain account of how it is known and how its reports have been weighed, for the strength of a biography rests on the honesty with which it grades its own evidence. The material for the life of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ does not arrive at one level of certainty. It arrives in tiers, and this work has tried throughout to signal which tier a given statement stands upon, so that the reader may both believe what is secure and examine what is held more loosely.

The highest tier is the Quran itself. It is, for the believer and as a matter of textual transmission, the verbatim record of the revelation, carried from the first by mass parallel transmission, memorized entire by many in every generation, gathered into one secured text within years of the Prophet's death, and standing today as it stood then. Where this work renders a verse, it does so in the present author's own faithful English rather than reproducing at length any single existing translation, both to respect the rights of the translators whose work fills the libraries and to let the meaning be carried plainly. A rendering is an approximation and not the Arabic, and a reader who would weigh a verse closely should return to the original. The Quran is the firmest ground in the whole account, and where it speaks to an event, its word has been treated as the load-bearing testimony.

Beneath the Quran stands the Hadith, the transmitted record of the Prophet's words and deeds, and the Hadith is itself tiered. The mass-transmitted reports, the *mutawātir*, carried by so many independent chains that collusion in error is not credible, approach the certainty of the Quran. Below them are the sound reports, the *ṣaḥīḥ*, authenticated by the rigorous science the early scholars built for examining the chains of transmission, the reports gathered above all in the collections of Bukhārī and Muslim and the other accepted books, and these this work has cited by their collections and treated as strong evidence. Below the sound are the good reports, the *ḥasan*, weaker in their chains but acceptable, and below those the weak, the *ḍaʿīf*, which carry little weight and have been used here, where at all, only with their weakness marked. Where this work paraphrases the meaning of a hadith rather than quoting it at length, the same principle governs as with the Quran, the avoidance of reproducing extended copyrighted translations and the carrying of the sense in plain words, with the collection named so the reader may find the original and weigh its chain.

Beneath the Hadith stands the biographical tradition proper, the *sīra* and the *maghāzī*, the narrative life assembled by the early biographers, Ibn Ishāq in the recension of Ibn Hishām, and al-Wāqidī, and the great history of al-Ṭabarī, and the others. This material is the source of much of the connected story, the scenes and the sequences and the human detail that the Hadith collections, organized by legal and devotional topic, do not supply. But it is a lower tier of certainty, for the biographers gathered their reports with a looser standard than the hadith critics applied, and their chains are often weaker or incomplete, and their narratives sometimes carry the shaping and the embellishment of the storyteller's art. This work has drawn on the *sīra* freely, for without it there is no connected life, but it has tried to mark *sīra*-grade material as such, with phrases noting that the biographers transmit, or that the report carries the weight of its genre, so that the reader does not mistake a vivid biographical scene for a verse or a sound report. The episode of the monk Baḥīrā, the detailed scene of ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib before Abraha, the spider and the doves at the mouth of the cave, the precise figures in several of the battles, these and their like are *sīra*-grade, valuable and beloved and lower in certainty than the Quran and the sound Hadith, and they have been held at that weight.

Standing apart from all of these, neither confirming the tradition from within nor bound by it, is the external evidence, the inscriptions and the archaeology and the contemporary records of the surrounding civilizations. The Ḥimyarite inscriptions that name the Merciful two centuries before the Hijra, the inscriptions of Abraha at the Marib dam and at Murayghan, the Syriac and Greek records of the Najrān massacre, the chronicles of the Roman and Persian wars, these are evidence of a different kind, and this work has used them both to corroborate the tradition where they support it and to complicate it honestly where they strain against it. The clearest instance of the strain is the chronology of Abraha, whose datable activity in the late 540s and early 550s sits some two decades before the traditional date of the Year of the Elephant and the Prophet's birth, a tension this work laid plainly on the table in its first Book rather than hiding it, holding the secure core, the calamity of the Elephant and the divine defense of the House affirmed by the Quran and the sound report, distinct from the looser content, the exact date and its synchronization with the birth, which remains a matter of careful estimate.

That distinction, between the secure core of an event and the details held more loosely, has been the governing method of this work throughout, applied to the contested episodes by name. The disputed report of the high cranes was set down as existing in the conversation of the sources and judged unsound in its chains, with nothing of substance resting upon it. The numbers and fine details transmitted about the reckoning with Banū Qurayzah were typed as *sīra*-grade while the broad event was noted as referenced in the Quran, the severity and the context of wartime treason held together without apology and without inflation. The shared Late Antique literary horizon behind the Quranic account of Dhū al-Qarnayn was acknowledged openly, the existence of a common motif-world distinguished carefully from the metaphysical status of the revelation, which the tracing of a motif cannot adjudicate. In each case the aim was the same, to present what the sources say, to grade them honestly, and to let reverence and rigor stand together rather than forcing the one to silence the other. The life of the Prophet ﷺ does not need to be defended by the suppression of evidence, and a faith that rests on the secure ground of the Quran and the sound Hadith is not threatened by the honest acknowledgment that the biographical details vary in their certainty.

A word, last, on the manner of reading these sources, and the Quran above them all. To grade a report is to ask whether it is sound, and that asking is the exterior discipline this note has described. But the Quran asks of its reader a second labor beside the first, an interior one, that he not pass over its verses as a man passes over a load he carries without grasping what is in it, but that he ponder them and turn them and let them open. It names this labor of itself. *Will they not then ponder the Quran, or are there locks upon their hearts* (Muhammad 47:24). It calls itself *a Book We have sent down to you, blessed, that they may ponder its verses and that those of understanding may be reminded* (Ṣād 38:29). And it points to its own seamlessness as the mark of its origin, *do they not ponder the Quran. Had it been from other than God, they would have found within it much contradiction* (al-Nisā' 4:82). The text holds a depth that is not spent on a first reading, and it says as much when it names its Author the First and the Last, the Outer and the Inner (al-Ḥadīd 57:3), the One who is at once the surface of every meaning and the ground beneath it. This work has read the life by the grading of its reports, which is the exterior discipline. Where the matter allowed, it has tried also to read for the depth the Quran asks of its reader, holding the two together, the soundness of the chain and the pondering of the word, so that what is told may be at once examined and entered.

It is for this reason that the work does not close upon the transmitted record. The eight Books and this note have drawn the life from the soundest reports the tradition preserves, graded as honestly as the evidence allows, and the synopsis above orders what those reports establish. Yet every tier beneath the Quran reaches the reader through chains of human memory, strong but not infallible in the sound and the mass-transmitted

alike, and weaker still in the biographical record beneath them. One source alone is wholly immune, secured from the first against the slip of transmission by the parallel memorization of multitudes, and standing today as it stood then. The final volume turns to that source by itself. Setting the transmitted report aside, it draws the portrait of the Prophet ﷺ from the Quran alone, by the plain sense of its words and the trilateral roots that carry them and its own usage as the interpreter of itself, and lets the one text that cannot err speak the man. What the graded sources reconstruct from without, the Quran utters from within, and it is fitting that a life woven throughout with the recitation should close in the recitation's own unaided voice.

IX • SERVANT AND SEAL

The Quranic portraiture of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ between exaltation and accountability. The volumes before this one drew the life from the soundest transmitted record, the strongest the historian holds, yet no chain of men is wholly immune from the errors of its transmission. One source alone is. This final volume sets the transmitted report aside and draws the portrait of the Prophet ﷺ from the Quran itself, read by its own words and its own usage, and lets the one text that cannot err speak the man. A study in Quranic prophetology.

Abstract

The Quran's address to the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ moves across a graded register, from the exaltation of his office to the insistence on his created humanity. The same sūra that raises him to a cosmic station will often return him, within a few verses, to the condition of a mortal under judgment. At the summit he is the mercy to the worlds, the seal of prophecy, the one upon whom God and the angels invoke blessing, and the bearer of names that are elsewhere the names of God. At the same time he is told that he is only a human being, that he holds no knowledge of the unseen, that he commands no power over outcomes, and he is reproved for particular acts and commanded to seek forgiveness. This study treats the two reaches as a single motif and argues that the portrait is internally coherent. Two features unify it. The first is that the Quran locates the source of the Prophet's ﷺ authority outside himself at every turn, so that his greatness is a greatness of reception and conveyance rather than of autonomous origin. The point reaches its limit where his own act is named the act of God, the throw that is God's throwing and the hand pledged to him that is the hand of God. The second is that the reproaches and the commands to seek forgiveness do not compete with his rank but constitute it, on the model of the Quran's own Adam, honored above the angels not for impeccability but for the capacity to recognize error and to turn back. A further register sets his endowment beside that of the earlier prophets. Where Moses (AS) was given the staff and the parted sea, and Jesus (AS) the healing breath and the titles of Word and Spirit, the sign of the Prophet ﷺ is the recited Book, and he is presented as the one they foretold and as the seal, in the root sense of the certifying and completing mark, set upon their line. The paper proceeds in three movements, each theme set in a three-part table of elevation, neutral, and warning. Nine registers draw the portrait. Four read it contested, the charge that he fabricated the revelation, the demand that he produce spectacle, and the refusal of the People of the Book who had awaited him, each answered from the same text and traced to one root, the envy that resents a gift given to another. Seven read the servant under trial, the slander and the law awaited and the bounded knowledge and the frown and the firmness and the unseen audience and the hidden enemy and his own vulnerability, and in each of them the resolution descends from God and not from him. Throughout it reads the principal terms at the level of their triliteral roots, illuminated where a sense is not plain by the same root's use elsewhere, taking the Quran as its governing source and interpreting it by its own usage. It concludes that veneration and accountability in the Quranic portrait of the Prophet ﷺ are two faces of one theology of the servant-prophet. Read to its end, that same servanthood turns the portrait outward. The seal upon the prophets, taken at its root as the mark that ratifies and completes rather than the mark that merely ends, closes the office of revelation while leaving open the road of the servant the prophets exemplify and the trials make concrete, the road the Prophet ﷺ himself walked by turning to God in every crisis. Its very protection, the refuge of the closing sūras, is a word given to every believer alike, and the study closes by reading that road as the text leaves it, a path held open to whoever will walk it and an invitation rather than a wall.

1. Introduction

The Quran does not address the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in a single voice. Across the text he is named, described, and spoken to along a spectrum that runs from the exaltation of his office to the affirmation of his created humanity. At one pole stand the titles that gather the highest honor. He is the mercy sent to all the worlds, the seal who closes the line of prophecy, a lamp that gives light, the one upon whom God and the angels themselves invoke blessing, and he is named with words that the Quran elsewhere reserves for its Lord. At the other pole stand the verses that strip every such elevation back to its created ground. He is told to announce that he is only a human being, that he holds no knowledge of the unseen, that he commands no power to benefit or harm even himself, that he will die as those before him died. Between these poles the Quran also speaks of him in a plain functional register, as a warner and a bringer of good news, a man among the people to whom he is sent.

The upper reach of this spectrum became, across the centuries, the material of devotion, elaborated in praise. The lower reach is no less present in the text. The emphasis on the Prophet's ﷺ humanity, his bashariyya, recurs throughout, and the verses that reprove him are direct and numerous enough that the tradition gathered them under a name, the reproaches of the Prophet, *ʿitāb al-nabī*. The two reaches are usually read apart, the one as honor and the other as a difficulty to be managed. This study reads them together, as one motif, and it reads the Quran by the Quran. The text supplies its own frame for holding exaltation and accountability in a single hand, and that frame is followed here rather than any imported one.

The thesis is that the portrait coheres, and that it coheres through two features of the text. The first is that the Quran locates the source of the Prophet's ﷺ authority outside himself at every turn. His very name, *Muḥammad*, is a passive form from the root ḥ-m-d, to praise: he is the one who is praised, not the one who praises, and the praise flows to him from a higher source that bears the same root. He is *rasūl*, from r-s-l, the one sent, dispatched by a sender. He is *ʿabd*, from ʿ-b-d, the servant, the title the Quran chooses for him at the height of his ascent. His greatness, read at the root, is everywhere a greatness of reception and conveyance, never of an autonomous origin he carries in himself. The point reaches its sharpest expression, examined in Sections 6 and 23, in the verses where his own act is named the act of God: of the throw at the battle of Badr, "you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17), and of the pledge of allegiance sworn to him, "the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10).

The second feature concerns the reproaches. The Quran's commands to the Prophet ﷺ to seek forgiveness, and its direct corrections of his conduct, do not sit in tension with his standing. They instantiate it. The controlling paradigm is the Quran's own account of Adam, honored above the angels not because he cannot err but because, having erred, he recognizes the error and turns back to his Lord, where the refusing party errs and justifies itself rather than returning. On this logic the Prophet's ﷺ corrigibility is not a subtraction from his rank but its mechanism, and the Quran marks the point by issuing the command to seek forgiveness at the very summit of his victory.

To this point the portrait is the one the Quran draws of him. The text also preserves the portrait as it was contested, and the second movement of the study reads that record. His hearers could not agree what he was, calling him poet and sorcerer and madman and forger. They prescribed the spectacle a messenger must bring, a visible God, a book from the sky, an angel at his side. And the People of the Book, who had awaited him and knew him, refused him when he came because the grace had fallen outside their lineage. The Quran answers each contest from the same text and then names its single root. The rejection of the prophets, the demand for

wonders, the envy of the chosen, and at the last the fracturing of the one religion into sects, are traced to one cause, baghy, the envy that resents a gift given to another, and the diagnosis is turned, in the end, upon the believers themselves.

The text met him not only as drawn and as contested but as tried. The third movement reads the crises of his life: the slander against his house, the woman whose plea he could not answer, the questions that probed the limit of his knowledge, the frown he was reproved for and the firmness he was held by, the unseen audience and the staked confrontation, the hidden enemy and the law of the struggle, and his own vulnerability to harm. In every one the resolution descends from God and is not produced by him, and the trials return, under fire, the finding the portrait had drawn at rest, that his greatness is a greatness of reception, and that what he is given he does not generate.

These features, traced through the registers of all three movements and gathered in the synthesis, open of themselves onto a further question, and the study takes it up in Section 24 before the conclusion. The highest of the Prophet's ﷺ titles is khātām, the seal, and once the seal is read at its root as the mark that ratifies and completes rather than the mark that merely ends, the portrait raises of itself the question of what that seal closes and what it leaves open, and of what a portrait of the servant-prophet, so read, holds out to the one who comes to it. The portrait and the contest brought against it are set out first. The question they raise is answered last, from the same text and by the same method.

A word on method and sources. This study foregrounds the Quranic text in its plain semantic and lexical sense, reading the trilateral roots that carry the meaning directly from the Arabic, following a key root through its other occurrences where its sense in a given verse is not plain, and interpreting the Quran by its own usage. Where the text attributes a fault or issues a correction, the fault and the correction are presented as the text gives them, without recourse to the later doctrinal harmonizations that sought to soften them. The evidence is the Quran itself, cited by sūra and verse. The English wording has been checked against the standard translations listed in the References, and the renderings given here are the author's own. The historical occasions reported in the biographical literature are noted only where the text itself requires a setting, and the analysis does not depend on them.

The body falls into three movements, and every table reads its theme under the same three registers, how it appears under elevation, under a neutral or functional treatment, and under warning, accountability, and criticism. The first proceeds through nine thematic registers of the portrait as the Quran draws it. The second proceeds through four registers of the portrait contested, the charges his hearers pressed and the answers the recitation returned. The third proceeds through seven registers of the servant under trial, the crises of his life and their resolution from above. A short discussion precedes every table, and each table closes with the principal term and its root. Section 2 defines the three registers before the analysis begins.

2. The Three Registers of Address

The columns that organize the tables below name three registers in which the Quran speaks of the Prophet ﷺ. They are analytic categories, drawn to make the motif legible, and the text does not always observe their borders cleanly. A single term can carry more than one charge at once, as the discussion of 'abd in Section 3 and of the throw at Badr in Section 6 will show. With that caution the three registers may be defined as follows.

The register of elevation gathers the titles and statements that raise the Prophet's ﷺ office to a cosmic or salvific dimension. It includes the great honorific names, the affirmations of his terminal and universal place, the declarations that bind obedience to him to obedience to God, and the marks of singular divine favor toward his person: the protection from his enemies, the consolation offered in his distress, the oath sworn by his life, the reorientation of the qibla to his unspoken wish, the abundance granted after his loss. These are read here as elevation because they single him out as the object of a care and a station granted to no one else, even though their grammar, examined closely, keeps the favor on the side of the Giver.

The register of neutral or functional address gathers the designations that state the Prophet's ﷺ role without exalting or diminishing it, together with the plainly descriptive statements of his humanity, the regulation of his daily and domestic life, and the ethical instruction directed to him as it would be to any believer. Here he is the warner, the bringer of good news, the reciter of what is sent down, a man from among the people. The dominant grammatical form in this register is the imperative *qul*, "say," which introduces his speech hundreds of times and frames his office as the conveyance of a received word.

The register of warning, accountability, and criticism gathers the verses that fix the Prophet ﷺ as a created and accountable mortal. It includes the categorical statements of his humanity, the limits set on his power and his knowledge and his agency, the exposure of his fear and his grief, the direct reproaches, the explicit attribution of fault with the commands to seek forgiveness, the conditional threats of the severest kind, the warnings of betrayal he cannot himself detect, and the deficits noted in comparison with earlier prophets. This is the register in which the Quran most plainly portrays the Prophet ﷺ in a manner that is corrective or limiting, and the present study reports those portrayals directly rather than dissolving them.

3. Theme One: Naming and Designation

The Quran's names for the Prophet ﷺ array themselves across all three registers, and the array is itself instructive. At the summit are the cosmic titles. He is *Khātām al-Nabiyyīn*, the Seal of the Prophets, the one in whom the prophetic succession is confirmed and brought to its completion (33:40), a title examined at its root in Section 10. He is *raḥmātan lil-ʿālamīn*, a mercy to the worlds, sent as mercy rather than merely bringing it (21:107). He is a radiant lamp, *sirājān munīran* (33:46). The honor rises higher still. God Himself, with the angels, invokes blessing upon him, "God and His angels send blessings upon the Prophet" (33:56), and his very renown is lifted, "and We raised high for you your remembrance" (94:4). He is named, moreover, with words the Quran elsewhere reserves for its Lord, "to the believers most kind and most merciful," *bil-mu'minīna ra'ūfun raḥīm* (9:128), where *ra'ūf* and *raḥīm* are two of the divine attributes, here predicated of the Prophet ﷺ. The two proper names sit on a single root. *Muḥammad* and *Aḥmad* both derive from ḥ-m-d, to praise, the first an intensive passive participle, the one repeatedly praised, the second an elative, most worthy of praise, placed in the Quran in the mouth of Jesus (AS) as a prophecy (61:6). Read at the root, the names are receptive. They mark him as the recipient of praise, not its origin.

In the neutral register stand the functional designations that name what he does. He is *al-Nabī*, the Prophet, and *al-Rasūl*, the Messenger, the sent one carrying a message. He is *bashīr wa nadhīr*, a bringer of good news and a warner (2:119; 34:28). One structural feature of the address belongs here and is easily missed. Every other prophet named in the Quran is at some point called by his personal name in direct address: Adam, Noah (AS), Abraham (AS), Moses (AS), Jesus (AS), David (AS). The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is never once addressed as "O Muhammad." To his face the Quran uses only the office, "O Prophet," "O Messenger." His

personal name appears only in the third person, in statements about him. The veiling of the name behind the title is itself a form of honor, and it sits quietly within the otherwise plain functional register.

In the register of warning and grounding stand the designations that return him to his created condition. The most categorical is the command to declare his humanity, "Say: I am only a human being like you, to whom it is revealed" (18:110). The differentiating clause is the revelation, not the substance of the man, who is basharun mithlukum, human like his hearers. The same register includes the verse that spends his one proper name on a reminder of his mortality and his replaceability in function, "Muhammad is no more than a messenger; messengers have passed away before him" (3:144). And it includes the title 'abd, servant, which the text deploys at the very height of his experience, in the opening of the Night Journey, "Glory be to the One who took His servant by night" (17:1). Here the analytic borders blur, for 'abd is at once the mark of his nearness, the servant carried to the highest place, and the deepest grounding, the one who is owned and who serves. The ascent is named by the servitude. One further root binds the registers together. The word for his humanity, bashar, and the word for his function as herald, bashīr, share the root b-sh-r. The flesh that can be addressed as mortal and the office of bringing good news are spelled from the same three consonants.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Titles raising his office to a cosmic and salvific dimension, including names elsewhere reserved for God.	Designations naming his prophetic function without exalting or diminishing it.	Names and declarations fixing him as a created, owned, and accountable mortal.
Context	Chiefly Medinan affirmations of his terminal and universal status, and of the honor God shows him.	Recurrent statements defining the mechanics of the mission.	Grounding statements, several set against demands to deify him.
Principal verses	al-Aḥzāb 33:40; al-Anbiyā' 21:107; al-Tawba 9:128; al-Aḥzāb 33:56	al-Baqara 2:119; Saba' 34:28	al-Kahf 18:110; Āl 'Imrān 3:144; al-Isrā' 17:1
Snippet	"the Messenger of God and the Seal of the Prophets" (33:40); "to the believers most kind and most merciful" (9:128); "God and His angels send blessings upon the Prophet" (33:56)	"We have sent you to all mankind only as a bringer of good news and a warner" (34:28)	"Say: I am only a human being like you, to whom it is revealed" (18:110); "Muhammad is no more than a messenger" (3:144)
Key term (root)	khātam (kh-t-m: to seal, certify, complete); ra'ūf (r-'-f: tender kindness); raḥīm (r-ḥ-m: womb, mercy)	rasūl (r-s-l: to send); nadhīr (n-dh-r: to warn)	bashar (b-sh-r: skin, flesh, humanity); 'abd ('-b-d: to serve, worship)

4. Theme Two: Authority and Obedience

The elevation of the Prophet's ﷺ authority is among the strongest in the Quran. Obedience to him is identified with obedience to God, "Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed God" (4:80). His judgment is made the test of faith itself, in an oath sworn by God on God's own name, "But no, by your Lord, they will not believe until they make you judge in what is disputed between them, and then find no resistance within themselves to what you decide, and submit fully" (4:65). Once he and God have decided a matter, the believer retains no choice in it (33:36). What he gives is to be taken and what he forbids is to be left (59:7). And the claim runs deeper than command, "The Prophet has a greater claim on the believers than they have on their own selves" (33:6).

Even at this height, one feature of the grammar holds. The authority is always conjoined and always named second. The formula is "God and His Messenger," never the Messenger standing alone as the ultimate source, and the decree of 33:36 is "once God and His Messenger have decided," with God first. The binding force is delegated. This is consistent with the wider pattern of the portrait, in which the Prophet ﷺ is the channel of an authority whose origin lies beyond him.

The neutral register defines the limit of his mandate at the point of delivery. He is a reminder and no more, "So remind; you are only a reminder" (88:21). His responsibility ends at conveyance, "The Messenger's duty is only to convey" (5:99). The register of warning then caps the authority explicitly. He is not a tyrant or compeller over the people, and he is not their controller, "You are not a controller over them" (88:22). He is not their guardian or keeper. And the Quran corrects specific exercises of his judgment. It reproves a decision taken over captives of war (8:67) and notes that only a prior decree spared him a severe consequence for it (8:68). It warns him, in a matter of judgment, "do not be an advocate for the treacherous" (4:105). The authority is real and binding, and it is also bounded, delegated, and subject to correction.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Obedience to him bound to obedience to God; his rulings made binding; a claim on the believers above their own.	His office defined as conveyance; no power to compel assent.	Authority capped: not a tyrant or controller, not a guarantor of outcomes; specific corrections of his judgment.
Context	Establishing his juridical authority and the duty of inward submission.	Marking the limit of his mandate at delivery.	Restraining overreach; correcting a ransom decision and a near-miscarriage of judgment.
Principal verses	al-Nisā' 4:80; al-Nisā' 4:65; al-Aḥzāb 33:6	al-Ghāshiyā 88:21; al-Mā'idā 5:99	al-Ghāshiyā 88:22; al-Anfāl 8:67-68; al-Nisā' 4:105
Snippet	"Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed God" (4:80); "they will not believe until they make you judge" (4:65)	"you are only a reminder" (88:21); "the Messenger's duty is only to convey" (5:99)	"you are not a controller over them" (88:22); "do not be an advocate for the treacherous" (4:105)
Key term (root)	awlā ('-w-l: priority, greater claim); ḥakama (ḥ-k-m: to judge, govern)	balāgh (b-l-gh: to reach, convey); mudhakkir (dh-k-r: to remind)	muṣayṭir (ṣ-ṭ-r: to dominate, oversee); khaṣīm (kh-ṣ-m: advocate, disputant)

5. Theme Three: Knowledge and the Unseen

The Prophet's ﷺ access to the unseen is presented under all three registers, and the registers together yield a precise position. In elevation, the Quran grants him a disclosure withheld from others, "Knower of the unseen, He discloses His unseen to no one, except a messenger whom He has approved" (72:26-27). It records the supreme vision in which he drew near, "at two bow-lengths' distance or nearer," and in which "the heart did not lie about what it saw" and "the sight did not swerve, nor did it transgress" (53:8-17). It even grants him knowledge of events still to come. Against all appearances it foretells that the defeated Romans "after their defeat will be victorious within a few years" (30:2-4), a disclosure of the future placed in his mouth before the event. In the neutral register he is the reciter of what is sent down, the conveyor of a received word, "it is nothing but a revelation revealed" (53:4).

The register of warning then sets the boundary, and the boundary is sharp. He has no autonomous access to the unseen, no treasures, no angelic nature, "Say: I do not say to you that I possess the treasures of God, nor

that I know the unseen, nor do I say to you that I am an angel" (6:50). Had he known the unseen, he says, he would have secured every advantage and suffered no harm (7:188). He does not know his own outcome (46:9), nor the timing of the Hour (7:187). He did not know, before the revelation came, what the Book or the faith was (42:52). His knowledge is incomplete and still arriving, and he is told to pray for its increase, "say: My Lord, increase me in knowledge" (20:114). He is forbidden to hurry the recitation as it descends, to control the very intake of the word (75:16). And the revelation that comes is not his to alter, "Say: It is not for me to change it of my own accord; I only follow what is revealed to me" (10:15). The pattern that unifies the three registers is exact. What knowledge he has of the unseen, and of the future, is granted to him by selection, not possessed or governed by him in his own right.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	A singular disclosure granted; the supreme vision; foreknowledge of an event still to come.	His epistemic role as reciter of the revelation he receives.	No autonomous access to the unseen, no foreknowledge of his fate or the Hour; the revelation not his to alter.
Context	The Ascension passage, the descent of revelation, and a prophecy set before its event.	Defining him as the conveyor of a received word.	Answering demands that he display omniscience; disciplining his haste; barring any change to the word.
Principal verses	al-Jinn 72:26-27; al-Najm 53:8-17; al-Rūm 30:2-4	al-Najm 53:4	al-An'ām 6:50; al-A'rāf 7:188; al-Aḥqāf 46:9; Yūnus 10:15
Snippet	"He discloses His unseen to no one, except a messenger whom He has approved" (72:26-27); "after their defeat they will be victorious within a few years" (30:3-4)	"it is nothing but a revelation revealed" (53:4)	"I do not know the unseen, nor am I an angel" (6:50); "it is not for me to change it of my own accord" (10:15)
Key term (root)	ghayb (gh-y-b: the hidden, absent); irtaḍā (r-ḍ-w: to approve)	tilāwa (t-l-w: to recite, follow)	ghayb (gh-y-b: the hidden); baddala (b-d-l: to change, exchange)

6. Theme Four: Power, Miracle, and the Limits of Agency

The Quran surrounds the Prophet ﷺ with marks of singular divine favor, which belong to the register of elevation because they single his person out for protection and deliverance. God undertakes to shield him, "God will protect you from the people" (5:67). A plot against his life is met and turned (8:30). At the most dangerous hour of the emigration the Quran records a tranquility sent down upon him (9:40). His mission itself is framed as a universal mercy. And at the decisive moments his own act is named the act of God. Of the gesture that scattered the enemy at Badr, the text says, "you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17). Of the pledge of allegiance sworn to him under the tree, "those who pledge to you pledge only to God; the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10). These verses stand at the meeting point of the two registers. They are at once the highest exaltation, his hand and his throw made the very vehicle of divine action, and the most complete grounding, for the act is credited not to him but to God. In the neutral register he is the bearer of a recited sign, defined by the functions of warning and good tidings, "We have sent you only as a bringer of good news and a warner" (25:56).

The register of warning then denies him the capacities that earlier prophets displayed and that his adversaries demanded of him. When they ask for gushing springs, a house of gold, an ascent into the sky, the answer reduces him to his created station, "Say: Glory to my Lord. Am I anything but a human messen-

ger?" (17:90-93). His sign is the recited Book, not a wonder produced on demand. He cannot even produce guidance in those he loves, "Indeed, you do not guide whom you love, but God guides whom He wills" (28:56). He holds no power to secure benefit or to repel harm for his own person (7:188). And the revelation itself is not his possession but a trust held at the Giver's discretion, "And if We willed, We could take away that which We have revealed to you" (17:86). His agency is bounded on every side, and the deliverance, the throw, and the pledge alike are referred to God. The favor reaches its height precisely where the boundary between his action and God's is declared permeable, and even there the action is God's.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Marks of singular favor: protection, deliverance, and his very act made the vehicle of God's act.	His role as warner and herald, bearer of a recited sign.	Denial of miracle on demand, of the power to guide, of self-benefit; the revelation held at God's discretion.
Context	Shielding him amid danger; the throw at Badr and the pledge of allegiance referred to God.	Responding to demands for an angel or a wonder.	Answering the call for spectacular signs; grounding his agency.
Principal verses	al-Mā'ida 5:67; al-Anfāl 8:17; al-Fath 48:10	al-Furqān 25:56	al-Isrā' 17:90-93; al-Qaṣaṣ 28:56; al-An'ām 7:188; al-Isrā' 17:86
Snippet	"you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17); "the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10)	"We have sent you only as a bringer of good news and a warner" (25:56)	"Am I anything but a human messenger?" (17:93); "you do not guide whom you love" (28:56)
Key term (root)	ramā (r-m-y: to throw); yad (y-d: hand)	nadhīr (n-dh-r: to warn)	bashar (b-sh-r: human being); hadā (h-d-y: to guide)

7. Theme Five: Moral Standing, Reproach, and Repentance

This theme carries the strongest material in both directions, and it is the register in which the Quran's accurate portrayal most requires that the corrective verses be reported plainly. In elevation, the Prophet's ﷺ character is commended in the highest terms, "you are of a magnificent character" (68:4), and a comprehensive forgiveness is announced over him (48:2). In the neutral register stands the ethical instruction directed to him as it would be to any believer. He is enjoined to forgiveness, to patience, and to seeking forgiveness, including, strikingly, at the very height of his success, "exalt your Lord with praise and seek His forgiveness, for He is ever-relenting" (110:3). And he is to take no payment for the message he carries, "Say: I ask of you no reward for it" (6:90), so that the revelation is never traded for a price.

The register of warning and accountability records the direct reproaches, the category the tradition named 'itāb al-nabī. The chapter 'Abasa opens with a reproof delivered in the third person, "He frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him" (80:1-2), at his turning from a blind man who had come for instruction while he attended to others of standing. The grammatical shift into the third person at the moment of the fault is itself a feature of the address. In al-Tawba the correction is framed as a pardon that presupposes a lapse, "God has pardoned you; why did you give them permission?" (9:43). The Quran attributes dhanb, fault, to him explicitly and commands him to seek forgiveness for it (40:55; 48:2).

Two warnings concern the integrity of the message in his keeping, and they are of the severest kind in the whole Quran. The first guards against any fabrication against God. The text records that his opponents nearly drew him to invent against God something other than the revelation, and it states the consequence without

softening it. Had God not made him firm, he might have inclined to them a little, "and then We would have made you taste a double of life and a double of death" (17:73-75). The second is more absolute still. Were he himself to fabricate sayings and attribute them to God, "We would surely have seized him by the right hand, then severed from him the aorta" (69:44-46). And association of others with God, even in his case, would render his own works void, "If you associate others with God, your work will surely come to nothing" (39:65). The most exalted of messengers is held to the most exacting standard, and the threats are stated against him directly.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	His character commended; a comprehensive forgiveness granted.	Ethical instruction as to any believer; commanded repentance; no payment taken.	Direct reproaches, explicit attribution of fault, and the severest conditional threats, admitting no immunity.
Context	Affirming his moral standing and divine favor.	Enjoining forgiveness and seeking pardon, even at the height of success, asking no wage.	Correcting specific acts; guarding the message against fabrication and against association.
Principal verses	al-Qalam 68:4; al-Faṭḥ 48:2	al-Naṣr 110:3; al-Anʿām 6:90	ʿAbasa 80:1-10; al-Tawba 9:43; al-Isrāʾ 17:73-75; al-Ḥāqqa 69:44-46; al-Zumar 39:65
Snippet	"you are of a magnificent character" (68:4)	"exalt your Lord with praise and seek His forgiveness" (110:3); "I ask of you no reward for it" (6:90)	"He frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him" (80:1-2); "We would have seized him by the right hand, then severed from him the aorta" (69:44-46)
Key term (root)	khuluq (kh-l-q: nature, disposition); ghafara (gh-f-r: to cover, forgive)	istaghfir (gh-f-r: to seek covering); ajr (ʿ-j-r: wage, reward)	dhanb (dh-n-b: tail, that which trails; offense); iftirāʾ (f-r-y: to fabricate); watīn (w-t-n: aorta)

8. Theme Six: Mortality, Body, and Person

The Quran honors the person of the Prophet ﷺ in ways granted to no one else, and these belong to the register of elevation. It swears an oath by his life, "By your life, they were lost in their intoxication" (15:72), conferring on his mortal span the dignity of a thing sworn by. It legislates the sanctity of his presence, forbidding the believers to raise their voices above his (49:2-3). And it consoles him in his distress. When the revelation paused and his opponents taunted that he had been abandoned, the answer came, "your Lord has not forsaken you, nor does He hate you" (93:3). His breast is expanded and his burden lifted, "Did We not expand for you your breast, and remove from you your burden?" (94:1-2).

In the neutral register the Quran states his plain humanity. He is a man among his people, and the wonder of his contemporaries that revelation should come to such a one is itself recorded (10:2). He eats and walks the markets, as his adversaries note in mockery (25:7), and the earliest addresses catch him in an ordinary human posture, wrapped in his garments (73:1). The register of warning then affirms his mortality and exposes his interior. He will die, "Indeed you will die, and indeed they will die" (39:30). No human before him was granted immortality (21:34). His breast is constricted by what his opponents say (15:97), and his grief over their disbelief is named to the edge of self-destruction and then restrained, "perhaps you would destroy yourself with grief over them" (18:6; cf. 26:3). His humble and dependent origin is recalled without ornament, "Did He not find you an orphan and shelter you, and find you lost and guide you?" (93:6-7). The

person who is honored by an oath sworn upon his life is the same person whose beginnings were need on every side, whose inner life bends under hostility, and whose end is death.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	His person honored: an oath by his life, the sanctity of his presence, and divine consolation in distress.	His plain humanity: a man among his people, subject to hunger and the marketplace.	His mortality, his constricted breast and exposed grief, and his humble, dependent origin.
Context	Conferring honor on his person and steadying him when the revelation paused.	Answering mockery that expected a superhuman envoy.	Affirming his death and finitude; restraining his grief; recalling his beginnings.
Principal verses	al-Ḥijr 15:72; al-Ḍuḥā 93:3; al-Sharḥ 94:1-2	Yūnus 10:2; al-Furqān 25:7; al-Muzzammil 73:1	al-Zumar 39:30; al-Anbiyā' 21:34; al-Ḥijr 15:97; al-Kahf 18:6
Snippet	"your Lord has not forsaken you, nor does He hate you" (93:3); "Did We not expand for you your breast?" (94:1)	"What is this messenger that eats food and walks in the markets?" (25:7)	"you will die, and they will die" (39:30); "He found you an orphan and sheltered you, found you lost and guided you" (93:6-7)
Key term (root)	'umr ('-m-r: life, lifespan); sharaḥa (sh-r-ḥ: to open, expand)	rajul (r-j-l: a man); ṭa'am (ṭ-'-m: food)	mawt (m-w-t: death); dāqa (ḍ-y-q: to be constricted)

9. Theme Seven: Rank Among the Prophets, Earthly and Eschatological

The Quran affirms that the prophets are not of equal rank, "Those messengers, some of them We favored above others. Among them were those to whom God spoke, and some He raised in degrees" (2:253; cf. 17:55). Against this stands the creed required of the believer, that no distinction be drawn between the messengers in the matter of belief, "we make no distinction between any of His messengers" (2:285). The two do not collide once the distinction is drawn precisely. The favoring is a statement about their stations and is God's to make. The non-distinction is an obligation about faith, that the believer accept all of them without selection, not a claim that their ranks are equal.

Within this frame the Prophet's ﷺ distinctions, stated strictly from the text, are distinctions of finality, of scope, and of covenant. He is the seal who confirms and completes the line (33:40). He is sent comprehensively to all mankind where others were sent to single peoples (34:28). He is named in the solemn covenant taken from the prophets (33:7). And he is promised a praised station, "It may be that your Lord will raise you to a praised station" (17:79). Honest reading requires a further observation. The Quran affirms that a ranking exists, but it issues no statement placing him by name above Moses (AS) or Abraham (AS) or Jesus (AS). He is told rather that he is no anomaly among them, "Say: I am not a novelty among the messengers" (46:9), and he is enumerated within their chain.

His earthly position even carries certain deficits relative to the earlier prophets, examined in detail in the section that follows. God spoke directly to Moses (AS) and supported Jesus (AS) with manifest signs and the Holy Spirit (2:253), while the Prophet ﷺ is denied the wonder produced on demand (17:90-93). In the hereafter his distinctions are real and yet bounded. He is granted the praised station and the role of a culminating witness over the communities (4:41; 16:89), but the messengers as a body disclaim knowledge before God on that day (5:109), and intercession is reserved to God and exercised only by His leave, "Say: Intercession belongs wholly to God" (39:44; cf. 2:255). His rank is genuine, terminal, and universal in scope, and it remains, in earth and in the hereafter, a rank held under God rather than apart from Him.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Distinctions of finality and scope: the Seal, a universal mercy, the praised station, the prophets' covenant.	His standing within the prophetic line, no anomaly among the messengers.	Earthly deficits relative to earlier prophets and the bounded character of his eschatological role.
Context	Affirming his terminal and universal place in the succession.	Locating him in the chain and in the believer's undifferentiated faith in all messengers.	Comparing his signs to those of Moses and Jesus; limiting intercession to divine leave.
Principal verses	al-Aḥzāb 33:40; Saba' 34:28; al-Isrā' 17:79; al-Aḥzāb 33:7	al-Aḥqāf 46:9; al-Baqara 2:285	al-Baqara 2:253; al-Isrā' 17:90-93; al-Zumar 39:44; al-Baqara 2:255
Snippet	"It may be that your Lord will raise you to a praised station" (17:79)	"I am not a novelty among the messengers" (46:9); "we make no distinction between any of His messengers" (2:285)	"Among them were those to whom God spoke, and some He raised in degrees" (2:253); "Intercession belongs wholly to God" (39:44)
Key term (root)	khātam (kh-t-m: to seal); maqām (q-w-m: to stand, station)	rusul (r-s-l: messengers); bid' (b-d-': a novelty)	faḍḍala (f-ḍ-l: to favor, give surplus); shafā'a (sh-f-': intercession)

10. Theme Eight: The Prophets Compared, Their Signs and His

The Quran never presents the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in isolation. It sets him within a long succession of messengers and characterizes that succession by the distinctive gift and the distinctive trial of each member. Read comparatively, the prophetic line throws his own endowment into relief, showing what he shares with those before him, what is withheld from him that others were granted, and what is given to him alone.

Each prophet carries a sign suited to his moment. Adam is taught the names of all things, a knowledge before which the angels fall silent (2:31). Noah (AS) is given the ark and the long patience of an unanswered call, and is remembered as "a grateful servant" (17:3). Abraham (AS) is taken by God as an intimate friend, khalīl (4:125), is delivered when the fire is commanded, "O fire, be coolness and peace upon Abraham" (21:69), and is made an imām for mankind (2:124). Moses (AS) is given the staff before which the sea divides, "and it parted, and each part was like a great mountain" (26:63), the Torah, and a distinction granted to no other in just these words, God "spoke to Moses directly," the verbal noun doubled for emphasis, kallama Allāhu Mūsā taklīmā (4:164). Yet even Moses (AS) meets a limit, for when he asks to see his Lord the answer is "you will not see Me," lan tarānī (7:143). David (AS) is given the Psalms and a creation that worships alongside him, "O mountains, echo God's praise with him, and the birds," and iron made soft in his hands (34:10; 21:79). Solomon (AS) is taught "the speech of the birds" (27:16), and the wind and the jinn are made subject to him (21:81; 34:12). Joseph (AS) is given the reading of dreams and of events (12:6).

The signs gathered around Jesus (AS) are the most concentrated of all, and the Quran's wording for them is exact. His coming is a creation by the divine word, set in parallel with Adam, "the likeness of Jesus before God is as the likeness of Adam: He created him from dust, then said to him, Be, and he was" (3:59). He is born of a virgin (19:20). He is himself called a Word from God, kalima, "His Word, which He cast to Mary, and a Spirit from Him," rūḥun minhu (4:171; 3:45), and he is strengthened with the Holy Spirit (2:87). By God's leave he forms from clay the likeness of a bird and breathes into it and it becomes a bird, and he heals the blind and the leper and raises the dead, each act marked "by God's leave," bi-idhni Allāh (3:49; 5:110). And Jesus (AS) is given one office that bears directly on the Prophet ﷺ. He announces the one to come, "giving good news of a

messenger to come after me whose name is Aḥmad" (61:6), naming him by a name from the same root as Muḥammad, the praised.

Against this array of wonders the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is given no staff, no parted sea, no clay made to breathe. The Quran records of him a night journey (17:1) and speaks of the moon split (54:1), but when his opponents demand a wonder as the price of belief, it redirects them to a sign of an altogether different kind, the recited Book itself, "Is it not enough for them that We have sent down to you the Book that is recited to them?" (29:51), "rather, it is clear signs in the breasts of those given knowledge" (29:49). His miracle is verbal and enduring rather than momentary and local, and the Quran stakes it on a challenge no rival speech has met, to bring even a single sūra like it (2:23). He is, in his own mouth, "only a human messenger" (17:93), and his scope is what no prophet before him was given. Where "every messenger" was sent "in the tongue of his people" (14:4), he is sent to all mankind and as a mercy to the worlds (34:28; 21:107).

The comparison then turns. The prophets who precede him are made, in the Quran, to point toward him. He is found "written with them in the Torah and the Gospel" (7:157). He is the answer to Abraham's (AS) own prayer, "Our Lord, raise up among them a messenger from themselves who will recite to them Your verses and teach them the Book and the wisdom" (2:129). And he is the one Jesus (AS) names (61:6). The single religion is presented as one across them all, "He has ordained for you of religion what He enjoined upon Noah, and what We have revealed to you, and what We enjoined upon Abraham and Moses and Jesus" (42:13), and the Quran comes "confirming what was before it," muṣaddiqān limā bayna yadayhi (3:3). The thread of divine speech that runs through Moses (AS), who was spoken to, and Jesus (AS), the Word cast to Mary, arrives as the recited Word laid upon the Prophet's ﷺ heart. The Spirit that is named of Jesus (AS) is named also of the revelation given to him, "We have revealed to you a Spirit of Our command" (42:52). He gathers the line and sets his seal upon it.

That sealing is named in a single phrase, Khātām al-Nabiyyīn (33:40), and the phrase repays attention to its root. The verb from which khātām is formed, kh-t-m, runs through the Quran with a sense that is wider than mere lastness. It is what God does to hearts and hearing when a state is fixed and confirmed, "God has set a seal upon their hearts and their hearing" (2:7). It is the authoritative closure of testimony on the Day of Judgment, "today We set a seal upon their mouths, and their hands speak to Us" (36:65). And in the description of the wine of the Garden it is the crowning, fragrant finish, a sealed draught "whose seal is musk," khitāmuḥu misk (83:25-26). In every case the seal both closes and certifies. It authenticates what it marks, secures it against alteration, and brings it to its finished form. Read against this usage, Khātām al-Nabiyyīn carries more than a position at the end of a sequence. It names the one who confirms and authenticates the whole prophetic line and brings it to completion, the certifying seal set upon all that came before. The familiar rendering "last" captures the aspect of closure. The root's fuller force is consummation, ratification, and the perfecting of what it seals. What such a seal closes, and what it therefore leaves open, is drawn out in Section 24.

The comparison therefore yields the motif once more. The Prophet's ﷺ distinction among the messengers is not a greater wonder held in his own hand, for the spectacular signs are precisely what he is not given. It is a sign of another order, the Word itself, a scope without precedent, and the office of confirming and sealing the line. And even that supreme office is receptive. He seals what was given to others. He is the fulfillment of a prayer and the answer to an announcement. And the seal he sets certifies a prophecy whose author is God. He completes the line. He does not originate it.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The prophetic line is made to point toward him: foretold in the earlier scriptures, the answer to Abraham's prayer, named by Jesus; he confirms the line and sets his seal upon it.	The pattern he shares with all messengers: a human envoy carrying the one religion and confirming what came before, no novelty among them.	The spectacular signs granted to earlier prophets are withheld from him; his sign is the recited Book, and he is only a human messenger.
Context	Locating him as the consummation the earlier prophets announced and the seal set upon their succession.	Setting him within the unbroken succession and its single call.	Answering demands that he match the staff of Moses or the signs of Jesus.
Principal verses	al-A'raf 7:157; al-Baqara 2:129; al-Şaff 61:6; al-Ahzab 33:40	al-Ahqaf 46:9; al-Shura 42:13; Al 'Imran 3:3	al-'Ankabut 29:50-51; al-Isra' 17:90-93; Al 'Imran 3:49
Snippet	"giving good news of a messenger to come after me whose name is Ahmad" (61:6); "raise up among them a messenger from themselves" (2:129)	"I am not a novelty among the messengers" (46:9); "He has ordained for you of religion what He enjoined upon Noah" (42:13)	"Is it not enough for them that We sent down to you the Book recited to them?" (29:51); "Am I anything but a human messenger?" (17:93)
Key term (root)	khātam (kh-t-m: to seal, certify, complete); Ahmad (h-m-d: to praise)	muşaddiq (ş-d-q: to confirm, hold true); rusul (r-s-l: messengers)	bayyina (b-y-n: clear proof); idhn ('-dh-n: leave, permission)

11. Theme Nine: Boon and Trial in His Circumstance

The Quran does not address the Prophet ﷺ only in the abstract. It meets him in his circumstance, in war and danger, in his household and among his kin, and the meeting carries the same double charge of favor and accountability that runs through the rest of the portrait. The register of elevation here takes the form of boons granted in his lived situation. The most intimate of them answers a wish he never voiced aloud. He had turned his face to the sky in longing, and the response reoriented the worship of the whole community to the direction he desired, "We have seen the turning of your face toward heaven, so We will surely turn you to a qibla you will be pleased with; so turn your face toward the Sacred Mosque" (2:144). After the death of his sons, when his opponents taunted that he was cut off and without posterity, the answer reversed the taunt and granted him abundance instead, "We have granted you al-Kawthar; so pray to your Lord and sacrifice; indeed, it is your hater who is the one cut off" (108:1-3). And his trials were answered with promise. A clear victory was declared his, "We have granted you a clear victory" (48:1), and the true vision of a safe return to Mecca was confirmed before its time, "you will surely enter the Sacred Mosque, God willing, in safety" (48:27).

The neutral register orders his daily and domestic life. His wives are addressed and regulated as a household set apart by his office, "O wives of the Prophet, you are not like any other women" (33:32; cf. 33:28-34), and the etiquette of his home is legislated for the believers who enter it (33:53). He is enjoined to consult those around him and to deal gently with them (3:159), and he asks no payment for his mission beyond the affection due to kinship, "Say: I ask of you no reward for it except love for kinship" (42:23).

The register of warning and accountability is equally present in his circumstance. He is told plainly that he cannot detect the disloyalty within his own ranks, and that God can, "Among the Bedouin around you are hypocrites, and among the people of Madinah who persist in hypocrisy; you do not know them, We know them" (9:101). His own household is the site of a public reproach. In the matter of his marriage he is told that he concealed within himself what God would bring to light, and that he feared the people when God had the

greater right to be feared, "you concealed within yourself what God would disclose, and you feared the people, while God has more right that you fear Him" (33:37). And he is reproved for forbidding himself a lawful thing to please his wives, with the further warning that, were he to divorce them, God could give him in their place wives better than they (66:1-5). Even his kinship is bounded by the message. He is forbidden to seek forgiveness for those who died in idolatry, though they be near of kin (9:113), and one of his own uncles is condemned by name in a sūra of the Quran (111). The favor that bends the qibla to his wish and the correction that exposes his fear of the people are the same address, meeting one man in the full particularity of his life.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Boons granted in his lived circumstance: worship reoriented to his unspoken wish, abundance after loss, victory promised.	The ordering of his household and the conduct of his mission, asking no payment beyond love of kin.	Betrayal he cannot himself detect, a public reproach within his household, and limits touching his own kin.
Context	Answering his longing and his trials with favor and promise.	Regulating his domestic and communal life.	Warning him of hypocrisy, correcting his conduct toward his wives, and forbidding intercession for idolatrous kin.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:144; al-Kawthar 108:1-3; al-Fath 48:1; al-Fath 48:27	al-Aḥzāb 33:32; al-Aḥzāb 33:53; al-Shūrā 42:23	al-Tawba 9:101; al-Aḥzāb 33:37; al-Tahrim 66:1-5; al-Tawba 9:113
Snippet	"We have seen the turning of your face toward heaven, so We will turn you to a qibla you will be pleased with" (2:144); "We have granted you al-Kawthar ... it is your hater who is the one cut off" (108:1-3)	"O wives of the Prophet, you are not like any other women" (33:32); "I ask of you no reward for it except love for kinship" (42:23)	"you do not know them, We know them" (9:101); "you concealed within yourself what God would disclose, and you feared the people" (33:37)
Key term (root)	qibla (q-b-l: to face, turn toward); kawthar (k-th-r: abundance)	azwāj (z-w-j: spouse, pair); mawadda (w-d-d: love, affection)	munāfiq (n-f-q: to dissemble); qurbā (q-r-b: nearness, kinship)

12. Theme Ten: The Charge of the Adversary and the Defense

The nine registers to this point have read the portrait as the Quran draws it. The text also preserves the portrait as it was contested, the charges his first hearers pressed against the man who recited the Book and the answers the recitation returned to them. Four registers gather that contest and its root. They are read under the same three registers as the portrait itself, the contest now seen in how the text raises and vindicates him against the charge, states his office at its plain floor, and turns its warning upon the accusers.

The first hearers could not agree what he was, and the Quran keeps their disagreement as part of its case. He was called a poet, *shā'ir*, root *sh-ʿ-r*, to perceive and to feel, his recitation reduced to inspired human craft (21:5; 37:36; 52:30). He was called a sorcerer, *sāḥir*, root *s-ḥ-r*, to bewitch, the word read as an enchantment that cleaves households (38:4; 43:30; 74:24). He was called possessed, *majnūn*, root *j-n-n*, to be covered over, his speech explained as a jinni's (15:6; 68:51; 81:22). He was called a soothsayer, *kāhin*, whose rhymed cadence his own resembled (52:29; 69:42), a man taught by another standing behind him, *mu'allam* (16:103; 44:14), and a teller of ancient fables, *asāṭir al-awwalīn* (25:5; 6:25; 83:13). The labels do not cohere, and the Quran makes their incoherence the first answer, "see how they strike comparisons for you, so they stray and cannot

find a way" (17:48; 25:9). A man cannot be at once too eloquent and merely raving, bewitched and coldly lying, and the failure of his accusers to settle on one charge is itself the sign that none of them fits.

Beneath the labels lay a heavier charge of a different order. The labels attack his faculty. This one attacks his honesty before God, that he fashioned the revelation himself and ascribed it to Heaven. "We never heard this in the latter religion. This is nothing but a fabrication," in *hādhā illā khtilāq* (38:7), the word formed from *kh-l-q*, the root of creation itself, so that to charge him with *ikhtilāq* is to charge him with the originating act, with fashioning a revelation as though he were its author. Its twin is *iftirāʾ*, root *f-r-y*, to forge a lie (25:4). And the charge sits, at 38:7, inside the very complaint that asks why the reminder was sent down to one man among them (38:8), the envy that the last register of this movement will name at its root.

The defense the Quran sets in his mouth answers not by escalation but by subtraction, and 46:9 is its clearest form. "I am not a novelty among the messengers," *mā kuntu bidʿan min al-rusul*, the root *b-d-ʿ* the very root of unprecedented origination, used of God the Originator, *Badīʿ* (2:117), so that his first word of defense is the denial of being an origination, the exact denial that *ikhtilāq* demands. "Nor do I know what will be done with me or with you," disclaiming the unseen and his own end, the one assurance a forger would never write into his own script. "I only follow what is revealed to me," in *attabīʿu illā mā yūḥā ilayya*, root *t-b-ʿ*, to follow, the precise opposite of fashioning, repeated at 10:15 where he answers a demand for a different Quran that it is not his to alter. "And I am not but a clear warner," *nadhīrun mubīn*, the office stripped to its floor and his speech named clarifying rather than bewitching. Each reduction is a refutation. And the Quran does not rest on disavowal but stakes the matter on tests that can be checked. Produce a single *sūra* like it (2:23; 17:88). Find the discrepancy a human forgery would leave, "had it been from other than God they would have found in it much *ikhtilāf*" (4:82), the disproof of *ikhtilāq* lying in the absence of *ikhtilāf*, the two words a single letter apart. Explain the unlettered man who never read nor wrote before it (29:48) and had lived a lifetime among them reciting nothing (10:16). Set the clear Arabic against the foreign tongue of the alleged teacher (16:103). And weigh the self-incrimination, that a forger against God would have been seized by the right hand and his aorta severed (69:44-47), placed one verse before the defense, "if I have invented it, you cannot avail me against God at all" (46:8). The verdict is the photographic negative of the seal already read. The single question dividing the accuser from the accused is whether he originated the word, *ikhtilāq* answering yes and in *attabīʿu illā mā yūḥā ilayya* answering no, and the recipient who completes and does not originate is here seen from the dark side. The same axis that clears him condemns the impostor, for the Quran's own measure of the false claimant is the mirror of his defense, "who is more unjust than one who invents a lie against God, or says, it has been revealed to me, when nothing was revealed to him" (6:93).

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The recitation vindicated against the charge of fabrication and staked on tests that can be checked: that none can bring a <i>sūra</i> like it, that a human forgery would show discrepancy and shows none, and that an unlettered man recited it who had never read nor written.	The office named at its floor in the defense by subtraction: a clear warner who claims no origination and no foreknowledge, who only follows what is revealed and cannot alter it of his own will.	The judgment turned upon the false claimant: the forger against God would be seized and his aorta severed, the impostor is the most unjust of men, and the charge of <i>ikhtilāq</i> is the dark mirror of the certifying seal.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Context	Meeting the labels of poet, sorcerer, madman, soothsayer, taught-man, and fable-teller, and the heavier charge of fabrication, with proofs of authenticity rather than a conjured wonder.	Answering not by escalation but by subtraction, disclaiming origination, foreknowledge, and novelty, and claiming reception and conveyance alone.	Reading the whole dispute on the single axis of authorship, where the accusers' own incoherence is the first sign that no charge fits and the measure of the impostor is the mirror of his defense.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:23; al-Isrā' 17:88; al-Nisā' 4:82; al-Ankabūt 29:48; al-Nahl 16:103	al-Aḥqāf 46:9; Yūnus 10:15	al-Ḥāqqā 69:44-47; al-Aḥqāf 46:8; al-An'ām 6:93; Ṣād 38:7-8
Snippet	"had it been from other than God they would have found in it much discrepancy" (4:82)	"I only follow what is revealed to me, and I am not but a clear warner" (46:9)	"if I have invented it, you cannot avail me against God at all" (46:8)
Key term (root)	bayyina (b-y-n: a clear proof, distinguishing sign)	ittibā' (t-b-': to follow); bid' (b-d-': an unprecedented origination, here denied)	ikhtilāq (kh-l-q: to fashion, fabricate); iftirā' (f-r-y: to forge a lie)

13. Theme Eleven: The Sign Demanded and the Sign Given

Where the labels disputed what he was, a further objection prescribed what a messenger must bring, and the Quran gathers the demands into a single template of spectacle. He must show God plainly, arinā Allāha jahratān, root j-h-r, to be open and manifest (2:55; 4:153). He must bring down a book from the sky to be handled and read (4:153; 17:93; 6:7). He must secure the privilege of Moses (AS), that God speak to the people directly, lawlā yukallimunā Allāh (2:118). He must be escorted by a visible angel, or be made an angel himself (6:8; 25:7; 11:12). And Banī Isrā'īl had set the most exacting form of the condition, a messenger who brings an offering that fire from heaven devours, qurbānin ta'kuluhu al-nār (3:183). The single thread through every demand is proof by the supernatural made external, visible, and held in the messenger's own hand.

Against every term of that template the Quran's messenger is the refusal of it. He is a man who eats and walks the markets, denied the angelic form they require (25:7; "I am only a man like you," 18:110). The whole litany of Meccan demands, that he make a spring gush from the earth, own a garden of palms and vines, drop the sky in fragments, bring God and the angels face to face, or mount a ladder into heaven, is met not with a wonder but with a disclaimer, "Glory be to my Lord, am I anything but a human messenger" (17:90-93). His sign is not the conjured marvel but the recited Word and the heart it alters, "is it not enough for them that We have sent down to you the Book that is recited to them" (29:51), "rather, it is clear signs in the breasts of those given knowledge" (29:49). The demand wants the sign held outside and shown. The answer gives it heard and carried within.

And the Quran does not treat the demand as honest inquiry awaiting its satisfaction. It diagnoses it as evasion. The offering devoured by fire that Banī Isrā'īl required had been brought by messengers before them, "so why did you kill them, if you are truthful" (3:183), and the spectacle the rejecters swore would convince them would not, "even if We sent down to them the angels, and the dead spoke to them, and We gathered everything before them, they would not believe unless God willed" (6:111). The condition is refusal wearing the mask of a test. The verdict is the adversarial face of the first movement's reading of his power. The

messenger who holds no marvel in his own hand is the messenger whose only sign is the Word he did not author, the servant once more rather than the sovereign.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	His true sign is not the conjured marvel but the recited Word and the heart it alters, the clear signs carried in the breasts of those given knowledge, internal and enduring where the demand wanted the external and momentary.	A human messenger who works no wonder on command, denied the angelic form his accusers required, answering the whole litany of demands with the disclaimer that he is but a man.	The demand read as evasion rather than honest inquiry: the offering devoured by fire had been brought by prophets before and met with their killing, and the spectacle the rejecters swore would convince them would not.
Context	Setting the sign heard and carried within against the credential held outside and shown.	Meeting the demand for a plain sight of God, a handled book, direct divine speech, a visible angel, or an offering consumed by fire, with the categorical humanity.	Locating the withholding of spectacle as the mark of the servant whose only sign is a Word he did not author, the messenger rather than the sovereign.
Principal verses	al-ʿAnkabūt 29:49-51	al-Isrāʾ 17:90-93; al-Kahf 18:110	al-Baqara 2:55; al-Nisāʾ 4:153; al-Baqara 2:118; al-Furqān 25:7; ʾĀl ʿImrān 3:183; al-Anʿām 6:111
Snippet	"rather, it is clear signs in the breasts of those given knowledge" (29:49)	"Glory be to my Lord, am I anything but a human messenger?" (17:93)	"so why did you kill them, if you are truthful?" (3:183)
Key term (root)	āya (ʾ-y-y: a sign); bayyina (b-y-n: a clear sign)	bashar (b-sh-r: a human being)	jahra (j-h-r: to be open, manifest); qurbān (q-r-b: an offering, a drawing near)

14. Theme Twelve: The People of the Book and the Awaited One

A different adversary objected on different ground. The People of the Book did not ask what he was, for they knew. They had awaited the prophet their scriptures named, and had sought victory through his coming, "before, they used to seek triumph by him over those who disbelieved," *yastaftihūna ʿalā alladhīna kafarū*, root *f-t-ḥ*, to open and to grant the opening of victory (2:89). They recognized him "as they recognize their own sons," *yaʿrifūnahu kamā yaʿrifūna abnāʾahum* (2:146; 6:20), found "written with them in the Torah and the Gospel" (7:157), the one Jesus (AS) had named (61:6). The reported setting of the early biographies, that the Jewish tribes of Yathrib held the coming prophet over the pagan Arabs as a threat of imminent ruin, attaches to this seeking of victory. It is noted here as the historical frame, and the analysis does not rest upon it. The text alone establishes that they had awaited him and knew him when he came.

What the text then records is recognition followed by refusal, and it names the cause. "When there came to them what they recognized, they disbelieved in it" (2:89), and they did so "out of envy that God should send down His grace upon whom He wills of His servants," *baghyan*, root *b-gh-y*, insolent envy (2:90). The grace had fallen outside the lineage, and that was the whole of the offense. Their criterion became provenance and not truth, "we believe in what was sent down to us and reject what is beyond it," *mā warāʾah*, what lies behind their own enclosure (2:91). A party "cast the Book of God behind their backs" (2:101), and the Quran exposes their claim to honor their own prophets as hollow in the same breath, "say, why then did you kill the prophets of God before, if you were believers" (2:91; cf. 2:87).

The answer the Quran returns is the undivided line, and it is generous where it might have been only severe. The single religion was ordained alike for Noah (AS) and Abraham (AS) and Moses (AS) and Jesus (AS) (42:13). The Book comes "confirming what was before it" (3:3), and the creed it carries "makes no distinction between any of them" (2:136; 3:84), receiving every prophet of theirs without selection. The asymmetry this exposes is the argument itself, that the new community embraces the old prophets whole while the old community rejects the new out of ownership. And to those of the People of the Book who crossed over, the text promises not reproach but a doubled gift, "those will be given their reward twice, for their patience" (28:54), "a double portion of His mercy, and a light by which they walk" (57:28), the door held visibly open. The verdict is that prophecy was never anyone's property, and the line is honored most by those who receive it entire.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The foretold prophet whom the People of the Book had awaited and sought victory through, recognized as they recognize their own sons, found written with them in the Torah and the Gospel and named by Jesus, with a doubled mercy promised to those of them who believe.	The undivided line he confirms and completes, the one religion ordained alike for the prophets before him, the creed that receives every one of them and makes no distinction between any.	The recognition followed by refusal, named at its cause as envy that the grace fell outside the lineage, the criterion made provenance rather than truth, and the claim to honor their own prophets exposed as hollow.
Context	The grace awaited and sought, and the door held visibly open to those who cross over, given their reward twice.	Answering the exclusivist claim with a creed that embraces their own prophets entire.	Measuring him by provenance, accepting only what was sent to themselves, casting the Book behind their backs, while having killed the prophets they claim.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:146; al-A'rāf 7:157; al-Şaff 61:6; al-Baqara 2:89; al-Qaşaş 28:54; al-Ĥadid 57:28	al-Baqara 2:136; Āl 'Imrān 3:84; al-Shūrā 42:13	al-Baqara 2:90; al-Baqara 2:91; al-Baqara 2:87
Snippet	"they recognize him as they recognize their own sons" (2:146); "a double portion of His mercy" (57:28)	"we make no distinction between any of them" (2:136)	"out of envy" (2:90); "why then did you kill the prophets of God before?" (2:91)
Key term (root)	istiftāḥ (f-t-ḥ: to seek victory, opening); kifl (k-f-l: a portion, share)	taşdiq (ş-d-q: to confirm, hold true); farq (f-r-q: to distinguish, divide)	baghy (b-gh-y: envy, insolent transgression)

15. Theme Thirteen: Envy and the Sundering of the One Community

The three contests to this point share a single root, and the Quran names it and makes it general. Mankind was one community, ummatan wāḥidatan, and its division did not come from ignorance. "None differed over it except those who were given it, after the clear proofs had come to them, out of envy among themselves," baghyan baynahum (2:213). The formula returns almost word for word four times over, "they did not differ except after knowledge had come to them, out of envy among themselves" (3:19; 42:14; 45:17). The one affair was severed by their own hands, "they cut their affair into pieces among themselves," taqaṭṭa'ū amrahum baynahum (21:92-93; 23:52-53), until "each faction rejoices in what it holds" (30:32), and they "divided their religion and became sects," shiya'an (6:159). The cause the Quran assigns to religious division is not the absence of knowledge but the presence of envy after it. Sectarianism is baghy wearing the robe of doctrine.

Read together with the contests that precede it, the envy here is seen to wear three coats over one body. It is the angel's pride of substance, Iblis refusing the prostration to Adam with "I am better than him," *ana khayrun minhu* (7:12). It is the clansman's pride of place, the Meccans asking "has the reminder been sent down on him alone among us" (38:8). It is the heir's pride of lineage, Banī Isrā'īl resenting that grace was given outside the bloodline (2:90). One envy and three theaters, and the same envy at last fractures the one religion into rival sects among the very family of the prophets, each of whom was sent to "their brother" under a single ordained way (7:65; 7:73; 42:13).

The Quran does not leave this as an indictment of others, and the register that turns the lesson is the one to hold above the rest. The verse that draws the moral is addressed to the believers themselves, "do not be like those who divided and differed after the clear proofs came to them" (3:105), and "each faction rejoicing in what it has" (30:32) is aimed at everyone who fractures, the believing community first among them. The People of the Book are the cautionary case and not a uniquely fallen people. The envy diagnosed is the universal disease of the human breast that the whole portrait of the servant-prophet has been set against. The verdict, then, is not a triumph over a neighbor but a diagnosis turned inward, and it sets the question the final movement of this study takes up. If envy is what sundered the one community, what in the portrait of the seal heals it, and what, with the contest answered and its root laid bare, does the text hold open to the one who reads.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The one undivided community and the single religion ordained alike for all the prophets, the height of the intended unity from which every later sundering is a fall.	The cause of division named plainly and four times over, envy after the clear proofs had come and not the absence of knowledge, so that sectarianism is envy wearing the robe of doctrine.	The warning turned inward upon the believers themselves not to divide as those before them did, the affair cut into pieces, the religion broken into sects, and the one envy seen in its three forms of substance, place, and lineage.
Context	Mankind as one community before the rupture, a single ordained way among the family of the prophets.	Tracing the rupture to baghy after knowledge, the disease of the human breast the whole portrait is set against.	A diagnosis turned inward and not a triumph over others, setting the question the seal's open path will answer, how the sundering is healed.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:213	Āl 'Imrān 3:19; al-Shūrā 42:14; al-Jāthiya 45:17	Āl 'Imrān 3:105; al-An'ām 6:159; al-Anbiyā' 21:92-93; al-Mu'minūn 23:52-53; al-Rūm 30:32; al-A'raf 7:12
Snippet	"mankind was one community" (2:213)	"they did not differ except after knowledge had come to them, out of envy" (45:17)	"do not be like those who divided and differed" (3:105); "each faction rejoicing in what it has" (30:32)
Key term (root)	umma ('-m-m: a single community)	baghy (b-gh-y: envy, insolent transgression)	shiya' (sh-y-': factions, sects); taqaṭṭu' (q-ṭ-': to cut into pieces); furqa (f-r-q: division, separation)

16. Theme Fourteen: The Slander and the Vindication

The thirteen registers to this point have read the portrait and the contest brought against it. The text also met the Prophet ﷺ in the particular crises of his life, and the third movement of this study reads those meetings. They are not aspects of how he is drawn, nor charges to be answered, but trials, and what they share is one pattern that confirms all that has gone before. In each, the resolution descends from God and is not produced

by the Prophet ﷺ himself. The tables of this movement read each trial under the same three registers as before, marking where the text raises and vindicates him in it, where it states his part in plain terms, and where it marks his limit, his correction, or the warning it carries.

The gravest assault on his peace came not against his doctrine but against his household. A rumor spread that his wife had been unfaithful, and it ran through the community while he had no answer to it. The Quran records the ordeal without softening his helplessness in it, naming the affliction *al-ifk*, the lie, "those who brought the slander are a band among you" (24:11), and it does not show him ending the matter by his own authority or his own conviction. He waited, as the community waited, for the word from above.

The clearing came by revelation and not by his defense. The Quran absolved his wife directly, "they are absolved of what they say; for them is forgiveness and a noble provision" (24:26), and turned the affair into law for all. A charge of this kind requires four witnesses, and absent them the accusers are themselves at fault (24:13). To repeat what one has not verified is no small thing, "you took it up with your tongues and spoke with your mouths what you had no knowledge of, and reckoned it a trifle, while with God it was great" (24:15). The honor of the household was restored from above, and the one who spoke the slander, not the one it was spoken against, was condemned.

The pattern is the one the whole study has traced, met here at its most personal. In the crisis nearest his heart the Prophet ﷺ is not the agent of his own vindication. He is its recipient. The reversal is the same the text had worked when his sons died and his enemies called him cut off, *abtar*, and the answer came that the abundance was his and the hater was the one cut off (108:1-3). His honor, like his message, is given to him and not generated by him, and the slander against his house is answered by the same hand that answers every other trial.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	A direct vindication sent down from God, his wife absolved and his honor restored from above, and the kindred reversal of the taunt of being cut off answered by the abundance of <i>al-Kawthar</i> .	In the crisis nearest his heart he is not the agent of his own vindication but its recipient, bearing a month-long slander he could not end by his own word and awaiting the word from above.	The affair made into law and the careless tongue rebuked: a charge of this kind requires four witnesses, the accusers absent them are themselves at fault, and to repeat the unverified was reckoned a trifle yet was great with God.
Context	The honor of the household restored by the same hand that answers every other trial.	The assault falling on his household rather than his doctrine, and finding him without an answer of his own.	Condemning the one who spoke the slander rather than the one it was spoken against, and setting the standard of proof and the gravity of rumor for all.
Principal verses	<i>al-Nūr</i> 24:26; <i>al-Kawthar</i> 108:1-3	<i>al-Nūr</i> 24:11-12	<i>al-Nūr</i> 24:13; <i>al-Nūr</i> 24:15
Snippet	"they are absolved of what they say; for them is forgiveness and a noble provision" (24:26)	"those who brought the slander are a band among you" (24:11)	"you took it up with your tongues... and reckoned it a trifle, while with God it was great" (24:15)
Key term (root)	<i>kawthar</i> (k-th-r: abundance)	<i>bara'a</i> (b-r-': to absolve, declare innocent)	<i>ifk</i> ('-f-k: to lie, slander, overturn)

17. Theme Fifteen: The Law He Did Not Make

A woman came to him with a grievance for which he had no ruling. Her husband had cast her off by the old formula of *zihār*, declaring her as forbidden to him as his mother's back, a pronouncement that left her neither divorced nor wed, and she pleaded her case and complained to God. The Quran opens the *sūra* named for her, *al-Mujādila*, She Who Disputes, by marking that her plea was heard in heaven before it was answered on earth, "God has heard the speech of the woman who disputes with you concerning her husband and complains to God, and God hears your dialogue" (58:1). The Prophet ﷺ himself had given her no answer, for there was none to give until it was sent down.

The law came from above and not from him. God annulled the old formula, named it "an objectionable saying and a falsehood," and set in its place a graduated expiation (58:2-4). And the same hand governs the most scrutinized event of his own household, the marriage to Zaynab, the former wife of his adopted son. The Quran had already severed adoption from sonship, "He has not made your adopted sons your sons; call them by their fathers" (33:4-5), and it records that he married her by command, to fix in law that an adopted son is not a son, while reproving him in the same verse for having feared the people when God had the greater right to be feared (33:37). Neither the woman's relief nor his own marriage is his ruling. Both are legislated for him.

Here the servant-prophet stands at the precise point where a founder would be expected to legislate, and he does not. He cannot resolve the woman's plight by his own judgment, and he cannot order his own household by his own preference. The answer to her and the breaking of the taboo for him descend as revelation, and he is corrected even in the manner of receiving it. The one who only follows what is revealed (46:9) is shown following it into the law itself, which is given to him and never authored by him.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The law sent down from above to relieve the woman and to order his own household, God having heard her plea in heaven before it was answered on earth, annulling the old formula and abolishing adoption by command.	He legislates nothing of his own, having no answer to the woman until revelation came; the one who only follows what is revealed is shown following it into the law itself.	He is corrected even in receiving it, reproved in the very verse that commands his marriage for having feared the people when God had the greater right to be feared.
Context	God deciding both the woman's relief and the Prophet's ﷺ own affair, the marriage breaking the taboo only by command, to fix in law that an adopted son is not a son.	The case finding him without a ruling until the word came, at the precise point where a founder would be expected to legislate.	The taboo broken not by his preference but by command, and the manner of his receiving it held to account.
Principal verses	<i>al-Mujādila</i> 58:2-4; <i>al-Aḥzāb</i> 33:4-5	<i>al-Mujādila</i> 58:1; <i>al-Aḥqāf</i> 46:9	<i>al-Aḥzāb</i> 33:37
Snippet	"He has not made your adopted sons your sons; call them by their fathers" (33:5)	"God has heard the speech of the woman who disputes with you" (58:1)	"you feared the people, while God has more right that you fear Him" (33:37)
Key term (root)	<i>zihār</i> (z-h-r: the back, the old formula of repudiation)	<i>jidāl</i> (j-d-l: to dispute, argue)	<i>da'iyy</i> (d-'-w: an adopted son, one called to another)

18. Theme Sixteen: The Knowledge Bounded Under Question

He was tested with questions meant to expose the limit of what he knew. The reported setting of the early literature, that his opponents sought from the learned of the People of the Book three questions to put to him, the companions of the cave, the traveler of the two horizons, and the spirit, is the biographical frame, and the analysis does not rest upon it. What the text establishes is that on the hardest of the three the answer given was a confession of limit, "they ask you about the spirit; say, the spirit is of the command of my Lord, and you have not been given of knowledge except a little" (17:85).

The Quran answers the other two questions at length, in the narratives of the sleepers of the cave and of Dhū al-Qarnayn (18:9-26; 83-98), and in the telling it corrects the Prophet ﷺ himself for a presumption of his own. He had promised an answer on the morrow without referring it to the will of God, and the rebuke is set into the sūra, "do not say of anything, I will surely do that tomorrow, except that God wills," and remember your Lord if you forget (18:23-24). And where the People of the Book brought him a case for judgment, he was to rule not by his own mind but by the Book they already held, "how is it they come to you for judgment while they have the Torah, in which is the judgment of God" (5:43), for "We revealed the Torah, in it guidance and light" (5:44).

The trial of his knowledge returns the finding of the third theme of the first movement, now under examination. His knowledge is a granted and bounded thing, not a possessed and unlimited one. His very promises are corrected when they presume upon the unseen, and his judgments are referred to revelation, his own and that given before him. The interrogation meant to find the limit of the man finds exactly the limit the Quran everywhere draws, knowledge given in measure and the rest with God alone.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The two narratives given in full as answer through him, the sleepers of the cave and the traveler of the two horizons, knowledge of the hidden past granted where his interrogators thought to find ignorance.	His judgment referred not to his own mind but to the revealed Book, ruling for the People of the Book by the Torah they already held, in which is the judgment of God.	The hardest question answered by a confession of limit, that he was given of knowledge only a little, and his presumption corrected when he promised an answer on the morrow without referring it to the will of God.
Context	The granted knowledge of the past supplied where the test sought a gap.	The one who only follows what is revealed shown deriving his judgment from revelation, his own and that given before him.	His knowledge a granted and bounded thing, not a possessed and unlimited one, and his very promises corrected when they presume upon the unseen.
Principal verses	al-Kahf 18:9-26; 18:83-98	al-Mā'ida 5:43-44	al-Isrā' 17:85; al-Kahf 18:23-24
Snippet	"We relate to you their story in truth" (18:13)	"how is it they come to you for judgment while they have the Torah" (5:43)	"you have not been given of knowledge except a little" (17:85)
Key term (root)	'ilm ('-l-m: knowledge, here granted)	ḥukm (ḥ-k-m: judgment, ruling)	rūḥ (r-w-ḥ: spirit, breath); mashī'a (sh-y-' : will, what God wills)

19. Theme Seventeen: The Frown and the Firmness

Twice the Quran met him at the edge of his own conduct in the mission, once in a fault of manner and once in a danger of substance. The first is the reproach of 'Abasa. A blind man came seeking knowledge while the

Prophet ﷺ was occupied with the powerful he hoped to win, and he frowned and turned away. The rebuke is direct and opens the sūra in the third person, as if to hold the act at arm's length, "He frowned and turned away that the blind man came to him; and what would make you know, perhaps he would be purified" (80:1-4). The one who sought was worthier of his attention than the one whose favor he courted, and the text says so to his face.

The second is graver, a pull not of manner but of message. The Quran records that he was nearly drawn to soften what was revealed in order to win his opponents, and that God held him, "they almost tempted you away from what We revealed to you, that you might invent against Us something else, and then they would have taken you as a friend; and had We not made you firm, you would have nearly inclined to them a little" (17:73-74). The firmness was God's gift and not his own resolve. This is the place where the contested story of the cranes is sometimes set, and it is set in its place here, anchored not to that narrative, which the text does not carry, but to the firmness verses and to the general law that no prophet recited but that Satan cast something into the recitation, which God then annuls and makes firm (22:52).

Both episodes return the servant under correction and under protection, and from the same source. He is reproved for the frown and held firm against the temptation, and neither the reproof nor the holding originates in him. The reproaches the tradition gathered under the name *ʿitāb al-nabī* and the protection that kept the message unaltered are two acts of one care, the care of God for a servant who could err in manner and could be tempted in substance, and was carried through both.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The firmness granted from God that held him from inclining to his opponents, and the protection that kept the message unaltered, God abolishing what Satan casts and making His verses firm.	The servant under both correction and protection from the same source, the one who only follows what is revealed, neither the reproof nor the holding originating in him.	A fault of manner, the frown at the blind seeker who was worthier than the powerful he courted, and a danger of substance, the pull to soften the message that God held him against.
Context	The firmness God's gift and not his own resolve, the casting purified, the message carried through unbent.	Two acts of one care, the reproof and the holding, for a servant who could err in manner and be tempted in substance.	The contested story of the cranes set in its place, anchored to the firmness verses and the general law, not asserted as event.
Principal verses	al-Isrā' 17:74; al-Ḥajj 22:52	al-Aḥqāf 46:9	ʿAbasa 80:1-4; al-Isrā' 17:73
Snippet	"had We not made you firm, you would have nearly inclined to them a little" (17:74)	"I only follow what is revealed to me, and I am not but a clear warner" (46:9)	"He frowned and turned away that the blind man came to him" (80:1-2)
Key term (root)	tathbīt (th-b-t: to make firm, steady)	ittibāʿ (ṭ-b-ʿ: to follow)	ʿabasa (ʿ-b-s: to frown, scowl); fitna (f-t-n: trial, temptation)

20. Theme Eighteen: The Unseen Audience and the Staked Truth

Two trials stretched his mission past its visible bounds, one downward into the unseen and one outward into open confrontation. In the first, a company he could not see came to hear him. The Quran records that a band of the jinn listened to the recitation and believed, "say, it has been revealed to me that a company of the jinn listened, and they said, we have heard a wondrous recitation that guides to right conduct, so we believed

in it" (72:1-2; cf. 46:29-32). His audience was wider than the human, and the Word reached where his own sight did not.

In the second, the Christians of Najran disputed with him over the nature of Jesus (AS), and the Quran gave him not an argument to win but a trial to propose, the *mubāhala*, the mutual imprecation, "whoever disputes with you about him after the knowledge that has come to you, say, come, let us call our sons and your sons, our women and your women, ourselves and yourselves, then let us invoke and place the curse of God upon the liars" (3:61). The truth is not staked on his eloquence or his standing but on God's own judgment between the parties, the liar to be exposed by Heaven and not by the man.

Both trials carry the same mark. The reach to the jinn is the reach of the recited Word and not of his person. They believe on hearing it, as men do, and the wonder is the recitation and not the reciter. And the confrontation with Najran is handed, at its sharpest, to God to decide, the imprecation calling down a verdict the Prophet ﷺ does not himself pronounce. Where his mission passed beyond the seen and where it met its hardest denial, the resolution belonged to God, and the servant only carried the Word and proposed the trial.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The recited Word reaching past the visible, a company of the jinn who came to hear it and believed on hearing, the wonder being the recitation and not the reciter, the audience wider than the human.	The servant who only carries the Word and proposes the trial, the reach belonging to the recitation and not to his person, his mission stretched beyond the seen and into open dispute.	The hardest denial, the dispute with the Christians of Najran over Jesus, handed at its sharpest to God: a mutual imprecation calling the curse of God upon the liars, a verdict the Prophet ﷺ does not himself pronounce.
Context	The Word guiding where his own sight did not reach, believed by the jinn as men believe.	The reach the Word's, not his person's, so that the conveyance and not the conveyor is the marvel.	The truth staked not on his eloquence or standing but on God's own judgment between the parties, the liar exposed by Heaven and not by the man.
Principal verses	al-Jinn 72:1-2; al-Jinn 72:13	al-Aḥqāf 46:29-30	Āl 'Imrān 3:61
Snippet	"a company of the jinn listened... we have heard a wondrous recitation... so we believed in it" (72:1-2)	"We directed to you a company of the jinn, listening to the Qur'an" (46:29)	"let us invoke and place the curse of God upon the liars" (3:61)
Key term (root)	ruṣḥd (r-sh-d: right guidance, sound conduct)	jinn (j-n-n: the hidden, the unseen)	ibtihāl (b-h-l: to invoke earnestly, to imprecate)

21. Theme Nineteen: The Enemy Within and the Conduct of the Struggle

The hardest enemies of his community were not the open ones but the hidden, and against these the Prophet ﷺ was given no power of detection. The Quran states it plainly, among those around him were hypocrites he could not know and God could, "among the Bedouin around you are hypocrites, and among the people of Madinah, persistent in hypocrisy; you do not know them, We know them" (9:101; cf. 63:1-8). The reported account that he confided the names of certain of them to a single companion is biography. What the text establishes is the limit, that the inner enemy is hidden from him and exposed only from above.

Against the open enemy, the Quran did not leave him to his own measure but bound his conduct to a law of restraint. He is to fight only those who fight him and never to transgress, "fight in the way of God those who

fight you, and do not transgress; God loves not the transgressors" (2:190). He is to incline to peace when the enemy inclines to it, "and if they incline to peace, incline to it, and rely upon God" (8:61). He is to grant asylum to the very enemy who seeks to hear God's word and then convey him to safety (9:6), and to deal justly and kindly with those who did not fight him (60:8). The contest of words is fenced too, the believing poet permitted to answer only after wrong, among "those who believe and do righteous deeds and remember God much and defend themselves after they were wronged" (26:227).

The crisis of the enemy, within and without, returns the same servant. He cannot see the hypocrite, and the exposure is God's. He does not set the rules of the struggle, and the restraint is commanded. Even the answering of slander in verse is bounded by the law of the wronged. The one who holds no autonomous power over outcomes, as the first movement had already established, is shown holding none here, in the gravest matters of war and loyalty, where a sovereign would rule by his own will and the servant rules by the law sent down to him.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The conduct of the struggle raised by a law of mercy from above: to incline to peace when the enemy inclines to it, to grant asylum to the very enemy who seeks to hear God's word and convey him to safety, and to deal justly and kindly with those who did not fight.	He is given no power to detect the inner enemy; the hypocrites around him are hidden from him and known to God alone, the servant who holds no power over outcomes shown holding none in war and loyalty.	His conduct bound and limited from above: to fight only those who fight him and never to transgress, and even the answering of slander in verse fenced to the wronged who defend themselves only after wrong.
Context	Fencing the open struggle with limit, mercy, and the law of the wronged.	The community subverted from within, the inner enemy exposed only from above and not by his sight.	Where a sovereign would rule by his own will, the servant rules by the law sent down to him, in the gravest matters of war.
Principal verses	al-Anfāl 8:61; al-Tawba 9:6; al-Mumtaḥana 60:8	al-Tawba 9:101; al-Munāfiqūn 63:1	al-Baqara 2:190; al-Shu'arā' 26:227
Snippet	"if they incline to peace, incline to it, and rely upon God" (8:61)	"you do not know them, We know them" (9:101)	"and defend themselves only after they were wronged" (26:227)
Key term (root)	salm (s-l-m: peace, submission)	nifāq (n-f-q: hypocrisy, dissembling)	intiṣār (n-ṣ-r: to defend, vindicate oneself)

22. Theme Twenty: The Vulnerable Prophet and the Refuge

The movement closes its trials where he is most exposed, in his own body and person. He is, the text insists throughout, a man like other men, and the reported account that he was once afflicted by sorcery, knots tied against him, belongs to the biographical literature and is contested within it. It is noted as the occasion the tradition assigns and is not asserted here as event. What the text itself establishes is the premise beneath it, that he was vulnerable as men are vulnerable, holding no charm against harm in himself, subject to the evil eye and the whisper and the malice of others as any servant is.

The Quran's answer to that vulnerability is not to make him invulnerable but to give him a refuge to recite. The two closing sūras, the mu'awwidhatān, are exactly this provision, placed in his mouth and every believer's, refuge in the Lord of daybreak "from the evil of what He created, and from the evil of darkness when it gathers, and from the evil of the blowers upon knots, and from the evil of an envier when he envies" (113:1-5), and refuge in the Lord of mankind "from the evil of the slinking whisperer, who whispers

in the breasts of mankind, of jinn and of men" (114:1-6). The protection is sought, not possessed. It is a word he is given to say, not a power he holds.

This is the servant-prophet at his plainest. He is not armored against the harms that reach other men. He is taught to take refuge in God against them, and the refuge is the recited word once more. The envier's malice that the People of the Book had shown him, the whisper that troubled every breast and that the prophets too were made firm against, and the ordinary evils of the dark, are met not by an invulnerability in his person but by a turning to God that any servant may make. The last provision of the trials is the same as the first. The protection, like the vindication and the law and the firmness, comes from God, and the man holds nothing of it in himself. The refuge is a word given to every believer no less than to him, and what that openness means for the one who comes after is drawn out in Section 24.

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The refuge given to recite, the two closing sūras placed in his mouth and every believer's, refuge in the Lord of daybreak and the Lord of mankind, a word he is given to say rather than a power he holds.	The servant-prophet at his plainest, a man like other men, holding no charm against harm in himself, exposed in body and person to the harms that reach all men.	Not made invulnerable but left subject to the created evils, the blowers upon knots, the envier when he envies, and the slinking whisperer who whispers in the breasts of mankind, met by a turning to God any servant may make.
Context	The protection sought, not possessed, the recited word once more, given to every believer no less than to him.	The premise beneath the contested account of sorcery, that he was vulnerable as men are vulnerable, with that account noted as the reported occasion and not asserted as event.	The first and last note of the trials made one: the protection, like the vindication and the law and the firmness, comes from God, and the man holds nothing of it in himself.
Principal verses	al-Falaq 113:1-3; al-Nās 114:1-3	al-Kahf 18:110	al-Falaq 113:4-5; al-Nās 114:4-6
Snippet	"I seek refuge in the Lord of daybreak" (113:1)	"Say, I am only a man like you, to whom it is revealed" (18:110)	"from the evil of an envier when he envies" (113:5)
Key term (root)	ʿawdh (ʿ-w-dh: to seek refuge, take shelter)	bashar (b-sh-r: a human being)	ḥasad (ḥ-s-d: envy, the envious eye); waswās (w-s-w-s: the whisper, insinuation)

23. Synthesis: The Coherence of the Portrait

The registers return the same finding from three sides. The nine of the portrait return it directly. The four of the contest return it in the negative, the charge that he originated the word answered by his own disclaimer, the demand for spectacle answered by the servant who holds no marvel in his hand, the rejection of the awaited one explained by the envy that sunders every community. And the seven of the trial return it under fire, the slander answered by revelation and not by his defense, the law given and not authored, the knowledge bounded and the firmness granted, the unseen reached by the Word and the confrontation handed to God, the hidden enemy exposed from above and the very refuge from harm a word he is told to say. The Quran raises the Prophet ﷺ to the limit of created standing and, at every turn, withholds from him the one thing that would make him an independent source rather than a maximal recipient. The motif is not a contest between exaltation and grounding that the text fails to resolve. It is a single theology of the servant-prophet, and two observations make its coherence plain.

The first observation concerns the grammar of his elevation, which is receptive throughout. His names are receptive. Muḥammad is the one praised, by another, from the root ḥ-m-d that also names the praising God. His office is receptive. He is rasūl, the one sent, by a sender. His highest title is receptive in the strongest sense. He is 'abd, servant, the word the Quran chooses at the summit of his ascent. Even the marks of favor are framed as the action of the Giver, not the possession of the favored. God protects him, God suffices him, God expands his breast and lifts his burden, all in the divine first person. The receptivity reaches its limit in the verses where his own act is named the act of God. At Badr, of the gesture that scattered the enemy, the text says "you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17). Of the pledge sworn to him, "the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10). These are at once the highest exaltation, his hand and his throw made the very vehicle of divine action, and the most complete grounding, for the act is credited not to him but to God. The same permeability runs in the other direction in the matter of the qibla. God saw his face turning to the sky in silent longing and turned the worship of the community to the direction he desired (2:144). Between the throw that is God's and the qibla that bends to his wish, the Prophet ﷺ stands as the place where the human will and the divine meet, the locus through which God acts and to whose longing God answers, never an independent power set beside Him.

The comparison with the earlier prophets confirms the same reading from another side. His distinction among them is not that a greater wonder was placed in his hand, for the staff, the healing breath, and the clay made to breathe are precisely the signs he is not given. His sign is the recited Word, and his scope and his office of confirming and sealing the line are what set him apart. Even this supremacy is receptive. He is the answer to Abraham's (AS) prayer and the one Jesus (AS) names, foretold by the line he completes. He confirms what was given to others rather than originating it, and the seal he sets, in the full sense of its root, certifies and consummates a prophecy whose author is God. To seal the prophets, on the Quran's own usage of the word, is to ratify and complete them, not to stand merely as their terminus.

The second observation concerns the corrective verses, and it is here that the portrait's deepest coherence lies. The reproaches and the commands to repent are not a weight that drags against his rank. They are the substance of it, and the Quran supplies its own paradigm for reading them. The text honors Adam above the angels not for an impeccability the angels themselves possess but for a different capacity altogether. The angels do not deviate, and for that very reason they neither fall nor rise by returning. Adam deviates, recognizes the deviation, and turns back, receiving words of return from his Lord. The refusing party deviates and justifies itself, claiming an inherent superiority, and does not return. The dignity that raises the human above the angel is thus the capacity to err, to recognize the error, and to turn. On this paradigm the Prophet's ﷺ corrigibility is not the floor beneath his station. It is the station's own mechanism. He is the one in whom this human capacity operates at its fullest, and the Quran marks the point unmistakably by issuing the command to seek forgiveness not in a moment of failure but at the summit of his victory, when the conquest is complete, "exalt your Lord with praise and seek His forgiveness" (110:3). The crown of his success is an act of turning.

Read together, the observations explain why the apparent tensions in the portrait are not tensions at all. The same root that grounds him as flesh, b-sh-r, furnishes the word for his commission as herald, bashīr. The human being who can err is the very one who is sent. The character commended as magnificent (68:4) is corrected in its particular acts (80:1; 33:37; 66:1), because the perfected human is governed and not self-governing. The favor that bends the qibla to his wish and the abundance that answers his loss single him out, yet originate wholly in the Giver. The betrayals he cannot detect and the reproaches within his household ground him as a man among men, under God's correction as under God's protection. The bearer of two of

the divine names, ra'ūf and raḥīm, is the same servant who is told he holds no power to benefit himself, because the names are bestowed and not owned. And the comparison with the earlier prophets resolves on the same principle. The favoring of one prophet above another is God's to assign, and the Prophet's ﷺ terminal and universal place is a place within the divine economy, not a rank he occupies apart from it.

This reading does not soften the reproaches to protect the Prophet's ﷺ dignity, and it has no need to. It locates the dignity in the very capacity the reproaches presuppose. A prophet who could not be addressed in correction would be, on the Quran's own Adamic logic, lower and not higher, nearer to the condition the refusing party claimed for itself than to the condition for which Adam was raised. The most exalted of messengers is held to the most exacting standard, warned that fabrication against God would cost him the aorta and that association would void his works, precisely because the standard rises with the station. The honor and the accountability are not opposed values held in uneasy balance. In the Quranic portrait they are forged from a single material, and the text says as much in its own grammar, when it makes the servant the one it praises, the throw of his hand the throwing of God, and the seeking of forgiveness the crown of his victory.

24. The Seal and the Open Path

The portrait, its contesting, the trials that proved it, and their synthesis settle the matter: a servant-prophet whose greatness is the greatness of reception, raised to the limit of created standing and withheld at every turn from being an independent source, accused of originating the word he only carried and cleared by the same text, and met in every crisis by a resolution he received and did not make. One question the themes imply but do not separately resolve remains, and it is the question the title of this study has carried throughout. What does the seal close, and what does it leave open. The word has already been read here at its root, the seal that closes and authenticates and completes, and read by the Quran's own usage rather than as a bare terminus. Read so, it falls in the text upon a defined thing. The single sealing term the Quran sets upon the Prophet ﷺ falls upon the prophets, khātam al-nabiyyīn (33:40). The text sets no sealing term upon the messengers, no seal of the mursalīn and no last of the rusul, and the confession that opens the faith names him rasūl Allāh without naming him the last of them. What the seal closes is the office of prophecy, the descent of a new revelation upon a newly commissioned man. Where the text does not pronounce, it does not pronounce. Its reticence about the office beyond that point is reticence, and not a second seal, and not a license. What the text is nowhere reticent about, and nowhere closes, is guidance.

The reaching of God's guidance to the living the Quran keeps wholly open. The community is charged to call to the good and to forbid the wrong (3:104). The one who was dead and was given a light walks by it among the people (6:122). The living are summoned to answer the One who calls them to what gives them life (8:24). These are offices of guidance, and the text names them without the word rasūl. The recited Word itself, sent down as a guidance for mankind (2:185), is carried and recited and borne from one generation to the next, and the one who bears it bears what is not his own. The Quran frames even its highest bearer in exactly this way. The Prophet ﷺ is told to say that he is only a man to whom it is revealed (18:110), that it is nothing but a revelation revealed (53:4), that upon him lies only the conveyance (5:99; 24:54). The bearer bears a message whose origin is God. The giving of a new revelation is what the seal addresses. The carrying of what has been given is what continues. The seal was set upon the source, never upon the stream.

Behind this openness stands something the Quran places before every prophet. It speaks of an original disposition upon which God shaped mankind, the *fiṭra* (30:30), and of a covenant taken before time, when He drew from the children of Adam the acknowledgment of their Lord, "Am I not your Lord? They said, Yes" (7:172). The pattern toward which the prophets call is thus prior to them. They are not its authors but its clearest bearers, and the text is explicit that they are set to be followed and not admired from a distance. In the Messenger ﷺ there is a beautiful example for whoever hopes in God and the Last Day (33:21), as there was a beautiful example in Abraham (AS) and those with him (60:4). An example stands at the head of a road. He does not lie across it as a wall. And because, as the synthesis has shown, the summit of this prophet is servanthood, the imitation the text invites is the imitation of a servant, a station withheld from no one. The seal closes the office of revelation. It does not close the road of resemblance, the labor of the servant to grow toward the pattern the prophets carried. To revere the Prophet ﷺ and to walk toward him are not two motions but one.

The road the prophets walked ran through trial, and the Quran does not conceal that they walked it as men. It says plainly that there was no messenger and no prophet before whom, when he recited, Satan did not cast something into his recitation, and that God then annuls what Satan casts and makes His verses firm (22:52). The suggestion was real. The purifying was God's. The servant who reads this is not taught that nearness is the absence of the whisper but that it is the whisper overcome, and that the strength to overcome is granted from above. The prophets are exemplary not because temptation never reached them but because they were carried through it, and the same help is the hope held out to the one who follows.

And the trials read in the third movement give that following its shape. In each of them the Prophet ﷺ met his crisis not by a power in himself but by a turning to God for what he could not supply. Slandered, he awaited the vindication and did not force it. Questioned past the edge of his knowledge, he confessed the limit. Tempted to bend the word, he was held firm from above. Harmed as other men are harmed, he was given a refuge to recite. To walk the road of the servant is to learn that turning, not a power to wield but a dependence to keep. And the path is shown open at its plainest in the last of those trials, for the refuge that was the Prophet's ﷺ own protection was placed in his mouth and in every believer's alike, the two closing sūras a word given to all who will say it. The same recitation that was his armor is the reader's, and there is no plainer proof that the road of the servant was left open than that its very protection is a verse anyone may recite.

Read in this way, the resistance the second movement diagnosed loses its ground. The envy that refused the prophet at every turn, the angel's pride and the clansman's and the heir's, and that sundered the one community into sects, wears two faces in the single heart. One denies the prophet outright. The other sets him so far beyond reach that to follow him is quietly excused, and an idol is raised where an example was meant to stand. Both are answered at once when the prophet is received as what he was sent to be, a servant whose nearness is, by God's design, a road and not a fence. Envy finds no footing against a door held open. It turns toward love, and the love refuses every tribal narrowing, for the text refuses it first. Of the messengers the believers say, "we make no distinction between any of them" (2:285). Of mankind God says that the most honored before Him is the most mindful of Him, and not the nearest by birth or banner (49:13). This is the healing of the sundering, the one community restored not by erasing its prophets but by walking toward the pattern they set, the same undivided line to which the People of the Book were called. The Prophet ﷺ is honored most not by walling his station but by walking toward it.

And the road is to be walked with understanding, not borne in the dark. The Quran reproaches those who were entrusted with the Book and then carried it without grasping it, likening them to a donkey that carries volumes (62:5), and it commands the contrary, asking whether they will not ponder the Quran (47:24) and naming itself a blessed Book sent down that its verses might be pondered (38:29). It names its own depth, "He is the First and the Last, the Outer and the Inner" (57:3), and the way inward is open to reverent reflection rather than reserved to a class. Belief received from others is a beginning. It was never meant to be the end of the road.

So the seal, read with the same care the rest of this study has used, gives not a smaller Prophet ﷺ but a nearer one. The office of revelation is closed and the line of the prophets sealed and ratified. The carriage of God's guidance continues under names that are not *rasūl*. The road of the servant stays open to whoever will walk it, the prophets foremost upon it and beckoning rather than barring. And what lies past the seen remains where the text leaves it, with God, who holds the keys of the unseen and discloses them to none but a messenger He has approved (6:59; 72:26-27). The hope this leaves the reader is the truest the portrait affords: not a distant figure to be guarded from a safe remove, but the first of the servants on a road that was never closed, and a calling, open to all, to walk it.

25. Conclusion

The Quran's portrait of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ holds exaltation and accountability together by design. He is named with the highest titles the text affords, the seal of the prophets and the mercy to the worlds, blessed by God and the angels and called by names that are God's own, and he is addressed, in the same scripture and often in the same passage, as a mortal who will die, who does not know the unseen, who holds no power over outcomes, who is reproved for particular acts within his own household, and who is commanded to seek forgiveness. Set beside the earlier prophets, he is given no staff and no clay made to breathe, but the recited Word, a universal scope, and the office of the seal that confirms and completes their line. Read across the registers of his portrait, the contest brought against it, and the trials that met him, from his naming to the refuge he was given to recite, the portrait does not fracture. It coheres around a single conception.

That conception has two faces, which are finally one. The Prophet ﷺ is the maximal locus of divine action and never its autonomous source. His greatness is the greatness of perfect reception and faithful conveyance, and it reaches its height where his very act is named the act of God, where his wish is answered by the turning of the qibla, and where the prophets before him point toward him as the seal that ratifies and completes their succession. And his accountability, far from competing with his rank, is the mechanism of it, on the model of the Adam whom the Quran honors above the angels for the capacity to recognize error and to turn back. The most-praised servant is the one whose every excellence points beyond himself to its Giver, and who, at the height of his triumph, turns to seek forgiveness. In the Quranic portraiture, the honor and the dependence are the same fact, named from every side the text commands. And because that greatness is a servant's greatness, the portrait closes not as a wall but as an invitation. The seal that ends the descent of revelation leaves open the road of the servant the prophets walked, sets them at its head as the example the believer is bidden to follow, and offers the reader not a figure to be admired from afar but the first upon a path that was never closed. And that the path was never closed the text seals at its plainest in the end, when the Prophet's ﷺ own refuge against the harms that reach all men was given to every believer alike as a word to recite.

Appendix A. Note on Transliteration and Conventions

Transliteration follows a light academic scheme. Long vowels are marked ā, ī, ū. The emphatic and other distinguished consonants are marked with a dot below: ḥ, ṣ, ṭ, ḏ, ḏ. The letter ‘ayn is represented by ‘ and the hamza by ’. Roots are given as their bare consonants separated by hyphens, for example ḥ-m-d, and are read directly from the Arabic. Where the sense of a term in a given verse is not plain, the same root is followed through its other occurrences in the text to recover the meaning, a procedure used most fully for kh-t-m in Section 10. Quranic citations give the sūra number followed by the verse number or range, as 33:40 or 80:1-10. Sūra names are given in transliteration at first mention within each table. The honorific ﷺ follows the name and titles of the Prophet Muhammad in keeping with established usage, and rests on the Quran's own statement that God and the angels invoke blessing upon him (33:56). English renderings of the verses are the author's own, prepared directly from the Arabic text and checked for phrasing against the standard translations listed in the References.

Appendix B. Glossary of Principal Roots

The roots below carry the principal terms used across this work, the books of the life and the study of the portrait that closes it. Each entry gives first the sense the word bears in current and Quranic usage, and then, where the skeleton preserves it, the raw image buried in the three consonants, the concrete and often bodily thing the root meant before it was lifted into abstraction. The method is excavation rather than loose etymology: the one consonantal skeleton is followed across its derived words to recover the single picture beneath them, read directly from the Arabic and without the later doctrinal smoothing. The order is the Arabic alphabet.

’-j-r: a wage, a reward; ajr, the recompense a messenger does not ask (26:109). Beneath it, to set and splint a broken bone (the ajr of a fracture); the wage is the mending that restores, payment as repair.

’-kh-w: brotherhood, a brother; mu’ākhāh, the pact of brotherhood by which each Helper of Medina took an emigrant into his house, and akh, brother. The skeleton is the sharing of one source, two who come of the same womb or the same bond; the brothering of Medina is a kinship made by covenant where blood gave none, the tie of the womb extended by the word.

’-dh-n: to permit, to give leave; idhn, the divine leave by which the prophets' signs are worked, "by God's leave" (3:49). The skeleton is the ear (udhun); to give leave is to incline the ear and let a thing through, permission as a hearing granted; and the adhān, the call to prayer, is the same root turned outward, the announcement proclaimed for every ear.

’-f-k: to lie, to slander; ifk, the great slander against the household (24:11). The raw sense is to turn a thing over and invert it; the mu’tafikāt are the overturned cities (53:53), and the lie is truth tipped upside down, the world stood on its head.

’-m-m: to head toward, to lead, a community; ummah, the single community made of emigrant and Helper, imām, the one who leads from the front, and umm, the mother. The skeleton is the point one faces and makes for (amma, to repair to); a community is a body turned to one aim, the leader the one at its head, the mother the source it issues from.

’-m-n: to be safe, to trust, to believe; amān, the safe-conduct granted to an enemy, Amīn, the trustworthy, the Prophet's ﷺ name among his people before the call, and īmān, faith. The skeleton is security itself, the

settling of fear (amina, to be safe); to believe is to entrust oneself, to find in God the safety the heart stops fearing for, and the trustworthy is the one in whose keeping a thing is safe.

'w-l: priority, the first, the greater claim; awlā, "the Prophet ﷺ is closer to the believers than themselves" (33:6). The root is return, the coming back to an origin (awl); what is first is what one returns to, and the greater claim is the claim of the source.

'y-y: a sign, a mark, a token; āya, at once a miracle and a verse of scripture (2:118). The skeleton is the bare mark left for recognition, the trace by which a thing is known; wonder and verse are named alike as marks set for the eye that reads.

b-d-': to originate without precedent; bid', "I am no new thing among the messengers" (46:9), and al-Badī', the Originator. The raw image is the first sinking of a well never dug before, to bring forth where nothing of the kind has stood; origination is the breaking of new ground.

b-d-l: to change, to exchange; baddala, the altering of the word entrusted (2:59). The skeleton is substitution, one thing set in the place of another, the swap that leaves the slot filled but the content replaced.

b-r-': to be clear of, to absolve, to create by separating; bara'a, "they are absolved of what they say" (24:26), and al-Bārī', the Maker. The raw image is recovery from sickness (bur') and the cutting-free of one thing from another; to absolve is to be made clean of a thing, and to create is to part the made from the unmade.

b-sh-r: skin, flesh, the human, and to bring good news; bashar, the human being (18:110), and bashīr, the herald of glad tidings. The buried picture is the outer skin itself (basharah); good news is named from the face, the skin that brightens and shows the tidings before the mouth speaks.

b-gh-y: to seek wrongfully, to overstep, insolent envy; baghy, read in this study as the single root of rejection and schism (2:213; 42:14). Beneath it lies the wound that swells and festers past its bound (baghā l-jurh) and the one who sells the body (baghiyy); envy here is a swelling that breaks its own skin, a seeking that will not keep its bound.

b-l-gh: to reach, to convey, to attain; balāgh, "upon the messenger lies only the conveyance" (5:99). The skeleton is arrival at a destination and the coming of age (bulūgh); the bearer's whole task is to carry the thing the full distance and set it down intact.

b-h-l: to invoke earnestly, to imprecate; ibtihāl, the mutual cursing proposed at Najran (3:61). The raw sense is to leave unrestrained, the she-camel turned loose with her udder unbound (bahl); to imprecate is to loose the matter wholly to God, tether cut, and let His judgment fall.

b-y-n: to be clear, to make plain, to separate; bayyina, the clear proof (2:118), and mubīn, the manifest. The skeleton is the gap between two things (bayn), the distance that lets each be seen apart; to make plain is to open that space so the eye can tell one from another.

t-b-': to follow; ittaba'a, "I follow only what is revealed to me" (46:9). The raw sense is to walk in another's tracks, to come behind in the same prints; to follow the revelation is to set one's feet where it has stepped.

t-l-w: to recite, and to follow; tilāwa, the recitation of the signs (2:252). The skeleton is one thing close on the heel of another; reciting is following the text word after word, each syllable trailing the last, so that to recite and to follow are one motion.

t-w-b: to turn back, to return; tawba, the repentance the Prophet ﷺ is commanded toward (110:3), and al-Tawwāb, the ever-relenting. The raw image is the bodily turn, the swing of the whole frame back toward what it left; repentance is a reversal of the feet, and God's relenting is His turning back toward the one who turns.

th-b-t: to be fixed, to stand firm; tathbīt, "had We not made you firm, you would have nearly inclined" (17:74). The skeleton is the rooted and the planted, a stake driven and held; firmness is not the absence of the pull but the root that does not give when pulled.

j-d-l: to dispute, to argue; jidāl, and al-Mujādila, the sūra of the woman who argued (58:1). The raw sense is the tight twisting of a rope (jadīl), strand wound hard against strand; argument is a wrestling of twisted cords, each pulling the braid its own way.

j-n-n: the hidden, the covered; jinn, the concealed beings (72:1). The root is concealment itself. The same three letters give janna, to veil in darkness; jannah, the garden whose leaves hide its floor; janīn, the embryo curtained in the womb; and majnūn, the reason screened from itself. One picture under them all: what is covered from sight.

j-h-r: to be open, loud, manifest; jahra, "show us God openly" (2:55). The skeleton is the plain and the exposed, the thing said aloud and seen in full light; to demand God jahratan is to demand Him brought out into the open eye.

ḥ-d-th: to be new, to occur, to narrate; hadith, the report of what the Prophet ﷺ said and did, the second source woven through this life. The skeleton is the coming-to-be of what was not (ḥadatha, to happen newly); a narration is the bringing of an event into speech, news of a thing that occurred, the new told against the foregoing.

ḥ-r-m: to forbid, the sacred, the inviolable; ḥaram, the sanctuary at Mecca, iḥrām, the pilgrim's consecrated state, and ḥarām, the forbidden. The skeleton is the set-apart that may not be touched (ḥaruma, to be inviolable); the sacred and the forbidden are one image, a boundary drawn around a thing that hands must not cross, the precinct and the prohibition named alike.

ḥ-s-d: to envy; ḥasad, the envier's evil sought refuge from (113:5). The raw sense is a gnawing, an itch or mange that eats inward; envy in the skeleton is a thing that consumes the one who holds it from within.

ḥ-k-m: to judge, to govern, to be wise; ḥukm, the judgment that is God's in the Torah (5:43), and ḥakīm, the wise. The raw image is the bridle (ḥakama) that curbs the horse; to judge is to rein in, and wisdom is the restraint that holds chaos to a course.

ḥ-m-d: to praise, to commend; Muḥammad, the much-praised, and Aḥmad, and al-Ḥamīd. The skeleton is praise rendered as due, not flattery but the acknowledgment owed; the Prophet's ﷺ name is its passive form, the one praise comes to, never its source.

ḥ-n-f: to incline away, the upright primordial faith; ḥanīf, the seeker of the pure original religion of Abraham (AS), turned from the idols toward the one God (3:67). The skeleton is the deliberate leaning, a foot turned off the broad road; the ḥanīf has inclined away from the worship of the many to the worship of the One, upright by a turning.

ḥ-w-r: whiteness, to return, a disciple; ḥawāriyyūn, the disciples of Jesus (AS), the devoted white-garbed helpers (3:52). The skeleton is a bright whiteness and the turning back of a thing (ḥāra, to return); the disciple

is named for a purity that is also a constancy, one who whitens and returns, the close helper at the prophet's side.

kh-t-m: to seal, to stamp, to finish; khātam, set upon the Prophet ﷺ in 33:40. The Quran's own uses fix the range: a seal pressed on hearts and hearing that fixes a state (2:7), the sealing of mouths in final testimony (36:65), and the sealed wine "whose seal is musk," the certifying finish (83:25-26). The raw image is the signet pressed into clay or wax, the ring that at once closes a thing and stamps it as genuine; the seal ends, authenticates, and completes in one act.

kh-d-d: the cheek, a furrow, a trench; ukhdūd, the dug pit in which the People of the Ditch were burned for their faith (85:4). The skeleton is the long groove cut in a surface, the furrow of a cheek and the trench in the ground; the image is precise, a fire fed in a cleft dug for the killing.

kh-ṣ-m: to contend at law, an adversary; khaṣīm, "he is a manifest adversary" (16:4). The skeleton is the litigant, the one who stands against you in dispute; the same word names the disputant and the dispute, the contention and the one who carries it.

kh-l-q: to create, and disposition, nature; khuluq, the "magnificent character" of 68:4, and ikhtilāq, the fabrication charged against the revelation (38:7). The buried image is the measuring and cutting of leather to a proportion (khalaqa l-adīm); to create is to fashion by exact measure, and to fabricate a lie is the same craft turned to a false cut.

d-ʿ-w: to call, to summon, to claim; daʿiyy, the adopted son, the one called to a father not his own (33:5), and the offices of guidance that "call to the good." The raw sense is the raised voice that summons; the adopted son is a sonship by calling-out rather than by blood, a name conferred by the voice.

dh-k-r: to remember, to mention; dhikr, the reminder the bearers carry. The skeleton holds also the male (dhakar) and the sharp point; remembrance is the keen edge of the mind that pierces back to what was, and mention the bringing of it again to the tongue.

dh-n-b: an offense, a fault; dhanb, the fault the Prophet ﷺ is told to seek covering for (40:55). The raw image is the tail (dhanab), the part that trails behind; a fault is what drags after the deed, the consequence following at the heel like a tail.

r-ʿ-f: tender kindness, pity; raʿūf, a divine name applied to the Prophet (9:128) ﷺ. The skeleton is the softest pity, the tenderness that flinches at another's pain; it is the gentlest grade of mercy, compassion at its most yielding.

r-j-l: a man, the adult male; rajul, "two men of those who feared God" (5:23). The raw image is the foot and the leg (rijl); the man is named the one who stands and goes on his own legs, manhood as the upright gait.

r-ḥ-m: the womb, mercy; raḥma and raḥīm, and al-Raḥmān and al-Raḥīm. The buried picture is the womb (raḥim) itself; mercy in the skeleton is womb-feeling, the sheltering and feeding of the utterly dependent, named from the organ that holds and nourishes the unformed.

r-s-l: to send, to dispatch, to let flow; rasūl, the sent one. The skeleton is the loosing of a thing to go, a herd sent to water or hair let down loose (irsāl); the messenger is one released toward a destination by a sender, the sending never his own.

r-sh-d: right direction, sound judgment; rushd, the "right conduct" the jinn heard the recitation guide to (72:2). The raw image is holding to the true road and the maturity that can hold it (rushd, the coming of age); guidance here is the path kept and the judgment grown firm enough to keep it.

r-d-w: to be content, to approve; irtadā, the messenger God "has approved" to whom alone the unseen is disclosed (72:27). The skeleton is satisfaction, the settling of the self in consent; approval is the will at rest in a thing, wanting it as it is.

r-f-d: to support, to provision; rifāda, the hereditary office of feeding the pilgrims at Mecca, a charge of the Prophet's ﷺ clan. The skeleton is the propping of a thing and the giving of aid (rafada, to support); the provisioning of pilgrims is a holding-up of the weary traveler, sustenance offered as a prop under one who would otherwise fall.

r-f-q: gentleness, ease, a companion; rafīq, the companion, and the rafīq al-a'lā, the highest company of the prophets the Prophet ﷺ chose at his death. The skeleton is the easy and the kind, the elbow (rifq) one leans on; a companion is one whose nearness is a gentleness, the soft handling that makes a hard road bearable.

r-m-y: to throw, to cast; ramā, "you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17). The raw sense is the bodily hurl, the arm's release of a stone or shaft; the verse takes the most physical of acts and names its force as God's.

r-w-ḥ: spirit, breath, wind; rūḥ, named of Jesus (AS), "a Spirit from Him" (4:171), of the Holy Spirit, and of the revelation, "a Spirit of Our command" (42:52). The skeleton is moving air, breath and wind and the cool of relief (rāḥa); spirit in the root is the unseen breath that animates, known only by its motion.

z-k-w: to grow, to be pure, almsgiving; zakāt, the purifying due paid from wealth, and tazkiyah, the cleansing of the soul. The skeleton joins growth and purity on one frame (zakā, to thrive and to be clean); the alms is named for both, a giving that purifies what remains and a pruning that makes the wealth and the giver grow.

z-w-j: a pair, a spouse, a yoke; zawj, the wife kept or released in the trial of the household (33:37). The raw image is the yoking of two, a pair coupled to pull together; a spouse is one of a matched two, joined to a single draught.

z-y-d: to increase, to add; ziyādah, an addition, the increase God gives beyond the measure earned. The skeleton is the surplus laid onto a thing, the growth past the original sum; the root names the more that is added, the increment that exceeds, the giving that goes beyond the due.

s-ḥ-r: sorcery, enchantment; siḥr, the label "a manifest sorcerer" (10:2) and the bewitchment marked as the contested occasion of the refuge sūras. The raw sense is to turn a thing from its true nature to a false seeming, kin to saḥar, the turning-edge of night into dawn; magic in the skeleton is a diverting, the real bent into a counterfeit of itself.

s-r-y: to travel by night; Isrā', the night journey of the Prophet ﷺ from Mecca to Jerusalem (17:1). The skeleton is the journeying done in darkness, movement under cover of night while the world sleeps; the night journey is named for its hour, a passage made in the dark and known only after.

s-ṭ-r: to rule lines, to write in rows, to dominate; muṣayṭir, "you are not over them a controller" (88:22). The raw image is the drawn line and the written row (saṭr); to dominate is to rule lines over another, to set them within margins one has drawn.

s-q-y: to give to drink, to water; siqāya, the hereditary office of providing water to the pilgrims at Mecca. The skeleton is the giving of water to the thirsty, the irrigation of a dry field; the office is named for the most basic mercy in a waterless land, the cup held out to the parched.

s-l-m: peace, safety, surrender; salm, the peace to be inclined to "if they incline to it" (8:61), and islām and salām. The buried image is wholeness and soundness (salima, to be unhurt, entire); peace is the body intact, and to surrender is to hand oneself over whole into safekeeping.

s-y-r: to journey, to go, conduct; sīra, the path of a life and so the record of the Prophet's ﷺ life, and sayr, travel. The skeleton is the going of a traveler along a road (sāra, to move along); a life's sīra is its course and its conduct, the way a man walked through his days, the journey that, once told, becomes the life-story.

sh-r-ḥ: to open, to expand, to lay open; sharaḥa, "did We not expand for you your breast" (94:1). The raw sense is to slit and splay wide, to lay a thing open as one opens meat to the bone; the expansion of the breast is a cutting-wide of the inner space to receive.

sh-ʿ-b: a mountain pass, a people, a branch; shiʿb, the valley quarter of Abū Ṭālib in which the clan was penned during the boycott, and shaʿb, a people. The skeleton holds both gathering and dividing on one frame, the pass that draws a road into one narrow throat and the branching of a people into clans; the shiʿb of the boycott is the narrow place the clan was driven into and hemmed.

sh-ʿ-r: to perceive finely, hair, poetry; shāʿir, the "poet" the Prophet ﷺ was called (21:5). The skeleton is the hair (shaʿr) and the fine sensing it stands for (shaʿara, to feel acutely); the poet is named the one of hair-fine perception, and the charge of poetry sets mere fine feeling against revealed knowledge.

sh-f-ʿ: to pair, to make even, to intercede; shafāʿa, the intercession that holds only "by His leave" (2:255). The raw image is the even number (shafʿ) against the odd, the adding of a second to a one; to intercede is to come alongside as a second, pairing one's plea to another's need.

sh-y-ʾ: to will, to want; mashīʾa, the will of God excepted into every plan, "except that God wills" (18:24). The skeleton is bare volition, the wanting that brings a thing toward being; the correction of the Prophet's ﷺ promise binds his every "I will" beneath this larger willing.

sh-y-ʿ: to spread, to follow in a party; shiyaʿ, the "sects" into which the one religion was cut (6:65). The raw image is diffusion and accompaniment, a thing spread abroad and a band that walks together; a sect is a following spread off on its own line, splinter and company at once.

ṣ-d-q: to be true, to confirm; muṣaddiq, the Quran "confirming what was before it" (3:3). The skeleton joins truth and hardness; the true is the solid that bears weight, and to confirm is to stand under what came before and hold it up; and the ṣiddīq, the wholly truthful, the title borne by Abū Bakr, is the one in whom truth has set hard.

ḍ-r-r: to harm, injury; ḍirār, the mosque raised to do harm and split the believers (9:107), and ḍarar, hurt. The skeleton is the bare infliction of damage, a thing pressed against another to its hurt; the root names both the harm done and the intent to do it, the wound and the will behind it.

ḍ-ʿ-f: weakness, and the doubling of a thing; ḍāʿif, the weak, the believers without clan to shield them. The skeleton holds two senses on one frame, frailty (ḍaʿufa, to be weak) and multiplication (ḍif, a double); the weak is the one easily bent, and the reward promised the patient is the same root turned to increase, the deed doubled.

ḍ-y-q: to be narrow, constricted; ḍāqa, the breast that "tightens" under denial (11:12). The raw image is the strait and the pinched, space closing in until it grips; distress in the skeleton is room running out, the chest narrowed to a clench.

ṭ-ʿ-m: to taste, to eat, food; ṭāʾm, the objection that the messenger "eats food and walks the markets" (25:7). The skeleton is the bare act of tasting and the food tasted; the adversaries press it as proof of mere creatureliness, the mouth that must be fed.

ẓ-h-r: the back, to appear, midday; ẓihār, the old repudiation that likened the wife to "the back of the mother" (58:2). The raw image is the back (ẓahr), the surface turned and shown and the strength that bears a load; the same root gives the manifest (ẓāhir) and the noon (ẓuhr), the outer face fully lit.

ʿ-b-d: to serve, to worship; ʿabd, the servant, the title chosen for the Prophet ﷺ at the summit of the ascent (17:1). The raw image is the smoothed and trodden path (ṭarīq muʿabbad), ground made firm by being walked; the servant is one shaped to a road, level under the foot of his Lord.

ʿ-b-s: to frown, to scowl; ʿabasa, "he frowned and turned away" (80:1). The skeleton is the knit brow itself, the face drawn tight in displeasure; the sūra opens on the bare physical act, the muscles of the face indicted before the deed is named.

ʿ-r-j: to ascend, to mount, to limp; Miʾrāj, the ascension of the Prophet ﷺ through the heavens, and maʿārij, the ways of ascent (70:3). The skeleton is the going-up by stages and the unevenness of a limping gait (ʿaraja, to climb and to limp); the ascent is a mounting through ranks, a rising by steps from the earth toward the throne.

ʿ-ṣ-m: to grasp, to hold fast, to protect; the verb in "God will protect you from the people" (5:67). The buried picture is the handhold seized and the rope clung to (iʿṭasama bi-, to grip fast); protection in the skeleton is not a wall but a grip, the firm hold that keeps one from falling.

ʿ-k-f: to cleave to, to devote, to seclude; iʿtikāf, the withdrawal into the mosque in seclusion to seek the Night of Power, the Prophet's ﷺ retreat in the last ten days of the fast. The skeleton is the staying-fixed beside a thing, a constant bending over it (ʿakafa, to keep to); the retreat is a fastening of the self to one place and one purpose, the world shut out and the devotion held.

ʿ-m-r: to live long, to inhabit, to build; ʿumr, the lifespan by which God swears and against which a life is weighed. The raw image is the filling of a place with life (ʿimāra, to cultivate and people a land); a lifespan is a span inhabited, the years filled as one fills a house.

ʿ-w-dh: to seek refuge, to take shelter; istiʿādha, and the muʿawwidhatān, the two sūras of refuge (113-114). The raw sense is to cling to a thing for safety, to fasten oneself to a protector; to seek refuge is to grip God as a frightened creature grips what shelters it.

gh-z-w: to raid, to strive toward, a campaign; maghāzī, the military expeditions of the Prophet ﷺ, the part of the sira that records them. The skeleton is the setting-out against a thing with intent (ghazā, to raid); a campaign is a purposed going-forth, the march toward an aim that must be met in the field.

gh-f-r: to cover, to forgive; istighfār, the seeking of forgiveness commanded at the summit (110:3), and al-Ghafūr. The raw image is the covering-over, kin to the mighfar, the helmet that covers the head; forgiveness in the skeleton is a covering laid over the fault, hidden from sight rather than unmade.

gh-y-b: the hidden, the absent; ghayb, the unseen whose keys are God's alone (6:59). The skeleton is absence from sight, what has sunk below the horizon (ghābat al-shams, the sun set); the unseen is the withdrawn, present but past the edge of the eye.

f-t-ḥ: to open, to seek victory; istiftāḥ, the People of the Book who "had prayed for victory" by him (2:89), and al-Fattāḥ. The raw image is the opening of a closed door and the taking of a closed city; victory in the skeleton is an opening, the shut thing forced wide.

f-t-n: trial, temptation; fitna, the danger the firmness guarded against (17:73). The buried picture is the smelting of gold in fire to part it from its dross (fatana l-dhahab); a trial is an assaying by burning, the heat that proves what a thing is made of.

f-r-q: to split, to part, to distinguish; furqa, the "division" of the one community (42:14), and al-Furqān, the criterion. The raw image is the cleaving of a thing in two, the parting of the sea and the parting-line of the hair (farq); to distinguish is to cut between, and schism is the cut turned upon the body it should have served.

f-r-y: to fabricate, to invent falsely; iftirāʾ, the charge of forging a lie against God (69:44). The raw sense is the cutting of leather to shape (farā l-adīm); fabrication is a real craft of cutting and joining, but a thing cut to a false pattern and passed as given.

f-ḍ-l: to exceed, to favor, to grant surplus; faḍḍala, "We favored some of the prophets above others" (2:253). The skeleton is the overplus, the remainder above the measure (faḍl, what exceeds need); favor is a surplus poured beyond the due, more given than was owed.

f-ṭ-r: to split open, to originate, the primordial nature; fiṭra, the disposition upon which God shaped mankind, the innate turning toward Him (30:30), and Fāṭir, the Originator. The skeleton is the first splitting, the cleft from which a thing issues (faṭara, to cleave); creation is a breaking-open, and the fiṭra is the original cut, the native shape pressed into a thing at its making.

q-b-l: to face, to turn toward, to accept; qibla, the direction of prayer turned for him (2:144). The raw image is the front and the facing (qubul); to accept is to turn the face toward, and the qibla is the chosen face the whole body fronts in prayer.

q-r-b: to be near; qurbā, kinship (42:23), qurbān, the offering brought near (5:27), and qāba, the measure of nearness in the vision (53:9). The skeleton is approach, the closing of distance; kinship is nearness of blood, an offering a nearness sought by gift, and the vision's "two bows' length" the nearest a creature is brought.

q-ṭ-ʿ: to cut, to sever; taqaṭṭuʿ, the religion "cut into pieces" among them (21:93). The raw sense is the clean severing, a thing chopped through; the schism is named the dismemberment of one body, cut into parts that no longer hold.

q-w-m: to stand, to rise; maqām, the "praised station" of the Prophet (17:79) ﷺ. The raw image is the upright posture, the rising to one's feet; a station is a standing-place, a rank named for where one stands and how high.

q-y-l: the midday rest; qaylūlah, the noonday sleep of the Arabs in the heat, the hour the Prophet ﷺ kept. The skeleton is the stilling of the day at its height, the pause when the sun stands and motion stops; the root names the rest taken in the white heat of noon, the body laid down while the light blazes.

k-th-r: to be much, to abound; kawthar, the "abundance" granted against the taunt of being cut off (108:1). The skeleton is sheer multitude, number past counting; the gift is named the overflowing, set exactly against the enemy's charge of barrenness.

k-f-l: to take charge of, a portion, a double share; kifl, "a portion" of the burden or the reward (4:85). The raw image is the part folded back on itself, a double fold (kifl); a portion is a fold of the whole assigned to one, charge and share at once.

k-l-m: to speak, a word, a wound; kalima, the Word predicated of Jesus (AS) (4:171), and kalām, the speech of God. The buried picture is the wound (kalm) that breaks a surface; a word in the skeleton is a thing that cuts and marks, speech that leaves an incision on the air and the ear.

m-w-t: death, stillness; mawt, "you will die and they will die" (39:30). The skeleton is the going-still, the cessation of motion and breath; death in the root is the stop, the frame fallen quiet, and the Prophet ﷺ is held under it with all that breathe.

n-b-ʾ: to announce, to bring weighty news; nabī, the prophet, and by the alternate root n-b-w, to be raised high. The raw image is the report of consequence carried from afar (nabaʾ, grave tidings); the prophet is the bearer of the weighty announcement, or the one raised up to bear it.

n-dh-r: to warn, to vow; nadhīr, the warner (35:24). The skeleton is the cry of alarm raised before a coming harm and the binding of a vow; to warn is to give notice of what advances, the voice thrown ahead of the danger.

n-ṣ-r: to help against an enemy, to defend, to give victory; intiṣār, the believing poets who "defend themselves after they were wronged" (26:227), naṣr, and Anṣār, the Helpers of Medina who took the emigrants into their homes. The raw image holds also the rain that revives a dead land; help in the skeleton is a rescue sent down, aid that comes to the hard-pressed from beyond their own strength.

n-f-q: to dissemble, to spend, a tunnel; munāfiq, the hypocrite hidden from the Prophet's ﷺ sight (9:101), and nifāq. The buried image is the jerboa's burrow with a second hidden mouth (nāfiqāʾ), the escape-hole kept covered until it bolts; the hypocrite is the creature that shows one entrance and keeps another to flee through.

n-w-r: light; nūr, the light by which God guides, named of the revelation and of God Himself, light upon light. The skeleton is the bare radiance that makes seeing possible, the fire's gleam and the day's brightness; light in the root is what dispels the dark and shows the road, the first condition of sight, and the book that guides is named by it.

h-j-r: to abandon, to migrate, to shun; hijra, the migration from Mecca to Medina that opens the calendar, and muhājirūn, the emigrants. The skeleton is the cutting of a tie and the leaving of a place (hajara, to forsake); the migration is a severance before it is a journey, the abandonment of home and clan for the sake of the bond that replaces them.

h-d-y: to guide, to lead the way; hadā and hudā, the guidance the Quran keeps wholly open (2:185). The raw image is leading along a road and the gift offered with the right hand (hadiyya); guidance is a leading-forward and a thing given, the way shown and the hand held out on it.

w-ʾ-d: to bury alive; waʾd, the burying alive of infant daughters in the age before the call, waʾd al-banāt, which the recitation drags into the light to condemn (81:8). The skeleton is the pressing-down of a living thing

under earth, a weight laid on the buried; the root names the specific killing, the daughter set in the ground while she still breathes.

w-t-n: the aorta, the life-vein; watīn, the great vessel the false prophet would have severed from him (69:46). The skeleton is the single cord on which life hangs, the artery whose cutting empties the body; the image makes the threatened end exact and bodily.

w-d-d: to love, to feel affection; mawadda, the "affection of kinship" asked as the only wage (42:23), and al-Wadūd. The skeleton is settled tender love, the wishing-well that holds steady; it is affection as a fixed disposition, not the flare but the constant warmth.

w-z-n: to weigh, the balance; mīzān, the Scale on which the deeds are weighed at the crossing (21:47), and wazn, weight. The skeleton is the act of weighing, the pair of pans hung to find the truth of a mass; the Balance is the deed brought to its exact measure, the weight of a life read off against the standard, nothing added and nothing lost.

w-s-w-s: to whisper, to insinuate; waswās, the "slinking whisperer" sought refuge from (114:4). The word is its own sound, a low hidden hiss repeated, the rustle of a garment or the chink of ornaments; temptation in the skeleton is named by its noise, the faint susurrus at the edge of hearing.

w-q-y: to guard, to shield; taqwā, the God-wariness that shields the self by keeping it true, the being God-conscious. The skeleton is the placing of a guard between a thing and what would harm it (waqā, to protect); taqwā is the wariness that sets a shield before the soul, the watchfulness that keeps one from the edge.

y-d: the hand; yad, "the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10). The skeleton is the hand itself and, from it, power and a favor done (a yad, a benefaction given by hand); the hand in the root is agency made visible, the grip by which a thing is held and a gift is passed.

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The Primary Documentary Sources

The reconstruction rests on the primary Arabic corpus named below, set down here as the documentary foundation of the work. The Qur'an is the first anchor; the nine canonical hadith collections and the early Sira and Maghāzī literature are the transmitted record from which the connected life is drawn.

The Qur'an. The 'Uthmānic codex, al-muṣḥaf al-'Uthmānī, in the canonical reading of Ḥafṣ 'an 'Āṣim.

The Hadith, the nine books, al-Kutub al-Tis'a.

- Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, of Muḥammad ibn Ismā'il al-Bukhārī (d. 256 AH / 870 CE)
- Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, of Muslim ibn al-Ḥajjāj al-Naysābūrī (d. 261 / 875)
- Sunan Abī Dāwūd, of Abū Dāwūd al-Sijistānī (d. 275 / 889)
- Jāmi' al-Tirmidhī, with Al-Shamā'il al-Muḥammadiyya, of Muḥammad ibn 'Īsā al-Tirmidhī (d. 279 / 892)
- Sunan al-Nasā'ī, of Aḥmad ibn Shu'ayb al-Nasā'ī (d. 303 / 915)
- Sunan Ibn Mājah, of Muḥammad ibn Yazīd ibn Mājah (d. 273 / 887)
- Musnad Aḥmad, of Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal (d. 241 / 855)
- Muwaṭṭa' Mālik, of Mālik ibn Anas (d. 179 / 795)
- Sunan al-Dārimī, of 'Abd Allāh ibn 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Dārimī (d. 255 / 869)

The Sira and Maghāzī, the early biographical and campaign literature.

- Sīrat Rasūl Allāh, of Ibn Ishāq (d. 150 / 767), in the recension of Ibn Hishām (d. 218 / 833)
- Kitāb al-Maghāzī, of al-Wāqidī (d. 207 / 823)
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- Tārīkh al-Rusul wa'l-Mulūk, of al-Ṭabarī (d. 310 / 923)
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The external witnesses that stand outside this corpus, the Ḥimyarite and Aksumite inscriptions, the texts of Abraha at Marib and Murayghan, and the Syriac, Greek, and Persian records of the surrounding empires, are named in their places in the narrative above.

The Translations Consulted

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